

# **SURVIVING FLORIDA**

**AN RRF ORIGINAL UNIVERSE**

**WRITTEN BY RRF**

# **SURVIVING FLORIDA**

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# CONTENTS

- 01 The Back Court
- 02 Inside The Sunshine
- 03 Blue Lights
- 04 Evidence
- 05 Nobody Talks
- 06 Family Debt
- 07 Bossed Up
- 08 Ten Cars
- 09 La Madrina
- 10 Everybody Eats
- 11 The Long Reach
- 12 D-Low's Son
- 13 Two Crowns
- 14 The Garage
- 15 Candy Paint & Gun Smoke
- 16 State of War
- 17 No Business, No Peace
- 18 The Palm Haven Heist
- 19 Find Reem
- 20 Blood Before Empire
- 21 The Man Who Bought the War

# THE BACK COURT

Florida heat did not care what time it was.

At six-thirty in the evening, the sun still hung over Sunridge Gardens like a bright orange warning. Heat shimmered above the cracked pavement. Window units rattled from the apartment buildings. Somewhere near Sunridge Plaza, bass from a passing car shook loose glass in an abandoned bus shelter.

Behind Building 17, Kareem Dawson stood at the center of the Back Court with the basketball tucked beneath one arm and the whole neighborhood watching him argue.

Nobody called him Kareem out there.

On the court, he was Reck.

His red designer shirt burned against the faded orange concrete. Gold chains rested over his chest, catching sunlight every time he moved. A thin scar split his right eyebrow. His twisted fade was fresh, his black jeans were stacked perfectly over spotless red-and-white sneakers, and his voice carried from one side of the apartments to the other.

“Ain’t no next point,” he said. “That was game.”

The older boy across from him laughed. His name was Curtis, but everybody called him C-Mack. He was nineteen, nearly six feet tall, and surrounded by three friends who spent most afternoons leaning against the fence as if the Back Court belonged to them.

“Ball hit the fence,” C-Mack said. “Out of bounds.”

“After it went through the rim.”

“Still out.”

Reck bounced the ball once. “You losing got you rewriting basketball now?”

Laughter rolled across the bleachers.

That was the part C-Mack could not forgive.

Reck never disagreed quietly. He turned every argument into a performance and every audience into his audience.

Jamari Collins jumped down from the lowest bleacher. Mari was shorter than everyone else, but the white tank top stretched across his muscular shoulders made him look built for collisions. Sweat darkened the orange jersey hanging open over his chest. When he smiled, dimples appeared beside a gold bottom grill.

“He changing rules like he the commissioner,” Mari said. “Next he gon’ tell us the hoop too high.”

More laughter.

“Mari,” Isaiah Brooks warned.

Zay stood near the free-throw line, taller than everybody on the court. His royal-blue basketball shorts reached his knees, and long two-strand twists brushed his shoulders. He had the serious face of somebody who was always calculating how much trouble his friends could create in the next thirty seconds.

Usually, the answer was too much.

Terrence Jackson held a phone from the bleachers, recording everything. TJ’s full curly Afro moved in the hot breeze while his purple graphic shirt hung loosely from his narrow shoulders.

“I got the whole game,” TJ announced. “Reck scored. Clear as day.”

C-Mack pointed at him. “Put that phone down, little boy.”

TJ’s smile disappeared.

Reck stepped forward before TJ could respond.

“Talk to me,” he said. “Not him.”

Nasir Grant remained beside the fence. Naz wore a charcoal hoodie despite the heat, sleeves pushed to his elbows. Neat cornrows ran toward the back of his neck, and dark-framed glasses rested over deep-set eyes. He had been silent throughout the argument, studying C-Mack's friends and the people gathering on the apartment walkways.

Then he noticed the black Chevrolet idling near the entrance to the court.

"Reck," Naz said.

It was only one word, but Reck heard the warning inside it.

He glanced toward the car.

Ramon Ellis sat behind the wheel.

Mon was King K's most feared man, and he did not visit the Back Court to watch basketball. He was tall even while seated, with reddish-brown skin and a scar running along his chin. His black shirt matched the dark interior of the car. One hand rested on the steering wheel while his eyes remained fixed on Reck.

The laughter faded.

C-Mack saw Mon too. Confidence returned to his face.

"You do a lot of talking when your daddy can't teach you better," he said.

The court went still.

Reck's fingers tightened around the basketball.

Everybody in Sunridge knew about Kareem Dawson Sr. Reem had once carried weight throughout The Ridge. Now he existed in old stories, prison photographs and collect calls Shanice Dawson sometimes refused to answer.

Zay moved closer. "Leave it alone, Reck."

Mari's grin disappeared.

TJ lowered the phone.

Naz pushed himself away from the fence.

Reck looked at C-Mack, then toward the apartment windows. Mothers stood behind blinds. Children leaned over the upstairs railings. Men outside the corner store had turned their heads toward the court.

Walking away would have been smart.

Reck hated looking smart when it felt anything like looking scared.

He tossed the basketball behind him.

“My father ain’t got nothing to do with you losing,” he said.

C-Mack stepped close enough for their shoes to nearly touch. “Your father lost too.”

Reck shoved him.

C-Mack stumbled backward, caught himself and charged.

The Back Court erupted.

They crashed against the chain-link fence as people scattered from the sideline. C-Mack swung hard. Reck ducked the first punch but caught the second across his cheek. Mari rushed toward them, only for Zay to grab him around the chest.

“Let Reck handle it!” Zay shouted.

“Get off me!”

TJ climbed onto the bleacher seat for a better view, caught between recording and fear. Naz did neither. He watched C-Mack’s three friends, waiting to see if the fight would remain between two people.

It did not.

One of them stepped forward.

Naz blocked his path. “Don’t.”

The boy looked at Naz’s glasses and quiet expression, mistaking calmness for weakness.

“Move.”

Naz did not.

At the fence, Reck drove his shoulder into C-Mack and forced him backward. His gold chains jumped against his chest. C-Mack was older and heavier, but Reck fought like the entire neighborhood would remember whichever one of them took a step backward first.

Reck refused to let it be him.

A car door slammed.

“Enough.”

Mon’s voice cut through the noise.

Nobody listened immediately—not even C-Mack.

Mon crossed the court, grabbed him by the back of his shirt and pulled him away from Reck with one arm. Reck stepped forward again, breathing hard, a small streak of blood at the corner of his mouth.

Mon placed himself between them.

“I said enough.”

C-Mack looked down. “He put his hands on me.”

“And you let him.”

That answer wounded C-Mack worse than the fight.

Mon turned toward Reck. The court became silent enough to hear the broken streetlight buzzing above the fence.

“You think being loud makes you dangerous?” Mon asked.

Reck wiped his mouth with the back of his hand. He looked at the blood, then smiled.

“You heard me, didn’t you?”

Mari whispered, “Man, Reck crazy.”

Zay closed his eyes for half a second.

TJ lifted the phone again.

Naz watched Mon.



Mon stepped closer, studying the sixteen-year-old who had just challenged him in front of half the complex. Reck's chest rose and fell, but he did not move. Fear lived somewhere inside him—Naz knew that—but pride stood in front of it like a locked door.

“King K wants to see you,” Mon said.

That changed the air.

Even Reck's smile weakened.

King K did not call teenagers to his car wash for conversation. He called people when he had business, questions or problems.

“About what?” Reck asked.

“If he wanted you to know out here, I would've told you out here.”

Mon turned and walked back toward the Chevrolet.

C-Mack and his friends followed, leaving the court without another word. He looked over his shoulder once, humiliation burning across his face.

Reck had won the crowd.

He might have made an enemy too.

The apartment walkways came alive with whispers. Somebody replayed TJ's video. Younger boys repeated Reck's answer to Mon, each version louder than the last.

You heard me, didn't you?

Within an hour, the words would cross Sunridge Plaza, pass through Garden Courts and reach The Palms. By midnight, people who had never attended the game would swear they had stood beside Reck when he said them.

That was how reputations grew in The Ridge.

Not from truth.

From witnesses who wanted better stories.

Mari slapped Reck's shoulder. "You just talked crazy to Mon in front of everybody."

"I talked regular."

"That ain't regular for nobody with sense."

Zay picked up the abandoned basketball. "King K calling you isn't something to celebrate."

"Who celebrating?" Reck asked, still smiling.

"Your face."

TJ hurried down from the bleachers. "The video already got three hundred views."

Reck's smile vanished. "Take it down."

TJ stared at him. "What? Why?"

"Because I said take it down."

"But everybody posting it."

Naz finally walked over. "Then everybody is showing King K exactly who was here, what happened and what Mon said."

TJ looked at his screen, understanding too late. He deleted the post.

"You still treating me like I'm little," he muttered.

Reck reached over and squeezed the back of TJ's neck. "Then stop making little mistakes."

TJ pulled away, embarrassed.

Zay tossed the ball toward Reck. "Don't go see King K by yourself."

Reck caught it against his chest.

"He didn't call all of us."

"That's the point."

For the first time all evening, Reck looked uncertain. Across the parking lot, The Sunshine's yellow paint glowed beneath the sunset.

His cousin D-Low stood on its porch in a vintage Miami jersey and gold-framed glasses, watching from a distance.

D-Low raised his chin.

Come here.

Reck handed the ball to Zay.

“I’m going to see what my cousin want.”

Mari stepped beside him. “We coming.”

“Nah.”

“What happened to together?”

Reck looked at all four of them: Mari’s restless energy, Zay’s concern, TJ’s wounded pride and Naz’s unreadable stare.

They had spent their childhood on that court. Back then, the biggest danger had been broken glass beneath the bleachers or Shanice calling Reck upstairs before the streetlights came on.

They were not children anymore.

The Ridge had started noticing them.

And somebody powerful had started noticing Reck.

“Stay here,” he said. “If I need y’all, I’ll call.”

He crossed the parking lot alone, red shirt bright beneath the dying sun. Residents watched from porches and windows. Reck walked slowly, shoulders loose, as if King K’s invitation had not placed a knot inside his stomach.

D-Low opened the door to The Sunshine.

Cold air spilled from the darkness behind him.

“You been busy, little cousin,” he said.

Reck stopped at the bottom of the steps. “Everybody keep saying that.”

D-Low studied the blood at the corner of his mouth.

“King K heard about you.”

“Good.”

“You sure about that?”

Reck looked back toward the Back Court. His friends stood beneath the flickering light, each one watching him.

Then he faced the open doorway.

Most people in Sunridge spent their lives trying not to attract the attention of men like King K.

Reck wanted the entire neighborhood to know his name.

He climbed the steps.

“Yeah,” he said. “I’m sure.”

D-Low moved aside.

Reck entered The Sunshine, and the door closed behind him.

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# INSIDE THE SUNSHINE

The first thing Reck noticed was the cold.

Outside, Sunridge Gardens felt like an oven. Inside The Sunshine, two stolen window units pushed freezing air through rooms with boarded windows. The abandoned yellow duplex had looked dead from the street for years, but behind its reinforced door, it never slept.

Music played from a speaker on the kitchen counter. Men moved through the narrow hallway. Somebody counted money at a folding table beneath a bare bulb. A security monitor showed four grainy camera angles—the front steps, the parking lot, the canal path and the entrance to Garden Courts.

The place smelled like cigar smoke, sweat and old carpet.

Reck had been inside once as a child, when the duplex still belonged to Mrs. Green and plastic covered her furniture. She used to hand out frozen cups from the porch.

Now the family photographs were gone. Metal covered the back door. The living room had become a waiting area for people who never stayed long.

D-Low locked the entrance behind them.

“Keep your eyes forward,” he said.

Reck glanced at the money table again. “I know how to act.”

“Knowing and doing ain’t never been the same thing with you.”

D-Low led him down the hallway. His freeform locs brushed the shoulders of a faded Miami jersey. Gold-framed glasses made him look relaxed, but he checked every room they passed.

At the end of the hall, Mon stood beside a closed bedroom door.

He looked at Reck's bleeding lip. "You proud of that?"

"You keep asking me questions like you care."

Mon moved away from the wall.

D-Low stepped between them. "Not tonight."

Mon stared over D-Low's shoulder. "That mouth gon' put him somewhere his legs can't carry him out of."

Reck smiled. "But not tonight, right?"

D-Low pushed open the bedroom door before Mon could answer.

Kendrick Wallace sat behind a glass desk wearing a cream polo shirt, dark tailored pants and brown loafers. King K was heavysset, bald and perfectly groomed. A gold watch rested against his wrist. He looked more like the owner of an expensive restaurant than the man whose name controlled half of western Palm Haven.

Bree Lawson stood beside the desk with a tablet in one hand. Her platinum-blond pixie cut, fitted black blazer and sharp cheekbones made her look completely out of place inside the ruined duplex.

That was probably intentional.

King K looked at Reck for several seconds.

"Kareem Dawson."

"People call me Reck."

"I know what people call you." King K leaned back. "I knew your father before people called him Reem."

Reck's jaw tightened.

"Everybody know my father."

"Everybody knows a story about him. That's different."

Bree watched Reck without expression. Mon remained in the doorway. D-Low took a position near the wall.

Reck suddenly understood that this was not a conversation. It was an examination.

King K folded his hands. "Why did you fight Curtis?"

"He lost and started talking crazy."

"People talk crazy every day."

"Not to me."

King K smiled slightly. "That what makes you special?"

"I ain't say I was special."

"You didn't have to. You wear it."

Reck looked down at his red shirt and chains. "I like looking good."

"You like being seen." Bree spoke for the first time. Her voice was cool and precise. "There's a difference."

Reck looked at her. "Who are you?"

D-Low exhaled softly.

Mon shook his head.

Bree did not react. "Someone you should know before you enter rooms asking questions."

King K laughed once. "That fearlessness might be real. Or he might not understand danger yet."

"Same result if nobody corrects it," Mon said.

Reck looked toward the doorway. "I'm standing right here."

"That's what we're discussing," King K replied. "Where you stand."

The room became quiet.

King K reached into a desk drawer and removed a thick white envelope. He set it on the glass between them.

"Your mother behind on rent?"

Reck's face changed before he could stop it.

"Who told you that?"

"The Ridge talks."

“My family ain’t neighborhood business.”

“Everything becomes neighborhood business when eviction papers touch the door.”

Reck stepped toward the desk. D-Low straightened. Mon unfolded his arms.

King K did not move.

“Be careful,” he said quietly. “Your pride is about to disrespect somebody trying to help your mother.”

Reck stared at the envelope.

It was thick enough to solve a problem Shanice had been hiding behind closed bedroom doors and late-night phone calls. The lights had already been disconnected once that summer. Kobe believed it was a neighborhood outage. Reck had let him believe it.

“What you want?” Reck asked.

“Smartest thing you’ve said since you walked in.”

King K tapped the envelope.

“D-Low needs somebody to make a delivery across town.”

“I can do that.”

“You don’t know what it is.”

“Don’t matter.”

Bree’s eyes narrowed. “It should.”

King K pushed the envelope across the desk. “Half now. Half when you return.”

Reck picked it up. It felt heavier than money should have felt.

“Where am I going?”

D-Low answered from behind him. “Paradise Beach.”

Reck turned.



Paradise Beach was not part of their world. Tourists filled its hotels, valet drivers parked cars worth more than Building 17, and police arrived before arguments had time to become fights.

It was also territory claimed by men who did not recognize King K's control.

"Why me?" Reck asked.

King K smiled again. "Because nobody looking for you yet."

Yet.

The word stayed with Reck.

"You want respect?" King K continued. "Learn what it costs before you start spending it."

Reck slipped the envelope into his pocket.

"When?"

"Now."

• • •

Outside, night had settled over Sunridge.

The broken streetlight behind Building 17 flickered above the Back Court. Mari was dribbling between his legs. Zay sat on the bleachers, long arms resting across his knees. TJ stared at his phone. Naz stood where Reck had left him, charcoal hoodie almost disappearing into the darkness.

All four looked toward The Sunshine when the door opened.

Reck walked across the parking lot with D-Low beside him.

A silver sedan waited near the curb. It belonged to one of D-Low's girlfriends, which meant police would not immediately connect it to The Sunshine.

"What King K want?" Mari asked.

"Business," Reck said.

Zay stood. "What kind?"

"The kind that don't concern you."

That answer irritated all of them.

Mari stopped dribbling. "We been out here waiting for you."

"I ain't ask you to."

TJ looked up from his phone. "You said if you needed us, you'd call."

"I don't need you."

The words landed harder than Reck intended.

Naz studied the silver car, then D-Low. "Where are you taking him?"

D-Low smiled. "He always let you question grown men?"

"Only when grown men avoid simple answers."

Reck stepped between them. "Chill, Naz."

Zay came down from the bleachers. At six-foot-four, he stood eye to eye with D-Low.

"If something happens to him—"

"What?" D-Low interrupted. "You gon' throw a basketball at me?"

Mari moved beside Zay.

TJ rose too.

For one brief second, the Ridge Boyz stood together beneath the dying streetlight. They had no rank, no money and no real power. But D-Low saw something in the way they closed around Reck without being called.

So did Reck.

"I'm good," he told them. "Go home."

Naz looked directly at him. "That envelope worth lying to your brothers?"

Reck touched his pocket instinctively.

Naz noticed.

Of course he did.

“I said I’m good.” Reck opened the passenger door. “Stop acting scared for me.”

Zay’s serious expression hardened. “We ain’t scared for you. We scared of what you become when people start paying you to be reckless.”

Reck climbed into the car without answering.

D-Low drove away from the Back Court, leaving the four boys beneath the flickering light.

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Paradise Boulevard separated two versions of Florida.

On the west side stood Sunridge Gardens: stained apartment walls, dark windows, corner stores protected by scratched security glass and patrol cars moving slowly enough to study everybody outside.

On the east side, palm trees were wrapped in white lights. Hotel towers reflected moonlight from the ocean. Tourists walked between restaurants carrying shopping bags, unaware that ten minutes away, families were deciding which bill could remain unpaid.

D-Low drove with one hand on the wheel.

A black duffel bag rested at Reck’s feet.

“You don’t open it,” D-Low said.

“Wasn’t planning to.”

“You don’t ask the man receiving it what’s inside.”

“I know.”

“And if anything feel wrong, you call me before you make one of your Reck decisions.”

Reck looked through the passenger window. “Why King K pick me?”

“You wanted him to notice you.”

“That ain’t an answer.”

D-Low glanced at him. “People like King K don’t give opportunities. They purchase pieces of you. Tonight he bought the part worried about your mama’s rent.”

Reck touched the envelope again.

“Then I got something I needed too.”

“That’s how everybody explains the first time.”

Blue lights appeared in the rearview mirror.

D-Low’s face changed.

The police cruiser was two cars behind them, moving closer through traffic.

Reck looked down at the duffel bag.

“Is that for us?”

“Don’t turn around.”

The cruiser changed lanes.

Reck’s heartbeat climbed. Every instinct told him to look back, open the bag or demand answers. Instead, he stared through the windshield as Paradise Beach glowed ahead of them.

The blue lights grew brighter across the mirrors.

Then the siren sounded.

D-Low tightened both hands around the steering wheel.

“Listen carefully,” he said. “Whatever happens next, don’t panic.”

Reck looked at his cousin.

Then he looked at the black bag between his feet.

For once, Kareem “Reck” Dawson had nothing loud to say.

• • •



# BLUE LIGHTS

The siren screamed behind them.

Blue-and-red light rolled across the silver sedan, bounced off hotel windows and flashed over the black duffel bag between Reck's shoes.

D-Low slowed the car.

"What you doing?" Reck asked.

"What it look like?"

"You pulling over?"

"This ain't the movies."

D-Low signaled and guided the sedan toward the curb outside a brightly lit seafood restaurant. Tourists waited beneath a blue awning while valets rushed between luxury cars. Several people turned to watch the police stop unfolding beside them.

Reck pushed the duffel farther beneath his seat.

"Leave it," D-Low said.

"It's sticking out."

"Moving around makes it worse."

D-Low lowered both front windows and placed his hands on the steering wheel. His gold-framed glasses reflected the patrol lights. Reck tried to copy his calm posture, but his right knee would not stop moving.

In the side mirror, two officers stepped from the cruiser.

One approached D-Low. The other moved toward Reck's side with a flashlight resting above his shoulder.

“License and registration,” the first officer said.

He was white, middle-aged and thick through the waist. His nameplate read **MILLER**.

D-Low kept his hands visible. “My license is in my back pocket.”

“Get it slowly.”

D-Low reached behind him.

The officer on Reck’s side shined his flashlight directly into his face. She was younger, Latina, with dark hair pulled into a tight bun. Her nameplate read **SANTIAGO**.

“How old are you?” she asked.

“Sixteen.”

“You have identification?”

“Not on me.”

“What’s your name?”

Reck hesitated.

“Kareem Dawson.”

Officer Santiago studied him. “Where are you two headed?”

“To see somebody.”

D-Low glanced across the car.

“Where?” she asked.

“Paradise Beach.”

“You’re already in Paradise Beach.”

“Then I guess we almost there.”

Santiago lowered the flashlight slightly. “Is something funny?”

“No, ma’am,” D-Low answered for him.

Officer Miller took the license back to the cruiser. Santiago remained beside the passenger window, watching Reck breathe.

The duffel bag pressed against his ankle.

Across the street, music drifted from a rooftop lounge. Couples laughed beneath strings of white lights. A horse-drawn tourist carriage rolled through the intersection as if two different cities were occupying the same block.

Santiago aimed the flashlight toward Reck's lap.

"What happened to your mouth?"

"Basketball."

"Basketball hit back now?"

Reck looked away.

The officer moved the light across the floorboard.

It stopped.

"What's in the bag?"

D-Low answered. "Gym clothes."

"I asked him."

Reck could feel D-Low's warning without looking at him.

"Gym clothes," he repeated.

"Whose bag is it?"

"Mine," D-Low said.

"His," Reck said at the same time.

Silence filled the sedan.

Santiago took one step back from the window.

"Driver, turn the vehicle off."

D-Low's jaw tightened. "For what?"

"Turn it off."

Officer Miller left the cruiser and walked back toward them. One hand rested near his holster.



Reck looked at D-Low.

D-Low looked straight ahead.

“Don’t,” he whispered.

Reck did not know whether his cousin was speaking to him, himself or both of them.

Miller reached the driver’s door. “Step out of the vehicle.”

“Officer, you stopped me over a taillight.”

“I’m not going to ask again.”

D-Low turned the key.

For half a second, the engine went silent.

Then his hand snapped back to the ignition.

The sedan roared.

“Hold on!”

D-Low slammed the accelerator.

The rear tires jumped from the curb. Officer Miller struck the side of the car with his palm as it shot into traffic. Santiago leaped backward, shouting into her radio.

Reck crashed against the passenger seat.

The duffel slid from beneath him and hit the dashboard.

“You said this ain’t the movies!” Reck shouted.

“Shut up and watch the bag!”

They tore through a red light.

Horns exploded around them. A convertible swerved toward the sidewalk. D-Low cut between two SUVs and pushed the sedan down Paradise Boulevard as the police cruiser surged after them.

Reck grabbed the duffel.

The zipper had split open.

Inside were several tightly wrapped packages and a handgun sealed in a plastic bag.

His stomach dropped.

“D-Low!”

“Zip it!”

“King K sent me with this?”

“Zip the bag!”

The cruiser struck the rear bumper.

Reck lurched forward. The handgun slid across the floorboard and disappeared beneath D-Low’s seat.

“It came out!”

D-Low looked down for a fraction of a second.

The sedan clipped a parked delivery van.

Metal screamed. The passenger mirror shattered, spraying glass through Reck’s open window. He covered his face as D-Low fought the steering wheel and forced the car back into the lane.

More sirens joined the first.

Reck looked behind them. Two cruisers were approaching from the next intersection. Farther back, the beach traffic had become a wall of brake lights and frightened drivers.

“Call Mon,” D-Low said.

“You call him!”

“I’m driving!”

Reck pulled out his phone. His hand shook badly enough to miss the contact twice.

Mon answered on the first ring.

“What?”

“Police behind us.”

“Where’s D-Low?”

“Driving!”

“Put him on.”

“He driving!”

Mon’s voice sharpened. “Where are you?”

Reck looked through the windshield. “Paradise and Ocean.”

“Why did he run?”

D-Low shouted, “Tell him the bag got seen!”

“They saw the bag!”

There was a brief silence on the phone.

“Do not bring that car back to Sunridge,” Mon said.

The call ended.

“He hung up,” Reck said.

“Of course he did.”

D-Low jerked the wheel and turned west.

The glowing hotels fell behind them. Tourist shops gave way to tire stores, pawnshops and shuttered businesses. The streets narrowed. Rainwater from an afternoon storm remained in deep potholes, exploding beneath the sedan’s tires.

The police stayed close.

A helicopter light appeared above the rooftops.

Reck stared through the rear window. “They got a chopper.”

“I see it.”

“Then where we going?”

D-Low did not answer.

They crossed beneath the expressway. The sedan bottomed out on the railroad tracks, throwing Reck against the door. His phone flew from his hand and landed near the loose gun.

The engine made a grinding noise.

“Car breaking down,” Reck said.

“I know.”

“So what now?”

D-Low looked toward a row of dark warehouses beside the canal.

“Now we run.”

He turned sharply into an industrial lot, struck a locked chain across the entrance and broke through it. The sedan bounced over gravel. The helicopter light swept across the roof.

D-Low braked behind an abandoned warehouse.

“Get out!”

Reck grabbed the duffel.

D-Low slapped it from his hands.

“Leave it!”

“King K gon’—”

“We get caught with that, King K ain’t gon’ matter!”

D-Low reached beneath his seat, found the handgun and threw it back into the open bag. Then he pushed through the driver’s door.

Reck followed.

They sprinted toward the canal as cruisers entered the lot behind them. Officers shouted. Gravel scattered beneath Reck’s sneakers. The helicopter light found them, turning night into violent white daylight.

“Stop running!” a voice boomed from above.

D-Low reached the canal fence first and climbed.

Reck jumped, caught the top and pulled himself upward. Metal cut into his palms. His chains tangled against the links.

A police dog barked somewhere behind them.

“Move!” D-Low shouted from the other side.

Reck ripped one chain from his neck and dropped into the weeds. Together they ran along the black canal water toward a concrete drainage tunnel.

The helicopter circled.

Officers climbed the fence.

D-Low reached the tunnel entrance and disappeared inside. Reck followed him into ankle-deep water and darkness.

The tunnel swallowed the sirens but multiplied every breath and footstep. Reck could not see more than a few feet ahead. Dirty water filled his expensive sneakers. Spiderwebs brushed his face. He kept one hand on the concrete wall and chased the sound of D-Low moving ahead.

“Where this go?” he asked.

“Just keep moving.”

Behind them, light entered the tunnel.

Police were coming.

They reached a split in the drainage system. D-Low went left.

Reck grabbed his jersey. “That way leads back toward the road.”

“How you know?”

“Me and my boys ride bikes through these canals.”

Reck pointed right. “That comes out behind Cypress Bottom.”

D-Low hesitated.

For the first time that night, the older man followed Reck.

They turned right.

The tunnel narrowed until both had to crouch. Reck's legs burned. His lungs pulled at the humid air. He thought about Shanice cleaning hotel rooms on the other side of the city. He thought about Kobe's drawings and Zay warning him at the Back Court.

He thought about the envelope still folded inside his pocket.

Half the money now.

Half when you return.

They reached a rusted grate overlooking a ditch behind Cypress Bottom. D-Low kicked it twice before it broke loose.

Both crawled through.

No helicopter light waited outside.

For the moment, they had disappeared.

They ran through the rear of the neighborhood, passing dark homes and barking dogs. D-Low slowed behind an abandoned daycare center and leaned against the wall, fighting for breath.

Reck bent forward with his hands on his knees.

Then he started laughing.

D-Low stared at him. "What's funny?"

Reck tried to answer but laughed harder.

The fear had nowhere else to go.

"We got away," he finally said.

D-Low shoved him against the wall.

"The car is gone. The work is gone. The gun is gone. Your phone is inside it, and cameras caught our faces from Paradise Beach to the warehouse."

Reck's laughter stopped.

"King K trusted you with one thing," D-Low continued. "Now he lost everything."

“You was driving.”

“And you think he gon’ care?”

Reck pushed D-Low’s hand from his chest. “You brought me.”

“Because I thought you wanted to grow up.”

“I handled myself.”

“You survived ten minutes. That ain’t the same thing.”

D-Low stepped away and looked toward the street.

“We need a phone.”

Reck reached into his pocket and removed King K’s envelope. The edges were wet, but the money remained inside.

D-Low stared at it.

“At least we got this,” Reck said.

“That ain’t yours anymore.”

Reck closed his fist around the envelope.

In the distance, sirens spread across Palm Haven. Police would trace the sedan. They would identify D-Low. They would find Reck’s phone, his fingerprints and the blood from his split lip.

Back in Sunridge, the Ridge Boyz were probably watching the chase on social media without knowing their friend had been inside the car.

Reck had wanted the city to know his name.

By sunrise, it might.

But not for the reason he imagined.

...

# EVIDENCE

By two in the morning, the police had turned the warehouse lot into a field of flashing lights.

The silver sedan sat crooked behind yellow tape with its passenger mirror missing and its front bumper hanging toward the gravel. Officers photographed the doors, the floorboards and the blood smeared along the inside of the passenger window.

Detective Renee Holloway stood beneath the helicopter wind with blue gloves covering her hands.

She was forty-one, tall, dark-skinned and composed, with her hair pulled into a low bun. Unlike the patrol officers moving excitedly around the car, Holloway looked at every piece of evidence as if it were part of a conversation only she could hear.

Officer Santiago approached with a clear evidence bag.

Inside was Reck's phone.

"Found beneath the driver's seat," Santiago said. "Screen is cracked, but it still powers on."

Holloway studied it through the plastic. A photograph filled the lock screen: five boys standing beneath a mural at the Back Court.

Reck stood in the center wearing red and gold. Mari grinned beside him. Zay towered over the others. TJ held up one hand toward the camera. Naz remained at the edge, expression unreadable behind his glasses.

"Kids," Holloway said.

"One of those kids almost got me run over."

"That doesn't make him grown."



An evidence technician called from the sedan.

“Detective, you need to see this.”

The black duffel bag rested open across the back seat. Its wrapped packages had been arranged beside the sealed handgun for photographs.

Holloway’s face hardened.

“Run the weapon,” she said. “Print everything. Find the registered owner of the car and pull every camera between the traffic stop and this lot.”

Santiago held up Reck’s phone. “And him?”

Holloway looked again at the five boys on the screen.

“Find out who he is before whoever owns that bag decides he knows too much.”

• • •

Reck and D-Low reached Sunridge shortly before sunrise.

They traveled separately for the final mile. D-Low disappeared toward The Palms. Reck crossed the canal on foot, wet jeans scraping his legs and ruined sneakers making soft sucking noises against the pavement.

His red shirt was torn. One chain was gone. Blood had dried beside his mouth, and dirt covered the bright clothes that had looked perfect only hours earlier.

Sunridge Gardens appeared quiet.

It wasn’t.

Faces watched from dark windows. People stood outside The Sunshine speaking in low voices. Clips of the Paradise Beach chase had already spread across social media: the silver sedan running a red light, police cruisers striking its bumper, two figures sprinting toward the canal beneath a helicopter light.

Nobody could clearly identify the passenger.

Yet.

Reck headed toward Building 17.

The Ridge Boyz were waiting at the Back Court.

Mari paced beneath the broken streetlight wearing the same open orange jersey. Zay sat forward on the bleachers, elbows on his knees. TJ's colorful clothes looked dull beneath the weak light. Naz stood beside the fence with his hood raised.

All four saw Reck at once.

Mari reached him first. "That was you?"

Reck kept walking. "Keep your voice down."

"That was you in that car?"

Zay rose. "Look at him. Of course it was."

TJ stared at Reck's torn clothes. "People saying they found a bag."

"People say anything."

Naz looked at Reck's empty hands. "Where's your phone?"

Reck stopped.

Nobody spoke.

Naz removed his glasses and cleaned them with the bottom of his hoodie. "Police have it."

"Maybe."

"Your location history, messages and pictures too."

"I know what's in my phone."

"Do you know what police can pull out of it?"

Mari stepped between them. "Let him breathe."

Zay looked toward The Sunshine. "King K know you came back?"

"Not yet."

“Then go home,” Zay said. “Wake your mother and tell her the truth before police tell it for you.”

Reck laughed bitterly. “You got all the answers now?”

“I had one answer before you left. Don’t get in that car.”

Reck walked toward him. “Say what you really want to say.”

Zay did not back away. “You wanted King K to notice you so bad you let him put you in a car with something that could bury you.”

“I didn’t know what was in the bag.”

“That make it better?”

“I did it for my family.”

“Everybody says that after.”

Reck shoved Zay’s chest.

Zay barely moved.

Mari grabbed Reck’s arm. “Chill.”

“Get off me.”

“We waited all night thinking you was dead or locked up!” TJ shouted.

The youngest boy’s voice cracked. Anger and fear fought across his freckled face.

“You told us you didn’t need us,” TJ continued. “Then the whole city chasing you and we had to find out online.”

Reck looked at each of them.

These were not King K’s people. They did not need his money, fear his reputation or owe him favors. They had stayed because they loved him.

That made their disappointment harder to face than Mon’s threats.

“I messed up,” Reck said.

Mari blinked. “What?”

“You heard me.”

“Say it again. I want to record it.”

Despite everything, Zay almost smiled.

Naz put his glasses back on. “What happens now?”

A car turned into the parking lot.

Black headlights swept across the court.

Mon’s Chevrolet stopped beside the fence.

The driver’s door opened.

Mon stepped out with C-Mack and another man behind him. He wore the same black shirt from earlier, but his calm had disappeared.

“Now,” Reck said, “we find out.”

Mon entered through the court gate.

“King K wants you at the car wash.”

“I just got back.”

“He knows.”

“Then he know D-Low was driving.”

Mon stopped several feet away. “He knows D-Low lost his property. He knows you left your phone in the car. And he knows both of you ran without calling until police were already chasing you.”

“What was I supposed to do?”

“You can explain that to him.”

Mon looked toward the other boys.

“Alone.”

Reck wiped dried blood from his lip.

“They coming.”

“They weren’t invited.”

Mari moved beside Reck. “We ain’t asking.”

C-Mack laughed from behind Mon. His cheek had swollen from the Back Court fight.

“These little boys think they an army now.”

Zay stepped to Reck’s other side. His height erased C-Mack’s smile.

TJ joined them, frightened but determined not to show it.

Naz moved last. He did not stand shoulder to shoulder with the others. He remained half a step behind, watching Mon, C-Mack, the second man and the Chevrolet.

Counting.

Mon’s eyes traveled across all five.

“This ain’t a basketball game,” he said.

Reck stepped forward.

“I ain’t ask for that chase. I ain’t tell D-Low to run, and I ain’t put that bag in the car. But I’m not letting nobody treat me like I’m weak either.”

The apartment windows seemed to lean closer.

“We out here living fast,” Reck continued, “so we know what comes with it. If King K wants his money, we can talk business. If he wants to disrespect me, threaten my family or go to war over it, then it’s whatever. I’m not a pushover, and I’m not standing by myself.”

Mari nodded immediately. “Not ever.”

Zay’s expression remained serious. “We handle our problems together.”

TJ lifted his chin. “All of us.”

Naz looked directly at Mon. “So tell King K five are coming.”

For several seconds, Mon said nothing.

Then he smiled.

It was the first time Reck had seen him do it, and there was no warmth inside it.

“Get in the car.”

...

King’s Premium Car Wash stood closed beneath the purple light before sunrise.

During business hours, employees detailed luxury cars beneath white awnings while music played from outdoor speakers. Tonight, the gates were locked. Only the office lights were on.

Mon led the Ridge Boyz through the wash tunnel. Their footsteps echoed between silent machinery. Water dripped from hanging brushes like rain inside a cave.

King K waited in the upstairs office with Bree and D-Low.

D-Low had changed clothes. A cut marked his forehead. He would not meet Reck’s eyes.

King K sat behind a wide wooden desk. He looked at the five boys entering his office and then at Mon.

“I asked for one.”

“One brought four,” Mon said.

King K leaned back.

“The Ridge Boyz,” he said. “That what people calling y’all?”

Nobody answered.

Bree placed several photographs on the desk. Images from traffic cameras showed the sedan racing through Paradise Beach. Another captured Reck’s face through the shattered passenger window.

“Police will identify him,” Bree said. “If they haven’t already.”

King K looked at Reck. “You lost my product, my weapon and my connection at the beach. D-Low says the officer saw the bag because you pushed it beneath the seat.”

Reck turned toward his cousin.

D-Low finally looked at him. "That's what happened."

The betrayal was small enough to sound reasonable.

That made it worse.

"You told me to watch the bag," Reck said.

"I told you not to move."

"And who started the car?"

D-Low's jaw tightened.

King K raised one hand. The room became silent.

"Blame does not repay loss," he said. "Results do."

He named a number.

Mari stopped smiling. TJ looked at Reck. Even Zay's controlled expression broke.

Reck had never seen that much money outside music videos.

"I don't owe all that," he said.

"You and D-Low owe it together."

"Then why am I the only one being tested?"

King K's gaze moved toward the four boys behind Reck.

"Maybe you aren't."

Naz understood first. "You want us working off his debt."

Bree answered. "Nobody said that."

"You didn't need to."

King K studied Naz with new interest.

"The quiet one listens," he said.

Reck placed both hands on the desk.

"My people don't owe you."

"Your people followed you into my office."

“To stand beside me. Not work for you.”

King K’s polished calm disappeared for a moment.

“Be careful, son.”

“Don’t call me that.”

Mon closed the office door.

Mari moved closer to Reck. Zay shifted his feet. TJ’s hands trembled at his sides, but he stayed in place. Naz watched Bree, recognizing that she—not Mon—was studying every possible outcome.

King K rose slowly from his chair.

“Your father once stood in this same neighborhood believing respect made him untouchable,” he said. “Then the streets taught him otherwise.”

“I’m not my father.”

“No. Your father knew when he was surrounded.”

Reck looked around the office.

Then he looked back at King K.

“So do I.”

Outside, tires squealed near the front gate.

Blue lights flashed across the car-wash windows.

Everyone froze.

A loudspeaker broke the morning silence.

“Palm Haven Police Department. Nobody leave the building.”

Bree swept the photographs from the desk. Mon reached beneath his shirt. D-Low stepped away from the window.

King K’s eyes locked onto Reck.

The same question crossed every face inside the office.

How had police found them so quickly?



Then TJ's phone began to ring.

The sound filled the silent room.

King K looked at the youngest Ridge Boy.

Mon looked at the phone.

And for the first time since entering the car wash, TJ looked like the fifteen-year-old he was.

• • •

# NOBODY TALKS

TJ's phone kept ringing.

Nobody inside King K's office moved.

Blue light swept through the blinds, crossed King K's face and disappeared. Outside, police radios crackled beneath the mechanical hum of the car wash.

Mon extended one hand.

"Give it to me."

TJ looked at Reck.

"Who calling?" Reck asked.

TJ pulled the phone from his pocket. The screen showed **MAMA** above a photograph of a woman in hospital scrubs.

"My mom."

Mon snatched it and rejected the call.

"Hey!" TJ reached for it.

Mon held the phone above him. "You brought this in here with the location on?"

"I don't know!"

"You don't know?"

Reck stepped between them. "Give him his phone."

"Your phone already put police on one car," Mon said. "Now his got them at the gate."

“Police could’ve followed anybody here.” Naz looked toward D-Low.  
“Especially someone who escaped a chase a few hours ago.”

D-Low came away from the window. “Watch how you talk to me.”

“Watch how many stories you tell.”

King K struck the desk with his palm.

Everybody stopped.

“Phones on the desk,” he said.

Mari hesitated. Zay removed his first. Naz followed. Mari placed his beside it. TJ glared at Mon until the older man dropped his phone with the others.

Reck had nothing to surrender.

His phone was already in police evidence.

The loudspeaker sounded again.

“Exit through the front entrance with your hands visible.”

King K looked at Bree.

“What do they have?”

“Enough for the building,” she replied. “Maybe not enough for everybody inside.”

Mon moved toward a cabinet.

“Leave it closed,” Bree said.

His hand stopped.

“If they find you reaching when they enter, none of this matters.”

Footsteps pounded below them.

The front door shattered.

“Police! Search warrant!”

Men shouted throughout the wash tunnel. Equipment crashed. Mari moved closer to Reck. Zay grabbed the back of TJ's shirt before the youngest boy could retreat toward the corner.

"Hands where they can see them," Zay said.

The office door burst inward.

Officers flooded the room wearing tactical vests and helmets. Red laser dots traveled across shirts, walls and faces.

"On the floor!"

Reck lowered himself beside his friends. Plastic restraints tightened around his wrists. A boot pressed between his shoulder blades while officers searched his pockets and removed King K's envelope.

"That's mine," Reck said.

"Nobody asked," an officer replied.

Across the room, King K lay facedown in his cream polo, silent and composed. Mon looked furious enough to bite through the floor. D-Low stared at Reck as if they were strangers.

TJ's breathing became fast and shallow.

"Look at me," Zay said from beside him.

"Face down!" an officer shouted.

Zay kept his head turned anyway. "Breathe, TJ. You good."

"I can't—"

"Yes, you can."

Reck heard the panic in TJ's voice and pulled against the restraints.

"He fifteen!"

An officer pushed him down harder.

"Then he should've been home."

That sentence stayed with Reck as officers raised him from the floor and marched him downstairs.

Outside, dawn had arrived.

So had the cameras.

Local reporters stood beyond the police line. Neighbors held phones above the gate. Employees from nearby businesses watched as King K, Bree, Mon, D-Low and the Ridge Boyz were led from the car wash one by one.

Reck lifted his head.

Zay looked straight ahead. Mari tried to smile at the cameras. Naz studied every vehicle in the lot. TJ searched the crowd for his mother.

The Ridge Boyz entered police custody together.

• • •

Detective Holloway placed five photographs across the interview-room table.

TJ sat opposite her with his wrists free and his hands hidden beneath his thighs. Without the other boys around him, he looked smaller. His curly Afro had flattened on one side from the ride downtown. The purple shirt that seemed bright at the Back Court now made him appear even younger beneath the fluorescent lights.

His mother had not arrived yet.

Holloway sat without opening a folder or raising her voice.

“Terrence, do you know why you’re here?”

“Everybody calls me TJ.”

“All right, TJ. Do you know why you’re here?”

“Because y’all brought me.”

Holloway almost smiled. “You sound like your friend Kareem.”

TJ stared at the photographs.

They showed the Ridge Boyz at the Back Court, Reck entering The Sunshine and Mon's Chevrolet leaving Sunridge with all five boys inside.

"Where is Kareem's phone?" Holloway asked.

TJ shrugged.

"We found it inside a car carrying narcotics and an illegal firearm."

TJ swallowed but said nothing.

"Did Kareem tell you about the chase?"

Nothing.

"Did D-Low take him to Paradise Beach?"

Nothing.

"You're fifteen years old," Holloway said. "King K is not going to protect you. Mon is not going to protect you. When grown men get scared, they place everything on the youngest person in the room."

TJ looked toward the mirrored glass.

"You think Reck will protect you?"

TJ finally spoke. "I want my mama."

"She's on her way."

"Then I'll wait."

Holloway leaned back. "You understand you can help yourself?"

"I ain't got nothing to say."

"That line belong to you or Kareem?"

TJ's freckles stood out against his frightened face. His fingers trembled beneath the table.

But his voice held.

"Nobody talks."

...

Reck sat in another room with dried canal water stiffening his jeans.

Holloway entered carrying his cracked phone in an evidence bag.

She placed it between them.

“You lose something?”

Reck looked at the lock-screen photograph of his crew.

“Never seen it.”

“That’s unfortunate. There are photographs of your mother, your brother and about six hundred pictures of you on it.”

“A lot of people take pictures of me.”

“Your confidence is impressive.”

“Thank you.”

“It wasn’t a compliment.”

Holloway sat across from him.

“Officer Santiago identified you as the passenger. Traffic cameras identified you. Your blood is in the car. Your fingerprints will probably be on the bag.”

Reck’s expression did not change.

“You were used,” she continued. “King K put a sixteen-year-old beside contraband because he believed you were disposable.”

“I don’t know no King K.”

“You were arrested in his office.”

“I went to get my car washed.”

Holloway looked through the mirrored glass as if inviting whoever stood behind it to appreciate the answer.

“At five in the morning?”

“I like beating the crowd.”

This time she did smile.

“You’re funny. That won’t make the evidence disappear.”

She placed a photograph of D-Low beside the phone.

“DeAndre says you brought the duffel into his girlfriend’s car.”

The lie hit Reck harder than he expected.

He looked at D-Low’s photograph but did not touch it.

“He says you asked him for a ride to Paradise Beach,” Holloway continued. “He panicked when he discovered what you were carrying.”

Reck heard D-Low inside the car.

You don’t open it.

You don’t ask the man receiving it what’s inside.

Family had brought him into The Sunshine. Family was now trying to bury him beneath it.

“You want to tell me your version?” Holloway asked.

Reck leaned back.

“I want a lawyer.”

Holloway gathered the photographs.

“That is the smartest decision you’ve made all night.”

At the door, she stopped.

“One more thing. That envelope police took from you? The bills were recorded. King K’s people used money from a controlled operation. So whatever story he tells about helping your mother, understand this: he handed you evidence.”

She left Reck alone with that information.

• • •

By early afternoon, four of the Ridge Boyz were released to their families while investigators continued processing evidence.



Zay's mother drove away without looking at any of them. Mari's uncle cursed from the parking lot. TJ's mother held him so tightly that his face disappeared against her hospital scrubs.

Naz waited alone near the courthouse steps.

Reck emerged last.

Shanice stood beside Amaya's car wearing her hotel uniform. Her shoulder-length locs were tied behind her head. Exhaustion and anger had hollowed her round face.

She looked at the torn shirt, the dried blood and the plastic bag containing his wet shoes.

"Kareem," she said.

He could face Mon, King K and a police helicopter without lowering his eyes.

He could not look at his mother.

"Get in the car."

Nobody spoke during the drive home.

When they entered Sunridge, every corner seemed to know Reck had returned. People pointed from Sunridge Plaza. Children rode bicycles beside the car. Someone had already printed a blurry image from the chase and placed the words **RECK REALLY LIKE THAT** across it.

Shanice saw it too.

"They celebrating," she said quietly. "Because they don't have to live with what happens to you."

Reck stared through the window.

At Building 17, the Ridge Boyz were waiting.

Again.

Shanice parked but kept the doors locked.

“Those boys love you,” she said. “That means you can save every one of them or destroy every one of them. You decide which kind of leader you want to be.”

She unlocked the doors.

Reck stepped out.

Mari met him with a grin. “Nobody said nothing.”

TJ lifted his chin proudly. “Nobody.”

Zay looked at Reck. “What did they show you?”

Reck’s eyes moved toward The Sunshine.

D-Low stood on the porch speaking with Mon.

“My cousin told police the bag was mine.”

Mari’s grin vanished.

TJ stared across the parking lot.

Zay exhaled slowly.

Naz nodded once, as if a suspicion had just become fact.

“What we doing?” Mari asked.

Reck watched D-Low laugh at something Mon said.

Hours earlier, Reck had been prepared to accept his share of the loss. He had been prepared to work, repay the debt and stand in King K’s office without bending.

That was before family placed his freedom on the table to protect itself.

“Nothing yet,” Reck said.

Mari looked disappointed. “Nothing?”

Reck turned toward his crew.

“Being loud got King K watching me. Being reckless got police watching me. Now we move smart.”

Naz’s expression changed first. Approval.

“We find out what D-Low told King K,” Reck continued. “We find out what he told police. We find out who really put that bag together and why the money King K gave me was already marked.”

Zay studied him. “Then what?”

Reck looked back at The Sunshine.

D-Low noticed him watching.

The cousins held each other’s gaze across the parking lot.

“Then,” Reck said, “we decide who started the war.”

• • •

# FAMILY DEBT

King K gave D-Low until sunset.

The message arrived before breakfast through Mon, who found him sitting alone inside The Sunshine with the security monitors glowing against his face.

Nobody else was working.

The folding tables had been cleared. The waiting room was empty. King K had shut down the duplex before police could raid it, and every hour it remained closed cost money.

Mon entered without knocking.

“Get up.”

D-Low remained in the chair. His gold-framed glasses rested on the table beside him. Without them, the exhaustion around his eyes made him look older than twenty-five.

“I’m working on it.”

“You got twelve hours.”

“King K know I can’t replace all that in twelve hours.”

Mon stepped close. “He knows.”

D-Low looked toward the dead security screens.

“And after twelve hours?”

“You know.”

Mon picked up the glasses and crushed them beneath his boot.

“You blamed a child for your bag,” he said. “Now you hiding inside a house King K owns, asking what happens when time runs out.”

D-Low stared at the broken gold frames.

“Reck ain’t no child.”

“Then you created another problem.”

Mon walked out.

D-Low waited until the reinforced door closed before removing a small prepaid phone from beneath the seat.

He dialed a number he had promised never to use.

A man answered after one ring.

“You got my property?”

D-Low looked toward the front windows.

“Police got it.”

Silence.

“Then why are you calling me?”

“Because King K set us both up.”

• • •

At noon, Reck stood outside Sunridge Plaza wearing a fresh black tracksuit, gold chains and brand-new sneakers purchased with part of King K’s envelope.

Shanice had refused the money.

She found it on the kitchen table, counted enough to understand where it came from and pushed it back against Reck’s chest.

“I would rather sleep in my car than let the streets pay my rent with you,” she told him.

Reck kept the envelope anyway.

In The Ridge, looking defeated invited people to participate in your defeat. So he dressed as if the chase, arrest and interrogation had improved his life.

Mari leaned against the plaza wall beside him, short and broad in an orange football jersey. Zay stood near the curb wearing blue basketball warmups. TJ sat on the hood of an abandoned car in a purple shirt, while Naz remained beneath the laundromat awning in forest green and charcoal.

Five different faces.

Five different styles.

One gathering that had drawn the attention of the entire plaza.

“There he go,” TJ said.

D-Low crossed the parking lot alone.

His usual glasses were missing. A bruise darkened one side of his face. People stepped away as he approached, sensing that whatever happened next belonged to the whole neighborhood.

Reck met him in front of Lena’s Kitchen.

“You told police that bag was mine.”

D-Low looked at the crowd gathering behind them. “We need to talk somewhere private.”

“You blamed me in private. Explain it in public.”

“Reck—”

“My name was Kareem when you asked me to get in that car. Then police came, and suddenly I was Reck again.”

Mari moved closer. Zay remained still, but his presence closed one side of the parking lot. TJ recorded with his phone held low. Naz watched the black SUV idling across Paradise Boulevard.

D-Low lowered his voice. “King K told me what to say.”

The words quieted the plaza.

Reck’s expression hardened. “Say it louder.”

“King K told me to put the bag on you.”

Across the street, the black SUV’s headlights came on.

Naz saw them first.

“We need to move.”

Reck ignored him. “Why?”

D-Low looked over his shoulder. “Because that delivery was never supposed to arrive.”

The SUV jumped from the curb.

Its rear window lowered.

Naz shouted, “Down!”

Gunfire ripped across Sunridge Plaza.

Storefront glass exploded. People dropped shopping bags and ran. Reck hit the pavement as bullets chewed through the wall above him. Mari tackled TJ behind the abandoned car. Zay pulled an elderly woman into Lena’s Kitchen. Naz disappeared behind a concrete planter as the black SUV rolled through the lot.

D-Low drew a handgun and fired toward it.

The SUV swerved but did not stop shooting.

Reck crawled behind a parked sedan. Glass rained over his back. A bullet struck the hood inches above his head, leaving a smoking hole in the metal.

The SUV accelerated toward Paradise Boulevard.

D-Low kept firing until it disappeared between traffic.

Then silence arrived all at once.

A car alarm wailed. Someone screamed inside the beauty shop. Water poured from a shattered pipe above the laundromat. Lena Price stood in her doorway with one hand pressed against her shoulder, blood spreading through her yellow blouse.

Zay caught her before she fell.

“Call an ambulance!” he shouted.

TJ stared at the blood, frozen.

Mari grabbed his face. “Look at me. You hit?”

TJ shook his head.

Naz came from behind the planter. A thin cut crossed his forehead, but his voice remained calm.

“Police will be here in minutes.”

Reck rose from behind the sedan.

His black tracksuit was gray with dust. The flashy smile he wore before D-Low arrived had vanished.

“That was Mon?” he asked.

D-Low tucked the gun beneath his shirt. “One of his trucks.”

“King K shot up his own plaza?” Mari asked.

“He don’t own this one,” D-Low replied. “And he wasn’t shooting at the plaza.”

He looked at Reck.

“He was shooting at us.”

Sirens rose in the distance.

D-Low grabbed Reck’s arm. “You want the truth? Come with me now.”

Reck pulled free. “I’m not getting in another car with you.”

“Then stay and let Mon circle back.”

Mari stepped beside Reck. “Where we going?”

D-Low looked at all four Ridge Boyz.

“This ain’t for them.”

Reck answered without hesitation. “Then it ain’t for me.”

D-Low looked toward the approaching lights.

“Fine. All of you.”



...

They crossed Sunridge through back streets and canal paths, avoiding the patrol cars flooding Paradise Boulevard.

D-Low led them beyond Cypress Bottom to an abandoned boatyard near the western marshes. Rusted fishing vessels leaned against broken stands. Tall grass moved around empty trailers. Beyond the property, dark water stretched toward the Gulf beneath a sky heavy with afternoon storms.

“Who we meeting?” Naz asked.

D-Low kept walking. “A man King K don’t want Reck to know exists.”

They entered a corrugated-metal warehouse.

Three black luxury SUVs waited inside.

Men stood around them wearing clean linen shirts, dark pants and no visible jewelry. They did not look like Sunridge hustlers. They looked organized, disciplined and completely comfortable inside a place nobody else knew was operating.

A tall man stepped from behind the center vehicle.

He was in his mid-thirties, dark-skinned and lean, with a close-cropped beard and a pale burn scar climbing the left side of his neck. A cream linen shirt hung open at the collar. On one wrist sat a plain black watch worth more than every car in the Back Court parking lot.

His name was Marcellus Baptiste.

Palm Haven knew him as **Cell**.

Cell looked past D-Low and studied Reck.

“Kareem Dawson Jr.”

Reck disliked how easily powerful strangers knew his government name.

“People call me Reck.”

“Your father called you Little Reem.”

The warehouse became still.

Reck stepped forward. “You knew my father?”

Cell smiled faintly. “Before prison. Before King K owned a car wash. Before D-Low learned how expensive fear could become.”

D-Low lowered his eyes.

Cell motioned toward the SUVs. One of his men opened the rear of the center vehicle.

Inside were sealed cases.

Enough product to change the balance of Sunridge Gardens.

Mari stared openly. TJ tried not to. Zay looked toward the exits. Naz watched Cell instead of the cargo.

Reck kept his attention on the man’s face.

“What this got to do with the bag?”

Cell walked closer.

“The Paradise Beach shipment belonged to me. King K claimed Harbor View robbed one of his trap houses and told me he needed enough weight to answer. I gave him a smaller shipment as a test.”

“A test he put in my lap.”

“Yes.”

“Why was the money marked?”

Cell looked toward D-Low.

D-Low removed the broken remains of his glasses from his pocket and placed them on a workbench.

“Because King K has been feeding police controlled money,” he said. “He points them toward whoever he wants removed.”

Reck stared at him. “You knew?”

“Not until after the chase.”

“That what you called somebody to say?” Naz asked.

D-Low looked at him. “How you know I called anybody?”

“Because scared men don’t wait for deadlines. They look for another boss.”

Cell’s faint smile returned.

“Keep the quiet one close,” he told Reck.

Zay crossed his arms. “If King K wanted Reck arrested, why send D-Low in the same car?”

“Because D-Low had become a liability,” Cell replied. “King K removed two problems with one bag.”

D-Low’s face tightened.

Reck thought about King K sitting calmly behind the desk.

Because nobody looking for you yet.

He had mistaken those words for opportunity.

They had been a sentence.

“King K planned the traffic stop?” Reck asked.

“A corrupt officer was supposed to recover the bag quietly,” Cell said. “D-Low running turned a controlled seizure into a citywide spectacle.”

The plot twist rearranged everything Reck believed about that night. The invitation, the envelope, the route, the police waiting near Paradise Beach—none of it had been chance.

He had never been recruited.

He had been selected to fall.

Gunfire struck the warehouse doors.

Metal sparked inward.

Cell’s men moved immediately. One pulled him behind an SUV. Another killed the warehouse lights. Darkness swallowed the room as more shots tore through the walls.

“Mon followed us!” D-Low shouted.

“Everybody down!” Zay pulled TJ behind a rusted engine block.

Mari crouched beside Reck. “This what you call moving smart?”

“Not right now, Mari.”

The main door rattled beneath an impact. Headlights appeared through gaps in the metal.

Cell’s people returned fire from cover. The sound became deafening inside the warehouse. Glass burst from one SUV. A tire collapsed. Bullets punched white holes through the corrugated walls.

D-Low moved toward a side exit.

Reck grabbed his jersey. “Where you going?”

“To draw them away.”

“Or leave us again?”

D-Low looked at his cousin.

“You can hate me if we live.”

He pushed through the side door.

Seconds later, a car engine roared outside. Gunfire shifted toward it.

Cell appeared beside Reck, calm even as bullets struck the SUV behind them.

“Your cousin just purchased us time,” he said.

“He still owe me.”

“Survival keeps accounts open.”

One of Cell’s men shouted that the marsh exit was clear.

The Ridge Boyz followed him through a rear passage and into tall grass behind the warehouse. Zay kept TJ in front of him. Mari stayed shoulder to shoulder with Reck. Naz looked back once, memorizing the vehicles entering the boatyard.

Mon stepped from the lead truck with a rifle in his hands.

Naz saw him.

Mon saw Naz.

That single glance confirmed the war more clearly than any declaration could.

The Ridge Boyz reached an airboat hidden beside the marsh. Cell climbed aboard with them while his remaining men covered the retreat.

The engine thundered.

The boat shot across the shallow water as black smoke rose from the warehouse behind them.

Reck watched flames appear along the roof. Somewhere beyond the fire, D-Low was either escaping, captured or dead.

Nobody knew.

Cell stood beside Reck as the Florida marsh opened ahead.

“King K tried to erase you,” he said. “Now you have a decision.”

Reck looked toward his friends.

Mari’s orange jersey was torn. Blood from Naz’s forehead marked his charcoal hoodie. TJ’s freckles had disappeared beneath dirt. Zay remained alert, protecting the youngest even while watching Cell. Every one of them had followed Reck into a war they had not started.

But they had chosen to stay.

“What decision?” Reck asked.

Cell pointed back toward the burning warehouse.

“You can spend your life running from men who already decided you are disposable.”

Then he pointed toward the distant Palm Haven skyline.

“Or I can boss you up.”

Reck looked at him.

“Why would you do that?”

Cell's burn scar caught the orange light from the fire.

"Because King K stole from me. Because your father once saved my life. And because Sunridge is about to choose a new leader whether King K accepts it or not."

Reck felt the entire future of The Ridge shifting beneath him.

"What you want in return?"

Cell smiled.

"Everything King K thinks belongs to him."

• • •

## BOSSSED UP

The airboat carried them deep into the marsh.

Palm Haven disappeared behind walls of sawgrass and black water. The fire at the boatyard became an orange stain beneath the clouds, then vanished completely.

Cell stood near the front with one hand resting against the rail. He had not raised his voice during the attack. He had not asked whether his warehouse, vehicles or product could be saved.

He watched Reck instead.

“Do you want enough money to survive,” Cell asked, “or enough power to take The Ridge?”

The airboat engine thundered beneath them.

Reck thought about the eviction notice hidden in Shanice’s bedroom. He thought about King K’s marked money, Mon’s gunfire crossing Sunridge Plaza and D-Low disappearing behind the burning warehouse.

Survival had kept his family in Building 17.

Power could change who owned the building.

“I want The Ridge,” Reck said.

Cell nodded once. “Then understand something. A package makes you a hustler. Fear might make you dangerous. Neither makes you a boss.”

“What does?”

“People choosing your order when another man is threatening them.”

Reck looked at his crew.

Mari grinned first. “They gon’ choose us.”

Zay did not share the excitement. “People get to choose, or we force them?”

Cell studied the tall athlete. “Good question.”

Reck answered before he could. “King K uses fear. We give them a better reason.”

Naz wiped blood from the cut on his forehead. “And if they don’t want either side?”

“Then they stay out of it,” Reck said.

Cell’s expression revealed nothing, but something in his eyes approved.

TJ looked back toward the lost shoreline. “What about D-Low?”

Nobody answered.

• • •

Cell’s safe house sat on a private piece of land beyond the marsh, hidden behind cypress trees and a hurricane-damaged citrus farm.

From the outside, it looked abandoned. Inside the main barn were polished concrete floors, surveillance screens and vehicles covered beneath black fabric.

Cell gave the Ridge Boyz dry clothes, food and a room to sleep in.

Reck did not sleep.

He stood before a wall-sized map of Palm Haven marked with neighborhoods, businesses and colored lines. Sunridge Gardens occupied a small section on the west side. Paradise Beach glowed along the coast. Harbor View Courts sat across the canal like an open challenge.

Naz entered wearing a forest-green shirt and dark jeans. A bandage crossed his forehead beneath the front of his cornrows.

“You believe him?” Naz asked.



“About King K?”

“About any of it.”

Reck stared at the map. “I believe King K tried to bury me.”

“That doesn’t make Cell honest.”

“He don’t have to be honest.”

“Then what does he have to be?”

Reck pointed toward Sunridge.

“Useful.”

Naz stepped closer. “And what are we to him?”

Reck did not answer.

That was the question he had been avoiding.

Cell entered behind them. His cream linen shirt had been replaced with a fitted black one that exposed more of the burn scar along his neck.

“Your friend sees the entire board,” he said.

Naz turned. “And you see pieces.”

“Everybody with power does.”

“Where’s Reck’s father fit on your board?”

For the first time, Cell’s calm expression changed.

Only slightly.

“Ask Reem when he calls from prison.”

Cell placed a key ring on the table.

“Come outside.”

• • •

Morning sunlight filled the barnyard.

The black covers had been removed from two vehicles: a midnight-black Chevrolet Tahoe and a pearl-white Dodge Durango. Both had tinted windows and clean interiors.

Mari circled the Durango with his mouth open.

“This ours?”

“They belong to me,” Cell said. “You have permission to use them.”

“Same thing for today.”

Zay leaned against the Tahoe, unimpressed. His royal-blue warmup jacket fit his long frame. “Cars don’t make us ready.”

“Correct,” Cell replied.

TJ emerged wearing a new purple-and-gray outfit, colorful sneakers and a crossbody bag. The clothes fit him properly instead of hanging from his slim body, but his freckles and full Afro still made him look like the youngest.

“What make us ready?” he asked.

Cell looked toward Reck.

“Leadership.”

Two men carried black cases from the barn and placed them on a folding table.

Inside the first were five custom pendants.

Each featured the cracked apartment crown above an interlocking **RB**, backed by a Florida sunset and small green palm trees. The emblem was the same, but the chains were not.

Reck’s was heavy yellow gold.

Mari’s had orange stones around the border.

Zay’s was white gold with royal-blue details.

TJ’s smaller pendant carried purple stones.

Naz’s used darkened metal with a single forest-green palm.

Five members.

Five identities.

One symbol.

Cell handed Reck the gold pendant last.

“Jewelry makes people look,” he said. “What you do after they look becomes your reputation.”

Reck fastened it around his neck. The cracked crown rested above his chains.

For the first time, the Ridge Boyz looked official.

The second case contained money and sealed packages.

The excitement disappeared from Zay’s face.

Cell closed the case before TJ could stare too long.

“This is not a gift,” he said. “It is an investment. If you lose it, you owe me. If police take it, you owe me. If somebody close to you steals it, you still owe me.”

Reck met his eyes. “We heard this speech before.”

“Then learn from the last ending.”

Cell pushed the case toward him.

“King K’s people abandoned three locations after the car-wash raid. One is The Sunshine.”

Reck looked toward the others.

“That’s our first move.”

Cell shook his head. “No. Your first move is deciding who you are before you return.”

Reck faced his friends.

“Mari, you with me when it gets loud.”

Mari smiled. “Always.”

“Zay, you keep everybody thinking before we move.”

Zay crossed his arms. “Including you.”

“Especially me.”

“TJ, you see everything moving through the neighborhood. But no posting and no chasing attention.”

TJ nodded seriously. “I got it.”

“Naz, you watch the money, information and everybody claiming they loyal.”

Naz adjusted his glasses. “Who watches you?”

Reck looked across all four faces.

“All of y’all.”

That answer mattered.

Cell watched from beside the table as the Ridge Boyz placed their hands together over the open case.

“Built by the Ridge,” Reck said.

“Built by the Ridge,” the others answered.

• • •

The two SUVs entered Sunridge Gardens shortly after noon.

Music shook the pearl-white Durango as Mari drove through Sunridge Plaza with the windows lowered. His gold grill flashed while he laughed at the people turning to look. TJ sat beside him filming the neighborhood—but not posting—while the purple stones in his pendant caught sunlight.

The black Tahoe followed.

Zay drove. His long twists rested against his blue jacket. Naz sat in the passenger seat wearing charcoal and green. Reck occupied the back alone, dressed in black and gold with the cracked crown resting against his chest.

They passed Lena's Kitchen.

Plywood covered the shattered windows. Flowers, candles and handwritten cards surrounded the doorway. Ms. Lena had survived surgery, but she remained in the hospital.

Reck's excitement cooled.

The war already had an innocent victim.

Then they reached The Sunshine.

C-Mack stood on the porch with six men.

King K had not abandoned the duplex. He had placed C-Mack there to hold it.

Residents emerged from apartments as the SUVs stopped in the parking lot. Children gathered near the Back Court. Phones appeared along second-floor railings.

Reck stepped from the Tahoe.

The neighborhood reacted to the pendant, the clothes and the vehicles before he said a word.

Mari parked the Durango sideways and joined him. Zay came around the Tahoe. TJ remained close to Mari. Naz stood slightly behind Reck, studying the porch and every window around it.

C-Mack smiled through his swollen cheek.

"Cell bought y'all costumes?"

Reck walked toward the steps.

"The Sunshine closed."

"Look open to me."

"Then you ain't hear me."

C-Mack came down one step. "Mon said nobody wearing that little pendant stands on King K's property."

“Mrs. Green raised her family in this house before King K ever touched it,” Reck said loudly. “He don’t own The Ridge because he put a lock on somebody else’s door.”

People murmured across the parking lot.

C-Mack looked at the audience and realized Reck was doing it again—turning confrontation into performance.

“You got until I count to three,” C-Mack said.

Mari laughed. “You ain’t even finish counting points yesterday.”

C-Mack rushed from the porch.

He swung at Reck.

Reck slipped the punch and drove him against the railing. The six men behind C-Mack moved at once. Mari crashed into the first with his broad shoulder. Zay intercepted another, using his long frame to throw him away from TJ. Naz pulled the youngest boy behind a parked car as the fight spread across the yard.

Residents shouted from the balconies.

Reck and C-Mack rolled down the porch steps. C-Mack struck Reck across the jaw, but Reck came back harder, fueled by the traffic stop, D-Low’s betrayal and Mon’s bullets crossing the plaza.

He hit C-Mack until the older boy stopped fighting back.

“Reck!” Zay shouted.

Reck raised his fist again.

Zay grabbed his wrist.

“You won.”

For one dangerous second, Reck considered striking his own friend.

Then he saw Kobe near the Back Court.

His eleven-year-old brother stood beside a bicycle, round glasses reflecting the crowd. He was watching Reck the way he watched superheroes in his own drawings.

Reck lowered his hand.

C-Mack coughed on the pavement.

The remaining men stepped away. Mari's orange jersey had torn at the shoulder. Zay's lip was split. TJ was unharmed. Naz had never entered the center of the fight, but he had recorded every person who came to support C-Mack and every person who quietly walked away.

Reck climbed onto The Sunshine's porch.

He removed King K's old lock from the broken door and threw it into the yard.

"The Sunshine closed," he announced. "Nobody sells out this house. Nobody from King K's crew works on this side of Garden Courts. This building belongs to The Ridge now."

An older woman on the balcony shouted, "What you turning it into?"

Reck looked through the doorway at the ruined rooms.

He could reopen the same trap house beneath a new name and become a younger copy of King K.

Or he could make the building mean something larger.

"Our headquarters," he said. "And the front stays clean."

Naz looked at him sharply.

That had not been discussed.

Neither had the next declaration.

"Anybody in Building 17 who need groceries, school clothes or rent help comes here," Reck continued. "King K made money off The Ridge. We putting money back into it."

The crowd reacted.

Some cheered. Others exchanged skeptical looks. Older residents had heard promises from young men wearing new jewelry before.

Cell's lesson returned to Reck.

People choosing your order when another man is threatening them.

Reck turned toward the Ridge Boyz.

“Take his sign down.”

Mari and TJ pulled the small King’s Car Wash sticker from the front window. Zay helped C-Mack stand and pushed him toward the parking lot.

Naz joined Reck on the porch.

“That community promise costs money,” he said quietly.

“Then we make money.”

“Cell expects his first.”

“He’ll get it.”

“And if King K comes tonight?”

Reck looked across Garden Courts.

More residents were standing beside the Ridge Boyz than C-Mack now.

“Then he finds out who The Ridge chose.”

• • •

Across town, King K watched the takeover on three different phones.

He sat inside a private room above the Emerald Lounge with Bree beside him and Mon pacing near the bar.

On one screen, Reck stood on The Sunshine porch wearing Cell’s cracked crown.

On another, C-Mack lay beaten in the parking lot.

On the third, comments and reposts multiplied beneath the words:

**RECK TOOK THE SUNSHINE.**

Mon slammed his fist against the bar.

“Let me finish this tonight.”



King K watched Reck promise groceries and rent help to Sunridge residents.

“No,” he said.

“He just took your house.”

“He took a building.”

Bree looked at King K. “He took the crowd.”

That was the part King K understood.

He set the phones facedown.

“Where does his mother work?”

Mon stopped pacing.

Bree’s expression hardened. “Family wasn’t part of this.”

“Family became part of it when Cell put Reem’s son against me.”

King K looked toward Mon.

“Don’t touch her. Make sure Kareem understands we can.”

Mon smiled.

...

Night fell over The Sunshine.

The Ridge Boyz cleaned the house while music played from the porch. Mari dragged ruined furniture outside. Zay repaired the basketball hoop behind the building. TJ painted the first orange line of a new **RB** emblem across a plywood wall. Naz sat at a folding table with a notebook, counting every dollar from Cell’s case twice.

Reck stood in the upstairs bedroom overlooking Garden Courts.

His phone was gone, so Cell had given him a new one.

It rang from a blocked number.

Reck answered. “Who this?”

For several seconds, he heard only breathing.

Then D-Low spoke.

“Mon got your mama followed.”

Reck gripped the phone.

“Where are you?”

“That don’t matter.”

“You alive because I ain’t decided what you owe me yet.”

D-Low coughed painfully.

“Listen. King K ain’t the biggest problem.”

“You said that before the boatyard got shot up.”

“Cell knew Mon was coming.”

Reck became still.

Downstairs, the Ridge Boyz laughed while painting their new emblem.

“What did you say?”

“Cell knew we were followed,” D-Low whispered. “He let Mon attack that warehouse because he needed you to see King K as the enemy—and him as the man who saved you.”

The call ended.

Reck stood alone in the dark bedroom, looking over the neighborhood he had just claimed.

King K wanted to control him.

Cell wanted to build him.

And D-Low wanted him to trust nobody.

Below the window, headlights entered Garden Courts.

Not one car.

Ten.

...

# TEN CARS

The headlights filled Garden Courts.

Ten vehicles rolled through Sunridge Gardens in two slow lines—black sedans, dark SUVs and a gray pickup with its lights switched off. They stopped around The Sunshine until every street, parking-lot exit and path toward the Back Court appeared blocked.

Music died on the porch.

TJ lowered his paintbrush.

Mari stepped toward the front window. “That King K?”

Naz pulled him away from the glass. “It’s everybody.”

Reck came downstairs holding the new phone against his ear. D-Low’s warning still burned through him.

Mon got your mama followed.

Cell knew we were followed.

Outside, doors opened.

C-Mack emerged from the lead SUV with a bandage crossing his nose. Mon stepped from the vehicle behind him. More men spread across the parking lot while residents retreated from balconies and pulled children inside.

Mon looked toward the upstairs window.

“Kareem!”

Reck opened the front door.

Zay caught his shoulder. “Don’t walk out there.”

“This our house.”

“A house ain’t worth dying over.”

Reck looked at him. “It ain’t about the house anymore.”

He stepped onto the porch with the four Ridge Boyz behind him.

Their new pendants caught the headlights: Reck’s gold, Mari’s orange border, Zay’s royal blue, TJ’s purple and Naz’s dark metal with the single green palm.

Mon smiled at the display.

“Cell dressed his children.”

Reck searched the vehicles. One carried a small Harbor View decal beneath its rear window.

Naz leaned close. “The gray pickup. That ain’t King K.”

Harbor View had come to watch Sunridge fall—or help push it.

“Where my mother at?” Reck asked.

“Hotel,” Mon replied. “For now.”

Every muscle in Reck’s body tightened.

“You follow my family again, I’m killing everybody you love.”

“Big promise for somebody surrounded.”

Mon raised one hand.

C-Mack and six men approached the porch.

“Walk away from the house,” Mon said. “Leave Cell’s package, vehicles and jewelry. King K might let your friends go home.”

Mari laughed without humor. “Might?”

Reck descended one step.

“Tell King K if he wants The Sunshine, come get it himself.”

C-Mack drew a pistol.

The first shot struck the porch railing.

The Ridge Boyz dropped.

Then Garden Courts exploded.

Gunfire crossed the parking lot from multiple directions. Windows burst inward. Bullets punched through The Sunshine's yellow walls. Reck crawled behind the brick foundation while Mari dragged TJ through the doorway. Zay pulled Naz behind an overturned table.

People screamed throughout the apartments.

"Back exit!" Zay shouted.

"They got it blocked," Naz replied.

Reck looked through a hole in the railing. C-Mack was advancing between parked cars while Mon directed men from behind the lead SUV.

The gray Harbor View pickup remained near the court.

Its occupants were not shooting at The Sunshine.

They were firing into the air and across empty vehicles, making the attack appear larger while waiting to see who survived.

"Harbor View playing both sides," Naz said.

A bottle trailing fire struck the porch.

Flames rolled across the steps.

Smoke filled the front room. TJ froze beside the painted plywood emblem, staring as orange fire consumed the green palm trees.

"Move!" Mari shoved him toward the kitchen.

Another round tore through the wall.

Mari jerked backward.

TJ screamed.

Blood spread across Mari's orange jersey near the shoulder.

"I'm good," Mari said through clenched teeth. "It went through."

Zay grabbed him beneath the uninjured arm and pulled him toward the hallway. Reck remained near the porch, watching C-Mack reach the burning steps.

The front door kicked inward.

C-Mack entered through smoke with his pistol raised.

He saw Reck.

Mari saw him first.

The shot came from Mari's hand.

C-Mack stopped in the doorway. His weapon fell. He collapsed across the cracked apartment crown painted on the floor.

Mari stared at him.

The wild smile was gone.

TJ looked from the body to Mari's face.

Neither boy spoke.

Outside, a vehicle crashed through the rear fence.

A faded green Buick struck one of Mon's men and stopped beside the kitchen door. D-Low climbed out with blood soaking the side of his shirt.

"Get in!"

Reck stared at him. "Where you been?"

"Dying. We can talk later."

D-Low fired toward the parking lot. Zay pushed TJ into the back seat. Naz climbed beside him. Mari stumbled toward the car while pressing one hand against his wounded shoulder.

Reck remained in the doorway.

"My family."

"Cell got people heading to the hotel," D-Low said. "Move!"

That answer made Reck trust Cell less, not more.

He climbed into the Buick anyway.

D-Low accelerated through the broken fence as Mon's men turned toward them. Bullets shattered the rear window. Zay covered TJ with his body. Naz pulled Mari down against the floor.

The Buick reached the Back Court.

The gray Harbor View pickup moved to block them.

D-Low did not slow.

He struck its front end hard enough to spin both vehicles. Metal folded. The Buick's airbags exploded. Reck's head hit the door.

For several seconds, the world became white powder, ringing ears and distant shouting.

Then D-Low opened his door.

"Run to the canal!"

The Ridge Boyz spilled from the wreck.

Men climbed from the Harbor View pickup. One fired toward Zay and TJ. D-Low returned fire, forcing them behind the truck.

Reck grabbed Mari's good arm and helped him toward the fence.

"Go!" D-Low shouted.

"You coming!"

"I'm behind you."

Reck knew the sentence was a lie.

Mon appeared beside the basketball court.

D-Low saw him.

The cousins exchanged one final look.

"I did you wrong," D-Low said. "But I ain't letting them bury you for it."

Gunfire swallowed the rest.



D-Low's body turned beneath the impact. He remained standing long enough to fire back, then collapsed beside the faded free-throw line.

Reck stopped running.

Zay wrapped both arms around him and dragged him toward the canal.

"He gave us time!" Zay shouted. "Don't waste it!"

Reck fought him until he saw Mon approaching D-Low's body.

Mon looked up across the court.

Reck pointed at him.

No words crossed the distance, but the promise did.

Then the Ridge Boyz disappeared into the canal path.

...

Police arrived eleven minutes after the first emergency call.

By then, The Sunshine was burning.

C-Mack lay dead inside the doorway. Two of Mon's men were found in the parking lot. D-Low died beneath the broken streetlight at the Back Court.

A seventeen-year-old Sunridge resident named Andre "Dreko" Mills was found near Building 16. He had been walking home from work when the shooting began. He had no weapon, no crew affiliation and no connection to King K or the Ridge Boyz.

Four bodies were covered before sunrise.

Detective Holloway stood beside D-Low and looked toward the canal.

Reck's gold chain lay in the dirt near the fence.

She placed it into an evidence bag herself.

...

Cell hid the Ridge Boyz inside an empty vacation house north of Palm Haven.

Mari sat at the kitchen table while one of Cell's people wrapped his shoulder. The bullet had passed through cleanly, but the blood covering his orange jersey belonged partly to him and partly to C-Mack.

He had not spoken since the Back Court.

TJ sat on the floor with his purple pendant clutched in one hand. His phone played the same three seconds repeatedly: fire spreading across The Sunshine, a gunshot and the camera falling sideways.

Zay took it from him and shut it off.

"You don't need to keep watching."

"I see it when I close my eyes."

Naz stood at the window, bandage still crossing his forehead. "Harbor View was there."

Cell entered the room. "I know."

Reck came from the hallway wearing a plain black shirt. Smoke stained his face. D-Low's blood covered one side of his jeans.

"Did you know Mon was coming to the boatyard?" he asked Cell.

Cell did not answer immediately.

That was enough.

Reck walked toward him. Two of Cell's men moved, but Cell raised his hand.

"I knew King K was watching D-Low," Cell said. "I did not know when Mon would move."

"You let us walk into it."

"And I got you out."

Reck shoved him.

The room froze.

Cell looked down at Reck's hands, then back at his face.

"Do that again when you are ready to finish what it starts."

Reck did not apologize.

"D-Low dead. C-Mack dead. A neighborhood kid dead. Mari shot. My family being hunted. I'm finished waiting on grown men to decide when I can move."

He turned toward the Ridge Boyz.

Mari finally raised his head.

Zay stood beside TJ.

Naz left the window.

Reck's voice filled the room.

"They got me messed up. I gave everybody a chance to leave me and my family alone. They shot up our neighborhood, came at my mama's house, killed my blood and thought I was supposed to hide."

His fists tightened.

"I'm done talking."

Cell watched without interrupting.

"I want everybody connected to this found. King K, Mon, C-Mack's people, Harbor View—everybody. We taking their money, their cars, their jewelry and every block they think belongs to them. I don't care what their name is or who backing them."

Zay stepped forward. "People responsible. Not families. Not random people."

Naz nodded. "And no moving angry without knowing who we hitting."

Reck looked at them both.

For a moment, rage argued with reason.

Then Reck agreed.

"Only the ones in it."

Mari stood despite his wounded shoulder.

“C-Mack was my first,” he said. His dimples did not appear. “He ain’t gon’ be the reason I quit.”

TJ rose from the floor. He was shaking, but he put the purple pendant back around his neck.

“Nobody talks,” he said.

“Nobody runs,” Mari added.

Zay looked at Reck. “Nobody moves alone.”

Naz finished it. “And nobody controls us.”

That last line was for Cell.

Reck reached into his pocket and placed D-Low’s broken gold glasses on the table.

“They wanted to know who Reck was,” he said.

Outside, thunder rolled over Florida.

“Now I’m about to show them.”

• • •

# LA MADRINA

The black vans arrived before sunrise.

Four masked drivers entered Cell's vacation property without triggering an alarm. They disabled the outside cameras, surrounded the house and knocked once on the front door.

Cell's men reached for weapons.

Naz looked through an upstairs window and saw a silver wave painted beside a green crown on the lead van.

"Mar Azul," he said.

Cell's face changed.

Reck noticed.

"You know them?"

"They have no business here."

The front door opened before Cell gave permission.

A tall man in a gray suit entered with empty hands visible. His shaved head carried a thin scar from his left temple to his ear. Behind him stood six disciplined figures dressed in black.

"Kareem Dawson," the suited man said. "La Madrina requests a meeting."

Cell stepped between him and Reck. "The boy is under my protection."

"That protection burned down twice in forty-eight hours."

Mari rose from the kitchen table with his wounded arm in a sling. Zay moved beside TJ. Naz remained near Reck.

The suited man looked across all five pendants.

“The invitation includes the Ridge Boyz.”

Reck turned toward Cell. “You said Mar Azul was finished in Palm Haven.”

“They are.”

The man smiled. “Then declining should be easy.”

Reck walked toward the door.

Cell caught his arm. “If you leave with them, our agreement changes.”

Reck looked down at Cell’s hand.

“We never had an agreement. You had a plan.”

Cell released him.

The Ridge Boyz entered the vans together.

• • •

They were blindfolded after leaving the property.

The ride lasted nearly an hour. Reck counted turns until Naz quietly told him to stop wasting his time. The vans traveled over a bridge, through a security gate and finally across a long gravel drive.

When the blindfolds came off, they stood inside a coastal mansion overlooking the Gulf.

White stone terraces descended toward a private marina. Tropical gardens surrounded an infinity pool. Original paintings covered the walls. Nothing about the home felt temporary or hidden.

The cartel did not merely operate in Florida.

It lived comfortably inside it.

Camila Vélez waited on the rear terrace wearing a perfectly tailored white suit. An emerald necklace rested against her bronze-brown skin. Waist-length black hair fell across one shoulder, divided by a single silver streak. Her amber eyes moved across the boys without hurry.

“The Ridge Boyz,” she said. “You look younger in person.”

Reck approached the table. “You look richer.”

Mari tried not to smile.

La Madrina motioned toward five chairs. “Sit.”

Reck remained standing. “We don’t know you.”

“But you entered my vehicles.”

“We wanted to see where they went.”

She smiled slightly. “Your father had that same talent for turning limited options into personal decisions.”

Reck’s expression hardened. “Everybody knew my father except me.”

“Then ask better questions when he calls.”

La Madrina opened a blue folder.

Inside were photographs of King K meeting Officer Miller, the same officer who stopped D-Low’s sedan. Other images showed Mon exchanging bags with members of Harbor View. A final photograph captured Cell entering a private restaurant with Detective Holloway’s supervisor.

Reck picked it up.

“Cell police too?”

“No,” La Madrina said. “Cell purchases information. King K trades people for protection. Different arrangements. Same disease.”

Naz studied the dates. “Why show us?”

“Because all three profit from keeping Sunridge unstable.”

She pointed toward a map of western Palm Haven.

“King K controls the visible street business. Harbor View controls the canal routes. Cell supplies both sides when the price is right, then pretends their war threatens him.”

Reck remembered Cell’s burned warehouse, the conveniently prepared airboat and the waiting safe house.

“He knew Mon was coming,” he said.

“He selected the location because he knew.”

Zay leaned forward. “How do we know you ain’t doing the same thing?”

La Madrina looked at him. “You don’t.”

The answer silenced the terrace.

“Trust is an expensive word used by people trying to avoid contracts,” she continued. “I prefer shared enemies and clearly divided profits.”

Mari looked at the marina. “What kind of profits?”

Naz cut his eyes toward him.

“What?” Mari asked. “She brought it up.”

La Madrina closed the folder.

“Cell stole a coastal route from my organization. King K compromised two of my operations to strengthen his arrangement with police. Harbor View occupies access I intend to reclaim.”

She looked directly at Reck.

“I need a local organization capable of taking western Palm Haven.”

“You need soldiers,” Reck said.

“I have soldiers.”

“Then what you need us for?”

“Soldiers can enter a neighborhood. They cannot make that neighborhood choose them.”

Reck thought about the crowd outside The Sunshine.

La Madrina had been watching before he ever knew her name.

“What you offering?” he asked.

“Your family disappears into secure housing today. Attorneys begin challenging every piece of evidence against your crew. The Sunshine is



rebuilt. Your organization receives vehicles, legitimate businesses and access independent of Cell.”

TJ looked toward Reck, excitement briefly defeating fear.

Zay remained guarded. “And the price?”

“Cell, King K and Harbor View lose Palm Haven.”

“Lose how?”

La Madrina’s amber eyes remained calm. “Completely.”

Reck understood.

She was not offering to help him survive a war.

She was hiring him to finish one.

“Everybody keeps offering to make me a boss like I need permission,” Reck said. “Help us win, and we make money together. But The Ridge belongs to the Ridge Boyz.”

The cartel soldiers around the terrace watched La Madrina.

Nobody spoke to her that way.

She lifted a coffee cup and took one measured sip.

“Cell wanted to build you. King K wanted to bury you. I want to see whether you can rule.”

She placed the cup down.

“Kings who disappoint me do not receive second chances.”

Reck leaned over the table.

“Neither do connects who lie to me.”

For several seconds, the Gulf wind moved between them.

Then La Madrina extended her hand.

Reck looked toward the Ridge Boyz.

Mari nodded immediately. TJ followed. Zay looked unhappy but loyal. Naz studied the photographs one final time, then gave the smallest nod.

Reck shook her hand.

The war changed ownership.

...

La Madrina's people moved Shanice, Amaya and Kobe before noon.

Shanice fought the decision until Reck showed her photographs of Mon's men outside the Paradise Crown Resort. She packed one suitcase, held Kobe close and refused to look at the cracked-crown pendant around her son's neck.

"Every man helping you wants something," she said.

"I know."

"Do you?"

"I'm getting y'all somewhere safe."

"Safe from the danger following you."

Her words stayed with him after the armored SUV carried his family away.

Reck did not have time to feel them.

La Madrina's first piece of intelligence arrived that afternoon.

King K was moving cash from three closed locations into a private club downtown. Harbor View men would protect the transfer. Cell expected a percentage.

One movement.

All three enemies.

The Ridge Boyz waited inside a cartel garage as two covered vehicles were revealed. The first was a black Cadillac Escalade. The second was a dark-green Dodge Durango with a sunset-orange stripe.

Fresh RB emblems had been placed discreetly near the rear windows.

New clothes waited beside them.

Reck wore black and gold.

Mari kept orange across his uninjured shoulder.

Zay wore royal blue beneath a dark jacket.

TJ chose purple and gray.

Naz remained in forest green and charcoal.

They looked united without looking alike.

La Madrina entered with the tall suited man.

“This is Rafael ‘Stone’ Guerra,” she said. “He coordinates security for Mar Azul in Florida.”

Stone’s scar curved toward his ear as he looked at Reck. “Tonight, you observe. My people handle the rest.”

Reck opened the Escalade’s driver door.

“Then your people can follow us.”

Stone moved into his path.

“You agreed to an alliance, not command.”

“The money came from The Ridge. King K made it off our families. We taking it back.”

Zay sighed. “We been cartel-connected six hours and already arguing.”

Mari grinned despite the pain in his shoulder. “That might be a record.”

La Madrina looked at Stone.

“Let them lead.”

Stone stepped aside.

Naz waited until La Madrina walked away before speaking quietly.

“She wants to see which one of us breaks first.”

Reck started the Escalade.

“Then don’t break.”

...

Night covered downtown Palm Haven in neon and rain.

King K's convoy left the Emerald Lounge shortly after midnight. The money traveled inside an armored SUV with two Harbor View vehicles ahead and Cell's men behind.

They never reached the bridge.

The street erupted beneath flashing headlights and screaming tires. Vehicles collided. Men abandoned doors and scattered through the rain. Store alarms joined distant sirens as the Ridge Boyz struck the alliance holding their neighborhood hostage.

Reck saw King K's armored SUV trapped between wrecked cars.

He stepped into the rain wearing the cracked crown.

Across the intersection, Mon emerged behind a vehicle.

Their eyes met through the storm.

Mon raised his weapon.

Reck did the same.

Before either fired, a Harbor View vehicle crashed between them.

Mari shouted from the Durango. Zay pulled TJ away from the open street. Naz pointed toward the armored SUV as Stone's people surrounded it.

The money was taken.

King K's alliance broke apart in every direction.

Reck climbed onto the running board of the Escalade as it accelerated away. Behind them, Mon stood in the intersection beneath police lights, watching the Ridge Boyz escape with everything he had been ordered to protect.

Inside the SUV, black cases covered the floor.

TJ opened one.

Stacks of money filled it.

Mari laughed for the first time since killing C-Mack.

Zay looked through the shattered rear window at the approaching cruisers.

“This ain’t over.”

Reck removed King K’s diamond watch from the top of the case and fastened it around his wrist.

“It just started.”

# EVERYBODY EATS

By sunrise, King K's watch was still on Reck's wrist.

The money was no longer in the Escalade.

Naz had counted every stack twice, separated the marked bills and divided the clean cash into locked cases. La Madrina's people expected Reck to deliver everything to the mansion.

He delivered her percentage.

The rest went home.

Sunridge woke to the sound of construction at The Sunshine.

The burned windows were boarded first. Then came new glass, steel doors, security lights and crews clearing smoke-blackened furniture from the ruined car wash. Reck stood in the parking lot wearing black from his shoulders to his shoes, D-Low's memorial photograph resting against the cracked wall behind him.

Residents gathered slowly.

Some came because they were curious.

Some came because their apartments had been damaged during the siege.

Others came because everybody in Palm Haven had heard what happened downtown.

Reck raised King K's watch where they could see it.

"He made this off The Ridge," he said. "So The Ridge getting paid first."

Naz opened a folding table covered with envelopes.

Rent assistance for the families forced from Garden Courts.

Money for Ms. Lena's medical bills.

Funeral expenses for D-Low's mother.

A retainer for TJ's lawyer.

Another for Mari.

Reck placed the final envelope in Shanice's name even though his mother was hidden somewhere he had not been allowed to know.

Zay watched the crowd change.

Fear did not disappear.

It became loyalty.

"King K always took," an older man said from beside the curb.

Reck looked toward him. "We building something different."

"Different how?"

Reck pointed toward the workers rebuilding The Sunshine.

"Everybody connected to The Ridge eats. But nobody makes money here while our people starve. Nobody uses our blocks and acts like we don't exist. And nobody gets to call themselves a Ridge Boy because they bought the right color shirt."

Behind the crowd stood nearly forty young men.

Some Reck knew from childhood.

Some had appeared only after the money did.

All of them wanted the cracked crown.

Mari studied them with his wounded arm resting in a sling.

"Half of them wasn't around when ten cars pulled up."

"That's why half of them leaving without a pendant," Naz said.

Reck stepped toward the recruits.

“Anybody can stand beside us while we winning. I need to know who stays when the money gone, when the police come and when standing here costs something.”

He looked from face to face.

“The Ridge comes first. You don’t switch. You don’t steal from the crew. You don’t abandon another member. You don’t bring families or innocent people into our war. If you get caught, you stand ten toes. If you betray this crown after taking our oath, there ain’t no coming back from it.”

The parking lot went silent.

“Anybody got a problem with that,” Reck said, “leave now.”

Thirteen people walked away.

Reck respected them more than the ones who remained for the wrong reason.

The original five stood behind him—Mari in orange, Zay in blue, Naz in green, TJ in purple and gray.

They had separate faces, separate styles and separate minds.

But the crown belonged to all of them.

Reck turned toward Naz.

“Nobody joins today.”

Several recruits looked disappointed.

“They earn it,” Reck continued. “Backgrounds checked. Loyalty tested. Every founder agrees. One no means no.”

TJ smiled for the first time since the siege.

“Now everybody want to be us.”

Zay looked at the police cruiser parked across the street.

“Everybody watching us too.”

• • •



Harbor View Courts sat beside dark canal water on the western edge of Palm Haven.

That afternoon, Cell stood inside an abandoned boat-repair warehouse with Tide Mercer and the first Canal Boyz assembled around him.

Deep teal banners covered the rusted walls. A silver CB emblem rose from painted water beneath a drawbridge.

Tide wore a navy jacket and a silver chain. His long twists were tied behind his head, exposing the scar across his lower lip.

He watched Cell place a brick-sized package on the table.

“Reck got one neighborhood and started believing he owns the city,” Cell said. “La Madrina gave him supply because she wants my routes.”

“Then we cut him off from the water,” Tide replied.

Cell smiled.

Mon did not.

He stood near the warehouse door, restless and angry, with two of King K’s remaining men beside him.

“All this talking while Reck wearing King’s watch.”

Tide glanced at him. “You had him in the street and let him leave with it.”

Mon stepped forward.

Lock moved between them.

Cell raised one hand.

“This is bigger than a watch. The Ridge Boyz are growing because people believe Reck protects them. So we make his protection look like a lie.”

He laid a photograph beside the package.

Amaya Dawson sat blindfolded in an unfamiliar room.

Mon’s anger turned into a grin.

Cell tapped the photograph.

“Tonight, we take his money. Tomorrow, we take his people. Then Harbor View takes Sunridge one block at a time.”

Tide looked toward the canal doors.

“And when Reck comes?”

Cell’s voice hardened.

“We remind him who made him.”

...

Detective Holloway entered the evidence room carrying a sealed envelope.

Captain Vance was already waiting.

The dead jump-out officer’s financial records lay open on the steel table. Deposits appeared beside dates of raids that had never been entered into the department system.

King K’s name appeared nowhere.

His confidential-informant number appeared seventeen times.

“You weren’t supposed to request these,” Vance said.

“A police officer died beside stolen cartel money.”

“A gang member killed him.”

“A corrupt officer stole from that gang first.”

Vance closed the folder.

“Careful, Detective.”

Holloway stared at him.

“Is that professional advice or a threat?”

His phone rang before he answered.

Vance walked into the hallway.

Holloway waited, then opened the sealed envelope.

Inside was a copy of King K's cooperation agreement.

At the bottom, beneath an old prosecutor's signature, was the name of the operation that sent Kareem Dawson Sr. to prison.

Holloway read it twice.

King K had not merely survived Reem's downfall.

He had helped create it.

...

The call reached Reck shortly before dark.

La Madrina's mansion appeared on the screen behind his father.

Reem was supposed to be calling from prison.

Instead, his face filled a private encrypted video feed while La Madrina stood beside the monitor in her white suit.

Reck's expression changed.

"How she get on this call?"

Reem leaned closer to the camera.

"Because she was on my calls before you knew her name."

The original five stood inside The Sunshine's unfinished office. Plastic covered the windows. Drills and hammers echoed from the front garage.

Reck looked from his father to La Madrina.

"What is he talking about?"

La Madrina said nothing.

Reem answered for her.

"King K stole my streets. Cell stole my connection. They put me behind these walls and thought the Dawson name was finished."

Reck's jaw tightened.

"La Madrina didn't choose you, son."

Reem paused.

"I sent her."

Nobody in the office moved.

Mari looked toward Naz.

TJ stared at the screen.

Zay lowered his head as if the truth confirmed something he had feared from the beginning.

Reck stepped closer.

"D-Low dead. Mari got blood on him. TJ facing charges. My mama and little brother can't sleep at home. You knew all this was coming?"

"I knew they would come for you eventually."

"So you built me into your replacement."

Reem's eyes remained cold.

"No. I built you into my revenge."

The words struck harder than anything King K had done.

Reck removed King K's watch and placed it on the desk.

"You don't get to claim this."

"Everything you have came through my name."

"Everything I got came with one of my people bleeding for it."

Reem's voice rose. "Watch how you speak to me."

"You watch how you speak about the Ridge Boyz." Reck pointed at the four beside him. "This ours. Not yours. Not Cell's. Not hers."

La Madrina finally spoke.

"Reck—"

“If we partners, say that. If I’m just your weapon for him, take your supply back.”

For the first time, La Madrina looked caught between two decisions.

Reem answered first.

“You are not ready to stand without us.”

Reck ended the call.

Silence filled the office.

Mari smiled slowly. “You just hung up on a prison boss and a cartel chief at the same time.”

“They keep thinking somebody made us,” Reck said.

Naz looked toward the window. “They did help.”

“Help ain’t ownership.”

Zay stepped forward. “Then prove we can stand without becoming everybody we hate.”

Reck looked at him.

“What that mean?”

“It means neutral ain’t enemy. Everybody who won’t wear our crown ain’t against us. Protect the neighborhood. Handle the people who actually crossed us. Don’t turn The Ridge into a prison.”

Mari shook his head. “This ain’t the time to sound soft.”

“It ain’t soft to know who you fighting,” Naz said. “It’s strategy.”

Reck looked at each founder.

Then he nodded once.

“Nobody innocent. Nobody neutral. But anybody helping Cell, King K, Mon or them dirty police chose a side.”

TJ’s phone vibrated.

He checked the screen.

His face emptied.

It was a photograph of Amaya.

Below it were six words.

**MIDNIGHT. BRING THE MONEY. COME ALONE.**

...

Reck did not go alone.

He also did not take the money.

Naz traced the photograph's background to an old motel near Paradise Boulevard. Zay recognized the faded mural through a broken mirror. TJ found a second clue in the reflection of a delivery truck outside.

The original five prepared to move.

Then every light inside The Sunshine died.

The drills stopped.

The music outside disappeared.

Three unmarked police vehicles blocked the front entrance while a fourth rolled behind the building. Officers in tactical vests stepped into the parking lot.

The same jump-out unit that had stolen from the Ridge had returned.

At the opposite end of Sunridge Plaza, teal headlights appeared.

Canal Boyz.

Naz looked through the plastic-covered window.

"This coordinated."

Reck's phone rang.

Cell.

He answered.

“You wanted the street,” Cell said. “Come outside and see what it costs.”

Reck watched officers move toward the building while Canal Boy vehicles sealed the intersection beyond them.

“Where my sister?”

“Ask Mon.”

“I’m asking you.”

Cell laughed quietly. “Bring me La Madrina’s shipment, return King’s money and surrender The Sunshine. Maybe your family survives your ambition.”

Reck looked toward the founders.

Mari removed his sling.

Zay pulled two young prospects away from the windows.

TJ opened the security feeds on a tablet.

Naz spread a neighborhood map across the desk.

They did not look afraid.

They looked ready.

“You made one mistake,” Reck told Cell.

“Only one?”

“You thought La Madrina was the reason we got bigger.”

Outside, apartment doors opened.

Residents stepped onto balconies holding phones. Store owners turned on exterior cameras. Cars blocked side streets before the Canal Boyz could enter them. Men who had failed Reck’s membership test stood at the edges of the plaza anyway—not wearing pendants, not claiming the gang, but refusing to let outsiders invade their neighborhood.

The Ridge itself was closing around Cell’s plan.

Reck watched the live cameras multiply across TJ’s screen.

“You brought Harbor View to our home,” he said. “Now the whole Ridge sees you.”

A corrupt officer struck the front door with a metal ram.

The first blow cracked the new frame.

The second shook the building.

Before the third, red and blue lights flooded the opposite street.

Detective Holloway stepped from an official cruiser with Internal Affairs behind her.

“Palm Haven Police!” she shouted toward the jump-out unit. “Stand down!”

Confusion broke the formation.

One officer ran.

Another reached toward his vest.

The Canal Boyz accelerated through the intersection, leaving the dirty unit exposed beneath dozens of cameras.

But one teal SUV did not leave.

It crashed through The Sunshine’s side gate.

Lock and three masked men rushed from it.

The building erupted into chaos.

Workers dropped behind cars. Glass shattered. Mari pulled TJ away from the garage as Zay shielded two residents trapped beside the office. Naz directed people through the rear exit while Reck moved toward the intruders.

Lock saw the cracked crown and charged straight for him.

They collided against the hood of King K’s recovered car.

Lock was heavier.

Reck was angrier.



The fight carried them across broken glass and wet concrete. Lock slammed Reck into a steel post, then reached for the chain around his neck.

Reck trapped his wrist.

“You don’t earn this by touching it.”

Mari struck Lock from the side.

Zay forced the remaining attackers back toward their SUV as sirens surrounded the plaza. One Canal Boy fell wounded. Two escaped over the fence. Lock broke free and climbed into the damaged vehicle.

Before it reversed, Reck ripped the silver CB emblem from its grille.

The SUV disappeared through the rear alley.

Holloway entered the garage with her weapon lowered but ready.

She saw Reck standing amid broken glass, blood running from his eyebrow, the Canal Boy emblem in one hand.

“You need to come with me,” she said.

Reck laughed without humor. “For them attacking us?”

“For staying alive long enough to hear what I found.”

She held up a copy of King K’s agreement.

“King K helped put your father in prison. The officers outside have been protecting him for years. And somebody inside my department gave Cell the timing for this raid.”

Naz stepped beside Reck. “Can you prove it?”

“I can prove enough to make everybody involved desperate.”

Reck’s phone vibrated again.

A live video appeared.

Amaya sat inside the motel room. Mon stood behind her.

King K entered the frame wearing a county-jail uniform.

Reck stared.

King K was supposed to be locked up.

King smiled into the camera.

“Your father got reach inside jail,” he said. “Mine reaches outside.”

The video ended.

Holloway’s expression changed.

“That’s impossible.”

Reck looked down at King K’s cooperation agreement.

Then at the watch on the desk.

Then toward the road leading to Paradise Boulevard.

He placed the torn Canal Boy emblem beneath his shoe and crushed it against the floor.

“Naz, find out how King got out.”

“Already working.”

“TJ, keep eye on that motel.”

TJ lifted the tablet. “Got it.”

“Zay, clear every resident away from here.”

Zay nodded.

“Mari—”

Mari picked up his orange jacket.

“You ain’t even got to say it.”

Reck fastened King K’s watch back onto his wrist.

He looked at Holloway.

“You handle your police.”

Then he looked at the Ridge Boyz.

“We getting my sister.”

Outside, the rebuilding crews returned to their feet.

Across Sunridge, phones carried the footage of corrupt officers and Canal Boyz attacking The Sunshine. By midnight, more people wanted the cracked crown than ever before.

But Reck accepted none of them.

Tonight belonged to the five who had started together.

Cell had declared war.

Reem had claimed ownership.

King K had escaped custody.

Mon had Reck's sister.

And the Ridge Boyz were coming for all of them.

# THE LONG REACH

Paradise Boulevard looked abandoned after midnight.

Rainwater collected beneath the broken sign of the Royal Palms Motel. Half the rooms were dark. The others glowed behind curtains stained yellow by years of smoke.

Amaya was inside one of them.

Reck sat in the passenger seat of a stolen sedan two blocks away, watching TJ's tablet. The motel's camera system had gone offline eleven minutes earlier.

That was not an accident.

"They know we coming," Mari said.

"They invited us," Naz replied.

Zay looked toward Reck. "Then we don't enter the way they expect."

The five founders had left The Sunshine together, but Sunridge was not unprotected. Three trusted associates remained behind with Stone's cartel security posted beyond the neighborhood.

One of the associates was Malik "Mook" Ford.

Mook had grown up two buildings from Mari. He had attended D-Low's funeral, helped carry injured residents during the siege and refused to abandon The Sunshine when the corrupt officers arrived.

He had not earned a pendant.

But he had earned enough trust to watch the building.

Reck's phone vibrated.

Mook's message was short.

## **RIDGE GOOD. GO GET YOUR SISTER.**

Reck showed Mari.

“Told you he solid,” Mari said.

Naz said nothing.

He was studying the motel map.

“King wants us focused on room 214,” he said. “That means Amaya probably isn’t in 214.”

TJ enlarged a frozen frame captured from the video. Behind Amaya, a brass number hung backward in the mirror.

“It says twelve.”

Zay leaned closer. “Not 214?”

“Building twelve,” TJ said. “Old laundry wing behind the pool.”

Reck opened the car door.

“Then that’s where we going.”

• • •

At Palm Haven County Jail, Reem Dawson stood alone inside the prison chapel.

The call from King K’s unit had reached him twenty minutes earlier.

King K had vanished during a medical transfer that did not exist on any official schedule. Two officers signed him out. Neither officer reported for work afterward.

Reem held the phone to his ear.

“Close every door,” he said.

The voice on the other end hesitated. “Your son told people he don’t work for you.”

“This ain’t about who he works for.”

“Then what is it about?”

Reem looked toward the wooden cross at the front of the chapel.

“My daughter.”

Within minutes, orders moved from the county jail to Blackwater State Prison, then through halfway houses and street contacts across western Florida.

Reem had spent years building a network nobody could see from outside the walls.

He activated all of it.

Cell’s incarcerated brother was pulled from his unit.

Two Canal Boy captains awaiting trial lost access to their phones.

A former correctional officer supplied the license plate used in King K’s escape.

It belonged to the Palm Haven Renewal Foundation.

Reem stared at the name.

For the first time that night, he looked afraid.

“Saint,” he whispered.

• • •

Detective Holloway watched Captain Vance leave police headquarters through a rear entrance.

Internal Affairs had detained three jump-out officers. A fourth had disappeared. Vance claimed he knew nothing about their unauthorized operation at The Sunshine.

Holloway did not believe him.

She followed his unmarked sedan across downtown, past Government Square and into the private underground garage of the Palm Haven Renewal Center.

The center occupied twelve floors of mirrored glass beside City Hall. Its founder appeared on charity billboards throughout the city.

Councilman Gabriel Saint.

Saint had built youth centers, funded violence-prevention programs and publicly demanded tougher prosecution of Palm Haven gangs. News stations called him the conscience of the city.

Holloway parked across the street.

Vance entered through a restricted elevator.

Three minutes later, Cell's black Bentley entered the same garage.

Then La Madrina's security chief, Stone.

Holloway photographed every vehicle.

The alliances made no sense.

Unless the war itself was the business.

• • •

Reck and Mari moved along the motel's rear fence while Zay, Naz and TJ crossed behind the empty swimming pool.

Room 214 exploded before they reached the laundry wing.

Flames tore through the second-floor railing. Glass fell across the parking lot. Mon's people opened fire from two dark rooms as police sirens began approaching from both ends of Paradise Boulevard.

"They called police before we got here," Zay shouted.

"King's old trick," Naz said.

The motel became a trap closing from every direction.

Reck kept moving.

He found Building Twelve behind a chained maintenance gate. Mari broke the lock with a tire iron. Inside, industrial washers sat beneath layers of dust.

Amaya's scream came from the room beyond them.

Reck reached the door first.

Mon stepped from behind it and struck him across the face.

Reck crashed into a dryer.

“Been waiting on this,” Mon said.

Mari rushed him, but two men emerged from the shadows. One grabbed Mari’s injured shoulder and drove him against the wall. The other blocked the hallway.

Reck saw Amaya tied to a chair inside the utility room.

King K stood beside her in his county uniform.

He was holding a pistol and smiling.

“Look at the new king,” King said. “Still running wherever family tells him.”

Reck wiped blood from his mouth.

“Let her go.”

“Take off my watch.”

Reck stared at him.

“You heard me.”

Reck slowly removed the diamond watch.

King pointed toward the floor.

“Put it down.”

The watch struck the concrete between them.

King’s smile widened.

“Now the chain.”

Reck reached for the cracked crown.

Amaya shook her head.

“Don’t.”

King pressed the gun against her temple.



“She got more pride than sense. Must run in the family.”

Reck unclasped the pendant.

Before he lowered it, every light in Building Twelve went out.

TJ had found the electrical panel.

Darkness swallowed the room.

Zay crashed through a side door.

Naz pulled Amaya’s chair backward as Reck drove into King K. The gun fired into the ceiling. Mari broke free and fought Mon across the laundry room.

The room erupted with shouting, metal and gunfire.

Then Amaya screamed Reck’s name.

Emergency lights flashed on.

Zay stood between her and King K.

Blood spread across the royal-blue shirt beneath his jacket.

He collapsed.

“Zay!”

Reck caught him before his head struck the floor.

King K escaped through the side door. Mon followed, wounded but moving. Their last man disappeared into the rain as police vehicles flooded the motel entrance.

Mari lifted Amaya while Naz pressed both hands against Zay’s chest.

“Stay with us,” Naz ordered.

Zay’s eyes struggled to focus.

“She good?”

Amaya dropped beside him, her wrists still tied.

“I’m here. You saved me.”

Zay looked toward Reck.

“Get them home.”

Reck grabbed his hand.

“We all going home.”

• • •

The Sunshine came under attack four minutes after Zay was shot.

Mook opened the side gate for what he believed was a Mar Azul vehicle.

Tide stepped out first.

The Canal Boyz flooded the garage before Stone’s people realized the security call had been falsified. They took cash, files and the remaining product. Then they set fire to the new office Reck had finished less than twelve hours earlier.

Mook stood in the parking lot as flames climbed the walls.

Tide handed him an envelope.

“You did right.”

Mook looked sick.

“You said nobody was getting hurt.”

“Nobody important did.”

One of the young construction workers crawled from the garage with burns across his arms.

Mook dropped the envelope.

Tide grabbed him by the collar.

“Too late to grow a conscience.”

A black SUV approached from Garden Courts.

Residents filled the street behind it.

Tide released Mook and ordered the Canal Boyz back into their vehicles. They escaped through the same side gate Mook had opened.

By the time firefighters arrived, The Sunshine was burning again.  
This time, the neighborhood knew who let the enemy inside.

• • •

La Madrina entered Gabriel Saint's private office just after one in the morning.

Captain Vance stood near the window. Cell sat on a leather sofa with one ankle resting over his knee.

Gabriel Saint faced the city from behind his desk.

He was sixty-one, silver-haired and dressed in a charcoal suit. A gold shepherd's staff rested on the bookshelf behind him—the emblem of his foundation.

“Your young friend embarrassed everyone tonight,” Saint said.

La Madrina remained standing. “Reck rescued his sister.”

“And lost his headquarters.”

Cell smiled. “He’ll come back angry. Angry people make easy cases.”  
Saint turned.

“Reem was easier.”

La Madrina's eyes sharpened.

“Reem understood sacrifice.”

“Reem believed you would leave his family alone,” she said.

Saint looked toward Stone, who stood silently beside the door.

“And I did. Until his son decided to inherit a kingdom that was never his.”

La Madrina stepped closer to the desk.

“You ordered Amaya taken?”

“I allowed King K to solve his problem.”

“That wasn’t my question.”

Vance shifted his hand toward his jacket.

Stone moved between him and La Madrina.

The room became still.

Saint smiled.

“Choose carefully, Camila. Reem’s son is temporary. The system that protects your ports is not.”

La Madrina looked at Cell.

“You brought Saint into our business.”

Cell laughed. “Saint was the business before either of us had one.”

That was when she understood.

Cell had not created the Canal Boyz on his own.

King K had not escaped because of a few corrupt officers.

The war was clearing territory for the Renewal Foundation’s billion-dollar waterfront development. Every burned building lowered property values. Every arrest removed resistance. Every seized stash became money for Vance’s unit. Every frightened family became easier to relocate.

Saint profited no matter who won.

He only needed them to keep fighting.

La Madrina turned toward the door.

“Where are you going?” Saint asked.

“To choose.”

• • •

Detective Holloway intercepted the Ridge Boyz behind the motel.

Zay lay across the back seat, barely conscious. Amaya held pressure against his wound while TJ shook beside her. Police cruisers blocked Paradise Boulevard.

Holloway pointed toward an unmarked vehicle parked beside the service road.

“Put him in mine.”

Reck hesitated.

“If I wanted you arrested, tactical would already be back here.”

They transferred Zay.

Holloway drove them through a maintenance exit before the road closed. She called ahead to a private trauma center and ordered the surgeon not to register Zay under his real name.

“Why you helping us?” Reck asked.

“I’m helping the boy who got shot protecting your sister.”

“That ain’t all.”

Holloway looked at him through the mirror.

“Captain Vance met Cell tonight at Gabriel Saint’s building.”

Naz leaned forward. “Councilman Saint?”

“You know him?”

Amaya stopped pressing for half a second.

“Our father used to call him Uncle Gabe.”

Reck looked at her.

“What?”

“When we were little. Before Daddy went to prison.”

Holloway’s phone rang.

Reem’s name appeared on the private line.

She answered on speaker.

“Is my daughter alive?” he asked.

“She’s here,” Holloway said.

Amaya leaned toward the phone. “Daddy?”

Reem exhaled.

Reck took the phone.

“Zay got shot. King got away. The Sunshine got hit. All while you sitting there talking about your reach.”

“Listen to me. King’s escape car belonged to Gabriel Saint.”

“Amaya says we called him uncle.”

Silence answered.

“Tell me who he is.”

Reem’s voice lowered.

“Gabriel Saint built the first Palm Haven organization. Me, King K and Cell—we weren’t partners. We worked beneath him.”

Reck looked toward Naz.

“You said they betrayed you.”

“They did.”

“You said they put you in prison.”

“That part wasn’t true.”

Reck’s grip tightened around the phone.

Reem continued.

“The federal case reached Saint. He controlled city contracts, police promotions, judges and the port. If his name surfaced, everybody’s families became targets—including yours.”

“So what you did?”

“I accepted the sentence. I gave them a boss and Saint stayed invisible.”

Amaya stared at the phone.

“You left us to protect him?”

“I left to protect all of you from him.”

Reck’s anger became something colder.

“And now he controlling the war.”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

Naz answered before Reem could.

He had opened the Renewal Foundation’s public development map on TJ’s tablet.

The proposed waterfront corridor covered Harbor View, Paradise Boulevard and Sunridge Gardens.

The Sunshine sat at its center.

“It ain’t only about drugs,” Naz said. “He wants the land.”

Reem heard him.

“Saint lets crews fight, lets police raid what survives, then buys everything through shell companies. King K feeds him names. Cell moves his product. Vance clears the streets. Saint stays clean.”

Reck looked through the windshield as Palm Haven’s towers appeared in the distance.

Councilman Gabriel Saint’s face smiled from a highway billboard.

**RENEWING PALM HAVEN. PROTECTING OUR FUTURE.**

Reck ended the call without saying goodbye.

...

Zay entered surgery at 2:17 a.m.

The doctors gave him a chance.

No promises.

Amaya sat beside TJ in the waiting room. Mari paced with dried blood across his orange jacket. Naz stood near the window, tracking the fire at The Sunshine through neighborhood messages.

Reck remained alone in the hallway.

La Madrina approached without Stone.

Reck saw her and stood.

“If you came to speak for my father, leave.”

“I came to tell you I chose.”

She handed him a black folder.

Inside were property records, police payments, port manifests and photographs of Saint meeting King K, Cell and Captain Vance across twelve years.

“Saint ordered the war to clear the waterfront,” she said. “Reem protected him once. I will not.”

Reck studied the evidence.

“Why should I trust you?”

“You shouldn’t. Trust what can be proven.”

Mari stopped pacing.

Naz moved beside Reck and examined the first page.

La Madrina looked through the glass at Zay’s operating room.

“Cell believes tonight weakened you.”

Reck closed the folder.

“He wrong.”

His phone displayed the first images from Sunridge.

The Sunshine’s office was destroyed.

Mook had been caught on camera opening the gate.



Residents wanted Reck to decide his fate.

King K remained free.

Mon was wounded.

Tide had taken the stash.

Reem had revealed the truth.

And Gabriel Saint—the celebrated man promising to save Palm Haven—had been feeding the war from above them all.

Reck looked at the four founders still standing and the door behind which Zay fought for his life.

“Nobody moves on Mook until Zay wakes up,” he said. “Founders decide together.”

Mari nodded reluctantly.

Reck handed the black folder to Naz.

“Make copies. Hide them everywhere.”

TJ rose from beside Amaya. “What we doing about Saint?”

Reck stared at the councilman’s smiling face on the folder.

“King K wanted The Ridge.”

He turned toward the hospital window, where the first gray light of morning touched Palm Haven.

“Cell wanted the water.”

He fastened the cracked crown around his neck.

“Saint wants the whole city.”

The surgery light remained red.

Reck’s voice dropped.

“So now we taking the war upstairs.”

## D-LOW'S SON

Khaos walked out of juvenile detention carrying everything he owned inside a clear plastic bag.

Two black T-shirts.

A paperback with half the pages folded.

Three letters from his mother.

One photograph of D-Low standing beside a burnt-orange Chevrolet outside Paradise Haven.

Nobody had told him his father was dead until six days after the siege.

By then, the story had already changed depending on who told it.

Some said D-Low died protecting Reck.

Some said Reck used him as a shield.

Others said King K arranged everything and Cell allowed it.

Khaos believed none of them completely.

The detention gate closed behind him.

Three vehicles waited across the road.

T-Rell leaned against the first. Kilo sat on its hood. Lil Smoke stood beside a gray sedan wearing a faded Haven Boy shirt beneath his jacket.

Only three.

There had been fourteen Haven Boyz when Khaos went away.

He crossed the road slowly.

“Where everybody at?”

T-Rell hugged him before answering.

“Dreko and Six still locked. Quan got twenty years. Baby Ant and Jugg gone.”

Khaos’s face remained still.

“Rambo?”

“Waiting at Paradise Haven.”

“Deuce?”

Nobody answered.

Khaos looked from one face to another.

“I asked where Deuce at.”

Kilo lowered his eyes. “Canal Boyz.”

The plastic bag tightened inside Khaos’s fist.

“He switched?”

“Tide gave him our old spot,” T-Rell said. “Cell gave them the connection. They been using the HB name like we dead.”

Khaos opened the photograph of his father.

“Take me to D-Low.”

The silence returned.

T-Rell nodded toward Sunridge.

“We got to take you to Reck.”

Khaos placed the photograph back inside the bag.

“I ain’t ask for Reck.”

“Your father’s grave is in Sunridge.”

Khaos stared at him.

Then he climbed into the car.

• • •

Zay survived surgery.

The bullet had missed his heart by less than an inch. Doctors placed him under heavy sedation and warned that the next forty-eight hours would decide whether complications finished what King K started.

Reck sat beside the hospital bed while the morning news praised Councilman Gabriel Saint for calling an emergency summit against gang violence.

Saint appeared behind a podium wearing a navy suit and a concerned expression.

“Palm Haven’s children deserve neighborhoods free from fear,” he told the cameras. “We will rebuild every community damaged by these criminals.”

Behind him was a rendering of the new waterfront corridor.

The proposed park sat where The Sunshine currently stood.

Reck muted the television.

Zay’s eyes remained closed.

“You was right,” Reck said quietly. “Everybody who ain’t with us ain’t the enemy.”

He looked at the machines keeping rhythm beside the bed.

“But Saint is.”

The door opened.

Naz entered first.

His expression warned Reck before he spoke.

“D-Low’s son home.”

Reck stood.

“Khaos?”

“He waiting at the grave.”

“Who brought him?”

“What’s left of the Haven Boyz.”

Mari appeared behind Naz with his orange jacket zipped over his injured shoulder.

“He got questions.”

Reck looked back at Zay.

“Then he deserves answers.”

• • •

D-Low’s grave was covered with fresh flowers and old rain.

Khaos stood alone in front of it wearing the same black clothes issued when he left detention. He was seventeen, lean and broad-shouldered, with short freeform twists and eyes that looked older than the rest of his face.

T-Rell, Rambo, Kilo and Lil Smoke waited beneath a nearby tree.

The Ridge Boyz approached from the opposite path.

Reck came first.

Mari and Naz followed. TJ remained at the hospital with Zay and Amaya.

Khaos did not turn around.

“My daddy saved your life?”

Reck stopped several feet behind him.

“Yeah.”

“After he told police the bag was yours?”

“Yeah.”

Khaos finally faced him.

“So which D-Low am I supposed to remember?”

Reck took King K’s cooperation agreement from inside his jacket and held it out.

“All of him.”

Khaos did not accept the paper.

Reck continued.

“He used me for a run without telling me everything. When it went bad, he put it on me. King K had both of us set up. Your father found out, came back and tried fixing it.”

“Tried?”

“He stepped in front of what was meant for me.”

The muscles in Khaos’s jaw moved.

“You leave him there?”

Mari stepped forward. “Watch how you—”

Reck raised one hand.

“No. He get to ask.”

Mari stopped.

Reck looked directly at his cousin.

“I held him while he died.”

Khaos’s eyes filled but no tears fell.

“He say anything?”

“He told me not to trust Cell.”

“Anything about me?”

Reck’s silence answered first.

“He didn’t have time.”

Khaos looked back at the grave.

“Everybody had time for their war. Nobody had time to tell me my daddy was gone.”

“You right.”

“You and him had problems before I got locked.”

“We did.”

“Then me and you got one.”

Khaos removed his jacket and dropped it beside the headstone.

Rambo moved closer.

Mari did the same.

Khaos pointed between the two groups.

“Nobody jumps in. No weapons. Me and my cousin settle everything my daddy left unfinished. After that, we decide whether we family.”

Reck removed his cracked-crown chain and handed it to Naz.

“Let’s settle it.”

• • •

Khaos hit harder than Reck expected.

His first punch caught Reck across the mouth. His second drove him backward through wet grass. Khaos fought with the anger of somebody who had rehearsed the moment inside a locked room for months.

Reck recovered and struck back.

Neither crew interfered.

They fought beside D-Low’s grave until both cousins were breathing hard and bleeding. Reck was stronger. Khaos was quicker. Every time Reck knocked him down, Khaos rose again.

After the fourth fall, Reck stepped back.

“Enough.”

Khaos pushed himself onto one knee.

“I say when it’s enough.”

“Then get up.”

Khaos tried.

His legs failed.

Reck offered his hand.

For several seconds, Khaos stared at it.

Then he accepted.

Reck pulled him to his feet.

“Everything between me and your father died when he saved my life,” Reck said. “I’ll never lie about what he did wrong. I’ll never disrespect what he did right.”

Khaos wiped blood from his lip.

“Anybody responsible for him dying got a problem with me.”

“They got a problem with us.”

The cousins embraced beside the grave.

The Ridge Boyz and Haven Boyz moved together for the first time.

• • •

Reck took Khaos to D-Low’s old garage that afternoon.

The doors had remained locked since the funeral. Inside sat a black Durango, toolboxes covered in dust and a burnt-orange Chevrolet matching the one in Khaos’s photograph.

On the workbench rested D-Low’s repaired pendant.

Beside it were two sealed packages from La Madrina’s supply and a case containing enough money to restart an organization.

Khaos stared at everything.

“What’s this?”

“Your father’s chance to make it right,” Reck said. “And mine.”

“You giving me all this?”



“I’m giving you something to stand on. What it becomes is on you.”

Khaos touched D-Low’s pendant.

“You trying to buy my loyalty?”

“If your loyalty got a price, I don’t want it.”

Reck opened the case.

“This is for D-Low. Use it to take care of your people and rebuild what was yours. But money makes careless people feel powerful. Don’t let it own you.”

Khaos lifted his father’s pendant and placed it beside the burning-HB chain T-Rell had saved during his incarceration.

“Haven Boyz stay Haven Boyz.”

“Ridge Boyz stay Ridge Boyz.”

“Nobody over nobody.”

Reck extended his hand.

“Family beside family.”

Khaos shook it.

“Then let’s get our territory back.”

• • •

The old Haven spot stood behind a convenience store near the Royal Palms Motel.

Deuce had replaced the burnt-orange HB halo with Tide’s silver canal emblem. Teal vehicles filled the lot. Music shook the windows as Canal Boyz counted money inside the building Khaos had controlled before detention.

Khaos arrived in D-Low’s Chevrolet.

The surviving Haven Boyz followed.

Reck, Mari and Naz remained across the street. This was Khaos's territory to reclaim.

Deuce stepped outside wearing teal.

He looked at Khaos and laughed nervously.

"They let anybody out now."

Khaos looked past him at the building.

"Take that emblem down."

"HB died when you got sentenced."

Khaos's eyes moved toward Deuce's chain.

The pendant hanging from it belonged to Baby Ant, one of the Haven Boyz killed while Khaos was away.

"Where you get that?"

Deuce covered it with one hand.

Rambo moved forward.

Several Canal Boyz emerged behind Deuce.

Khaos raised his voice so everyone nearby could hear.

"Anybody who left because they wanted another life can stay gone. I ain't hunting people for choosing peace. But anybody who switched, helped our enemies and stole from our dead chose something else."

He pointed toward the building.

"That belongs to Haven."

Deuce reached beneath his shirt.

T-Rell struck first.

The confrontation exploded across the parking lot. Windows shattered. Vehicles collided against concrete barriers. Residents fled into nearby stores as the Haven Boyz overwhelmed the smaller Canal crew and forced them from the property.

Deuce escaped through the rear alley.

Khaos let him run.

“He going to Tide,” Rambo said.

“Good,” Khaos replied. “Tell him who took it.”

He pulled the silver Canal Boy emblem from the wall.

Lil Smoke carried the old burning-HB halo from the Chevrolet’s trunk.

Together, they placed it above the entrance.

Across the street, Reck watched Paradise Haven recognize its returning leader.

Naz looked toward the Royal Palms Motel.

“Saint won’t let them keep this.”

Reck nodded.

“They don’t need his permission.”

• • •

Inside Palm Haven County Jail, Darius “Duke” Coleman received the news through a folded message hidden beneath his food tray.

### **KHAOS HOME. HB WITH RB.**

Duke read it once and destroyed it.

He was nineteen, stocky and quiet, with short twists and a cracked-crown tattoo across his forearm. Reck had planned to make him the first Ridge captain before an arrest placed him inside the county jail.

He had refused every offer to cooperate.

Across the housing unit, DeAndre “Dreko” Price sat with three incarcerated Haven Boyz.

Duke approached alone.

Dreko stood.

The entire unit became quiet.

“Your leader standing beside mine now,” Duke said.

“That mean we cool?” Dreko asked.

“It means Ridge and Haven stand together on both sides of these walls.”

Dreko studied him.

Then they shook hands.

The alliance moved through the jail before the next count.

Ridge members shared information with Haven.

Haven members warned Duke which officers worked for Captain Vance.

Both groups agreed that uninvolved inmates remained outside the conflict. But anyone verified as part of an attack against Ridge or Haven would no longer find safety simply because police placed them behind a locked door.

Duke made the boundary clear.

“We check every name. We don’t move off rumors. But if somebody helped burn our headquarters, kidnap our family or set our people up, custody don’t erase it.”

Dreko nodded.

“What about Reem?”

“We respect Reck’s father.”

“He run us?”

Duke looked toward the camera above the unit door.

“Reem controls his generation. Reck and Khaos control ours.”

• • •

The alliance received its first test that evening.

Officers brought Corey “Splash” Davis into the housing unit after his arrest in a Canal Boy vehicle.

Splash walked through the door expecting Cell’s name to protect him.

Instead, conversations stopped on both sides of the room.

Duke stepped from the Ridge table.

Dreko rose from the Haven table.

Splash looked between them.

“This ain’t got nothing to do with y’all in here.”

“You helped burn The Sunshine,” Duke said.

Dreko moved beside him. “Your crew took Haven territory while Khaos was locked.”

Splash backed toward the door.

“That was Tide.”

“You wear his emblem,” Duke replied.

Before either side moved closer, four officers rushed into the unit.

They removed Splash immediately.

No disciplinary order had been announced.

No protective-custody request had been filed.

The transfer came directly from the jail administrator’s office.

Duke watched the door close.

“Saint,” he said.

Dreko looked at him. “How you know?”

“Because regular people don’t get rescued that fast.”

Duke found the nearest trusted messenger.

“Tell Reck Saint controls movement inside the jail too. Somebody protecting Canal leadership before we can learn what they know.”

The message left the unit before Splash reached protective custody.

...

Khaos spent his first night home rebuilding.

D-Low's surviving connections arrived one at a time.

An older club owner brought account books D-Low had hidden.

A trucking-company operator returned keys to a vehicle King K never discovered.

A lawyer delivered money held in trust for Khaos since before his arrest.

The final visitor carried a phone sealed inside a plastic evidence pouch.

"Your father recorded something," the man said. "Told me you were the only one allowed to hear it."

Khaos pressed play.

D-Low's voice filled the garage.

"If something happen to me, King K ordered it. Cell knew enough to stop it. Don't let my son inherit my mistakes."

Static interrupted the recording.

Then D-Low continued.

"Khaos, the people calling themselves your friends might be the same ones opening doors for your enemies. Watch the ones who got richer while you was gone."

The recording ended.

Khaos looked toward T-Rell, Kilo, Rambo and Lil Smoke.

Nobody spoke.

Reck entered the garage with Duke's message from the jail.

Khaos handed him the phone.

Reck listened to his cousin's father accuse both King K and Cell.

“We got proof now,” Khaos said.

“We got his word.”

“That’s proof to me.”

“Saint bigger than both of them.”

Khaos looked around the garage his father left behind.

“Then we get bigger too.”

He walked outside.

Nearly thirty people waited beneath the restored Haven Boy emblem. Some were old members. Others were neighborhood residents who believed HB had died. A few were young men seeking the protection of a name that suddenly mattered again.

Khaos stood on the hood of D-Low’s Chevrolet.

“Everybody thought I was finished because a judge sent me away,” he said. “My people died, got sentenced or switched. They took our territory. Then they killed my father and expected me to come home broken.”

He lifted D-Low’s pendant.

“They got the wrong one.”

Reck and the Ridge Boyz stood beside the building.

“If you stayed loyal, you eat. If you left peacefully, stay gone. But if you switched sides and helped our enemies take from Haven, we coming to collect what belongs to us.”

The crowd grew louder.

Khaos pointed toward Sunridge.

“Reck got The Ridge. I got Paradise Haven. Nobody over nobody. Family beside family.”

Reck raised the cracked crown.

Khaos raised the burning halo.

“Whoever got a problem with my cousin got a problem with me,” Khaos said. “Whoever helped take my father got a problem with both organizations.”

Across Palm Haven County Jail, Duke received confirmation that the alliance was official.

He stood beside Dreko beneath the unit lights.

Outside, Reck and Khaos faced two connected neighborhoods preparing for war.

Inside, Ridge and Haven members controlled the same jail tier.

Cell had the Canal Boyz.

Saint had the police and politicians.

King K had protection.

But D-Low’s son was home.

The Haven Boyz were alive again.

And the Crown War now reached both sides of the walls.



## TWO CROWNS

Zay opened his eyes to an argument.

Reck stood near the hospital window with Mari. Naz occupied the chair beside the door, reviewing photographs from Gabriel Saint's black folder. TJ slept with his head against the wall.

Amaya was the first to notice.

"Zay?"

Every voice stopped.

Reck reached the bed before the others.

Zay tried to speak. Pain tightened his face before sound came.

"Y'all loud."

Mari laughed and covered his mouth with both hands.

TJ woke instantly.

"You alive."

Zay looked at him. "That usually how waking up works."

Relief moved through the room in different forms.

TJ cried without hiding it.

Mari turned away and stared at the ceiling.

Naz closed the folder.

Reck held Zay's hand.

"You saved my sister."

Zay's eyes shifted toward Amaya.

“She safe?”

“Because of you,” Amaya said.

Zay looked back at Reck. “King?”

“Gone.”

“Mon?”

“Gone.”

“The Sunshine?”

Nobody answered quickly enough.

Zay understood.

“Again?”

Reck nodded.

Zay closed his eyes.

“Saint wanted that.”

Naz leaned forward. “Wanted what?”

“Us angry. Running everywhere. Leaving home open.”

Reck’s grip tightened.

“They shot you.”

“And if you answer without thinking, they get to shoot everybody else too.”

Reck released his hand and stepped back.

“I ain’t letting it go.”

“I didn’t say let it go.” Zay forced his eyes open again. “I said win.”

The room became silent.

Zay looked at all four founders.

“Saint needs us acting like the monsters he puts on television. Don’t give him the picture he wants.”

Reck stared through the window at Palm Haven.

“Khaos ready to move.”

“Then make sure both crowns got a plan.”

• • •

Mook waited inside D-Low’s garage with his hands resting on the table.

He had been brought there before sunrise by Mari and Rambo. Nobody struck him. Nobody explained what would happen.

The security video played on a laptop in front of him.

Mook opened The Sunshine’s side gate.

Tide entered.

The Canal Boyz burned the office.

The video restarted.

Khaos stood against the tool cabinets with D-Low’s pendant beside his burning halo. Reck sat across from Mook. Mari, Naz and TJ represented the founding Ridge Boyz in person.

Zay appeared through a secure hospital call.

All five founders would decide.

“Tell it again,” Reck said.

Mook looked exhausted.

“Deuce called me. Said a Mar Azul vehicle was bringing replacement supplies. He knew the gate code, the security phrase, everything.”

Naz placed a photograph of Deuce on the table.

“You never verified with Stone.”

“I thought we had to move fast.”

Mari leaned forward. “You thought wrong and almost got people killed.”

“I know.”

“You took money?” Khaos asked.

“Tide gave me an envelope after. I dropped it.”

“After you saw the building burning.”

Mook lowered his head.

Reck looked toward the phone screen.

“Zay?”

Zay’s voice was weak but clear.

“He didn’t plan the attack. He still opened the gate without checking.”

“Mari?”

“Put him out The Ridge.”

“TJ?”

TJ studied Mook. “He can’t know anything important again.”

“Naz?”

“Remove him from the organization. Make him repay the construction worker’s medical costs and every family affected by the fire.”

Reck looked at Mook.

“You wanted the crown before you earned it. Now you never will.”

Mook’s eyes rose.

“I can fix this.”

“You can repay what you damaged. You can tell us everything Deuce said. But you ain’t Ridge.”

Mari’s expression showed he wanted more.

Reck continued.

“If we punish every mistake like betrayal, Saint won’t need to destroy us. We’ll do it ourselves.”

Zay heard him through the phone.

For the first time since waking, he smiled.

Mook was escorted from the garage without his colors.

Khaos watched the door close.

“You let people live with consequences.”

Reck looked at him. “When the truth says it was a mistake.”

“And when it says betrayal?”

“That’s different.”

Neither cousin knew the answer would matter before the night ended.

• • •

Kilo Warren arrived at D-Low’s garage in a new black BMW.

The car was too expensive for somebody who claimed he had barely survived while Khaos was incarcerated.

Khaos noticed immediately.

“That yours?”

Kilo smiled. “Business been good.”

“What business?”

“Moving around. Keeping money coming in after HB fell apart.”

Khaos walked around the car.

Fresh paper tags.

Custom wheels.

A watch on Kilo’s wrist worth more than everything Lil Smoke owned.

“You said Tide took all our spots.”

“He did.”

“You said Cell cut off every old connection.”

Kilo's smile weakened.

"People find ways to eat."

Khaos looked through the windshield and saw a parking receipt from Saint's Renewal Center.

He removed it before Kilo noticed.

"Where you was last night?"

"Home."

"Anybody confirm that?"

Kilo laughed. "You interrogating your own people your first day back?"

"I'm learning who my people are."

T-Rell called Khaos from inside the garage.

By the time Khaos turned back, Kilo had covered his watch with his sleeve.

...

Councilman Gabriel Saint convened the Palm Haven Emergency Safety Summit at noon.

Television cameras filled the Renewal Center's auditorium. Police commanders, property developers, clergy and neighborhood representatives occupied the stage.

Saint stood beneath a giant rendering of the waterfront corridor.

"Violence has stolen opportunity from Sunridge and Harbor View for too long," he announced. "Our renewal plan will replace abandoned properties with housing, parks and businesses."

The rendering showed luxury towers where Garden Courts currently stood.

Nobody mentioned where existing families would go.

Outside, Naz sat inside a delivery van with La Madrina and a financial investigator named Elena Ruiz.

Elena opened Saint's property records across three screens.

"The Renewal Foundation doesn't own the land directly," she explained. "Forty-three shell companies do."

Naz followed the payments.

"They started buying after Reem went to prison."

"Then accelerated every time violence increased," Elena said.

La Madrina looked at the auditorium entrance. "Saint creates the crisis, purchases the damage and receives public money to repair it."

Naz found a cluster of recent transfers.

One company had purchased the Royal Palms Motel forty-eight hours before Amaya's abduction.

Another owned the warehouse Cell gave Tide.

A third paid a consulting company registered to Captain Vance's wife.

"Got him," Naz said.

Elena shook her head. "You have a pattern. Not a case."

"Then we find the person moving the money."

Naz opened the Renewal Center's visitor records obtained from the parking system.

One name appeared repeatedly.

Kendrick Warren.

Kilo.

...

Reem entered the county jail unit surrounded by six older inmates.

He had arranged a temporary medical transfer from state prison through a doctor Saint once controlled. Reem used the same hidden system that freed King K, but he used it to reach Duke.

The unit fell silent when he arrived.

Duke and Dreko stood side by side.

“Ridge on the left,” Reem ordered. “Haven on the right.”

Nobody moved.

Reem looked at Duke.

“You hear me?”

“We heard.”

“Then organize your people.”

Duke folded his arms.

“They already organized.”

Reem stepped closer. “My son’s crew exists because of my name.”

“Reck says it exists because of five founders.”

The older inmates shifted.

Dreko moved beside Duke.

“Khaos says Haven stays Haven.”

Reem looked between them.

“You children think independence means disrespect.”

“No,” Duke said. “It means you don’t command us without Reck.”

For several seconds, father and son’s representative stared at each other.

Then Reem smiled.

“Good.”

Duke’s expression did not change.



“Good?”

“If you folded because I walked in with six men, you weren’t fit to represent my son.”

Reem handed him a folded transfer roster.

Splash Davis would be moved through the medical corridor at 6:40 that evening. The jail administrator, Milton Graves, had personally authorized the protected route.

“Don’t touch Splash,” Reem said.

Dreko frowned. “Why not?”

“Because scared people talk when they think they’re escaping.”

Reem pointed to a name on the roster.

Administrator Graves would escort him.

“Get proof Graves works for Saint. Information hurts this man more than blood.”

Duke accepted the paper.

“That an order?”

Reem turned away.

“Advice from somebody who survived long enough to learn the difference.”

• • •

At 6:40, Splash entered the medical corridor wearing restraints.

Administrator Graves walked beside him carrying transfer papers. A hidden phone inside Graves’s jacket connected him to Captain Vance.

Duke’s people did not attack.

Dreko’s people did not block the corridor.

Instead, a kitchen worker loyal to Haven activated the corridor camera Saint's officers believed had been disabled. Another inmate captured the conversation through a service vent.

Splash whispered, "Tide said I'd be out tonight."

Graves answered, "Saint can move you to state custody. Cell handles the rest."

"What about the Ridge people?"

"They'll be transferred after the next incident."

"What incident?"

Graves lowered his voice.

"The one King K is arranging."

The recording reached Duke.

Duke sent it outside through three separate channels.

One reached Reck.

One reached Khaos.

The third reached Detective Holloway.

By the time Graves realized the camera was active, Internal Affairs was already entering the jail.

...

The Two Crowns Agreement was signed without paper.

Reck and Khaos met at the boundary between Sunridge and Paradise Haven. The street separated two neighborhoods Saint intended to erase from his waterfront map.

Ridge Boyz stood on one side in their individual colors beneath the cracked crown.

Haven Boyz stood on the other in burnt orange, black and steel gray beneath the burning halo.

Residents watched from balconies and storefronts.

Reck spoke first.

“Ridge stays Ridge.”

Khaos answered, “Haven stays Haven.”

“Neither crown controls the other.”

“But an attack on one brings both.”

“Families stay outside the war.”

“Residents don’t become enemies because they refuse to join.”

“Every name gets verified.”

“Every betrayal gets answered.”

Reck extended his hand.

Khaos clasped it.

The two organizations raised their emblems together.

There was no cheering from politicians.

No television cameras.

Only two neighborhoods recognizing that survival required unity without surrender.

Tide watched the gathering through a live video sent by Deuce.

Cell stood behind him inside the canal warehouse.

“They got numbers now,” Tide said.

Cell looked unconcerned.

“Numbers don’t matter when the money man belongs to us.”

Deuce turned the camera toward Kilo’s black BMW parked near the Haven side.

• • •

The first Ridge–Haven move began before sunset.

Three Canal Boy locations had been built on property taken from D-Low and Sunridge families. Reck and Khaos applied pressure at the same time, forcing Tide’s people to divide their attention.

The Ridge Boyz reclaimed a car lot used to move Cell’s money.

The Haven Boyz retook two motel buildings Deuce had placed beneath the silver canal emblem.

There were fights, shattered windows and fleeing vehicles, but both young leaders enforced the agreement: residents were cleared away, families remained untouched and nobody was targeted without confirmation.

By nightfall, two silver CB emblems lay broken in the street.

One cracked crown hung above the car lot.

One burning halo shone beside the Royal Palms Motel.

The message traveled across Palm Haven.

Two crowns.

One war.

At the hospital, Zay watched the footage on TJ’s phone.

“They followed the plan,” TJ said.

Zay looked relieved.

Then Naz called.

The relief disappeared.

• • •

Khaos returned to D-Low’s garage expecting a celebration.

Instead, Reck, Naz and La Madrina waited beside the workbench.

Kilo entered behind him.

T-Rel closed the garage doors.

Rambo and Lil Smoke stood near the Chevrolet.

Khaos looked around.

“What happened?”

Naz placed the Renewal Center parking records on the table.

Kilo’s name appeared eleven times.

Khaos looked at him.

“You told me you was home last night.”

Kilo laughed once. “This what we doing? Trusting paperwork from Saint?”

La Madrina placed photographs beside the records.

Kilo entering Cell’s warehouse.

Kilo meeting Deuce near the canal.

Kilo handing an envelope to Captain Vance’s missing jump-out officer.

The smile left his face.

Khaos removed the parking receipt from his pocket and added it to the table.

“Tell me why.”

Kilo looked toward the garage door.

Rambo blocked it.

“I kept HB alive,” Kilo said. “While you was locked, everybody needed money. D-Low was losing control. Cell offered business.”

Khaos stepped closer.

“Did you help set up my father?”

“No.”

Naz connected D-Low’s recovered phone to the laptop.

The full recording had been hidden beneath the damaged audio file. Elena restored it that afternoon.

D-Low's voice filled the garage again.

"Khaos, if you hearing this, check Kilo. He gave King the Paradise route. I caught him meeting Cell. He said it was only business, but he knew they wanted Reck in that car with me."

Kilo's face collapsed.

The recording continued.

"He your friend, but he helped open the door. Don't let anger make you miss who handed them the key."

Silence followed.

Khaos stared at the person who had stood beside him before the Haven Boyz had a name.

"You knew?"

Kilo backed away from the table.

"King said police was only taking the shipment. He said D-Low would come home. I didn't know Mon was going to—"

Khaos struck him.

Kilo fell against the BMW.

Rambo moved forward, but Reck stopped him.

Khaos grabbed Kilo by the jacket.

"My father died."

"I ain't pull the trigger."

"You gave them the road."

Kilo's fear turned desperate.

"You need me. I know Cell's locations. I know how Saint pays Vance. I know where King going next."

Khaos froze.

Reck saw the choice tearing through him.

Revenge wanted an immediate answer.

Leadership demanded information.

Khaos released Kilo.

“Tie him to the chair.”

Kilo looked surprised to still be alive.

Khaos removed D-Low’s pendant and placed it on the workbench where Kilo could see it.

“You going to tell us everything.”

Reck stood beside his cousin.

“And after that?” Kilo asked.

Khaos looked at the burning halo above the garage door.

Then at the cracked crown around Reck’s neck.

“After that, both crowns decide what betrayal costs.”

Outside, engines approached from both ends of the street.

Teal headlights reflected across the garage windows.

Canal Boyz.

Kilo began laughing through his fear.

“Too late.”

Khaos turned toward him.

“What did you do?”

The first vehicle struck the garage door.

Metal folded inward.

Kilo looked at D-Low’s son.

“I brought them the Haven Boyz.”

# THE GARAGE

The steel door folded inward.

Tide's SUV forced halfway into D-Low's garage before its front wheels lost traction against twisted metal. Teal headlights swept across the walls. The Canal Boy emblem flashed between sparks and smoke.

Khaos overturned the workbench.

D-Low's pendant slid across it.

Reck caught the chain before it fell.

The first shots tore through the garage windows.

Everybody moved at once.

T-Rell pulled Lil Smoke behind the Chevrolet. Rambo dragged Kilo's chair toward the rear office while Naz secured D-Low's phone and the documents implicating Saint. La Madrina disappeared behind a concrete support as her security detail returned pressure toward the shattered entrance.

Khaos reached for the weapon beneath D-Low's tool cabinet.

Reck grabbed his arm.

"Think."

"They in my father's building."

"That's why you think."

Another vehicle struck the side gate.

Deuce entered behind the Canal Boyz wearing Baby Ant's stolen pendant.

Rambo saw it.



Whatever discipline he had disappeared.

He rushed through the smoke.

“Rambo!” Khaos shouted.

Too late.

Rambo and Deuce collided beside the damaged SUV. Their fight carried them across broken glass as Canal members flooded the garage.

Tide stepped through the opening last.

He wore deep teal beneath a black vest, long twists tied behind his head and no expression on his face.

“Khaos,” he called. “Welcome home.”

Khaos rose from behind the workbench.

“You brought an army to my daddy’s garage.”

Tide looked around. “Your daddy ain’t using it.”

Khaos moved before Reck could stop him.

Tide met him in the center of the garage.

Their crews crashed together around them.

The Haven Boyz were outnumbered, but they knew every corner of the building. T-Rell opened the old maintenance partition and moved Lil Smoke and Naz through it. Mari entered from the rear alley with Ridge reinforcements, trapping several Canal members between both organizations.

Reck fought beside Khaos for the first time.

No argument.

No competition.

Two cousins moving beneath two different emblems against the same enemy.

Tide struck Khaos across the face and forced him against D-Low’s Chevrolet.

“Prison made you famous,” Tide said. “It didn’t make you ready.”

Khaos drove him backward.

“You’ll remember me when you leave.”

Near the office, Kilo tipped his chair onto its side and worked one wrist free from the plastic restraint. Nobody saw him crawl toward the rear exit.

Nobody except T-Rell.

T-Rell abandoned cover and crossed the open floor.

He caught Kilo at the door.

Kilo raised a broken piece of metal.

T-Rell knocked it away.

“You sold D-Low.”

“I kept us paid.”

“You kept yourself paid.”

Kilo reached toward the handle.

T-Rell pulled him back into the garage.

“You facing Khaos.”

An impact shook the rear wall before Kilo could answer.

Fire climbed from the storage room.

Deuce had ignited the fuel D-Low once kept for the tow trucks.

Smoke spread across the ceiling.

“Everybody out!” Naz shouted.

Khaos looked toward D-Low’s Chevrolet.

Flames had reached its rear quarter panel.

For one second, he stopped fighting.

The car in his only photograph with his father began burning in front of him.

Tide used the hesitation to break free.

Reck caught Khaos before he followed.

“Your people first.”

“That’s all I got left of him.”

Reck pressed D-Low’s pendant into Khaos’s palm.

“No, it ain’t.”

Khaos looked toward T-Rell, Rambo, Kilo and the Haven Boyz disappearing through smoke.

Leadership defeated grief by inches.

“Clear the building!” he ordered.

T-Rell carried Kilo through the rear door. Mari pulled an injured Rambo away from Deuce. Naz escaped with D-Low’s recording and Saint’s documents.

Khaos was the last Haven Boy out.

The garage exploded behind him.

The force lifted both cousins from their feet.

They landed in the alley as glass and burning metal fell across the roofline.

Tide’s surviving vehicles escaped toward Harbor View.

Deuce left without Baby Ant’s pendant.

Rambo held it inside a blood-covered fist.

Khaos rose slowly and watched D-Low’s garage disappear inside fire.

T-Rell stood beside him.

“We saved the people.”

Khaos opened his hand.

D-Low's pendant remained there.

"Then we ain't lose everything."

...

Detective Holloway arrested Jail Administrator Milton Graves while the garage burned.

Internal Affairs entered his office with the corridor recording, bank transfers from Saint's consulting company and video of Graves moving Splash into unauthorized protective custody.

Graves did not ask for a lawyer immediately.

He asked to call Gabriel Saint.

Holloway placed his phone inside an evidence bag.

"That's not the call I'd make if I were you."

Graves's confidence changed.

"You don't understand what you're touching."

"Explain it."

"Saint chooses police chiefs. Judges attend his fundraisers. Half this jail was renovated through his foundation."

Holloway sat across from him.

"And the other half?"

Graves looked toward the one-way glass.

"Paid for by seizures."

"Whose seizures?"

"Everybody's."

He described a system hidden beneath Palm Haven's war.

The jump-out unit stole cash and drugs during unofficial raids.

King K identified vulnerable rivals through his informant agreement.

Cell repurchased seized supply through port intermediaries.

Saint's shell companies cleaned the money through construction contracts and property sales.

The same neighborhoods were robbed twice—first by street organizations, then by the officials claiming to rescue them.

"The drugs are not the biggest business," Graves whispered. "The land is."

Holloway placed Saint's waterfront map in front of him.

"Why free King K?"

"Saint needed him to keep Reck angry."

"Why?"

"Because angry young men make the mayor sign emergency redevelopment orders."

Holloway leaned back.

"The mayor hasn't signed anything."

Graves looked at her.

"Not yet."

...

Saint responded before Holloway finished the interview.

Duke and Dreko's names appeared on emergency transfer orders. Both were labeled instigators of organized gang activity inside the jail.

The orders sent them to separate state facilities.

Duke would enter Blackwater, where several Canal Boyz awaited him.

Dreko would be sent south to Gulf Rock, a prison controlled by King K's older allies.

Reem received the transfer list five minutes before movement.

He called Duke through the unit phone.

“They separating you.”

“We knew Saint would answer.”

“Blackwater got people waiting.”

Duke looked through the glass as officers gathered outside.

“Then tell Reck Ridge going to be standing when they open the door.”

“This ain’t a loyalty test.”

“Everything in here is.”

Reem lowered his voice.

“Listen to me. Saint wants you hurt so Reck reacts. Don’t give him that.”

Duke smiled without humor.

“Sound like Zay been talking to you.”

The officers entered.

Duke passed Dreko on the way out of the unit.

They clasped hands once.

“Two crowns,” Dreko said.

“Both sides of the walls,” Duke answered.

Then Saint’s system carried them in opposite directions.

• • •

La Madrina watched D-Low’s garage burn from the rear seat of her SUV.

Stone sat across from her.

He had arrived too late with six armed men and an explanation nobody requested.

“How did Tide know you were here?” she asked.

Stone looked through the window. “Kilo gave them the address.”

“Kilo gave them Khaos. Tide knew my vehicle was inside.”

Stone did not answer.

La Madrina placed a second phone between them.

It contained eleven calls from Stone to a number registered through the Renewal Foundation.

“Gabriel Saint,” she said.

Stone’s eyes shifted toward the driver.

The doors locked.

“He threatened my family.”

“Your family has lived in Cartagena under my protection for eight years.”

“He knows where they are.”

“Because you told him.”

Stone’s composure cracked.

“I gave him small things. Meetings. Vehicle movements. Nothing that could destroy Mar Azul.”

“There are no small betrayals at this level.”

Stone leaned forward. “You used Reck too.”

“I offered him business.”

“You sent him toward King K and Cell because you needed them weakened.”

La Madrina did not deny it.

Stone continued.

“Saint knew. He let you supply Reck because every shipment increased the war. You thought you were challenging Saint. You were financing his redevelopment plan.”

The truth struck deeper than the accusation.

La Madrina had manipulated Reck.

Saint had manipulated her manipulation.

She looked back at the fire.

“Where is the next transfer?”

Stone hesitated.

“What transfer?”

“The one Saint expects every organization to chase.”

Stone realized she already knew enough.

“Tomorrow night. Renewal Center payroll convoy. Except it isn’t payroll.”

“What is it?”

“Money from the evidence vault, King K’s informant fund and Cell’s port sales. Saint is moving everything before Holloway reaches it.”

“Why leak the route?”

Stone swallowed.

“He wants it robbed.”

...

Zay left the hospital against medical advice at 9:15 that night.

He could barely stand without assistance.

TJ found him attempting to put on his royal-blue jacket over the bandage.

“You lost your mind?”

“Reck ain’t answering.”

“Because the garage just exploded.”

“Exactly.”

TJ tried to block the door.



Zay stared at him until he moved.

Amaya arranged a wheelchair. A private nurse followed them into the elevator, protesting every floor.

They found Reck and Khaos inside the burned garage shell after firefighters left.

Kilo remained tied to a metal chair pulled into the alley. His face was swollen. T-Rell guarded him. Rambo sat nearby while a medic treated his arm.

Khaos stood where D-Low's Chevrolet had been.

Only the frame remained.

Reck turned when he saw Zay.

"What you doing here?"

"Stopping you from making Saint's next move for him."

"Go back to the hospital."

"Tell me the plan first."

Khaos looked toward Kilo.

"He knows King's next move."

Reck dragged Kilo's chair closer.

"Talk."

Kilo looked at the burned building.

"King and Mon hitting Saint's payroll convoy tomorrow. Cell and Tide too."

Naz arrived with La Madrina.

"It isn't payroll," she said.

She told them what Stone revealed.

Millions in hidden cash.

Seized money.

Informant payments.

Port profits.

Records capable of connecting Saint to every level of the operation.

Khaos looked at Reck.

“We take it first.”

Zay shook his head. “That’s what Saint wants.”

Khaos turned toward him. “You got shot and left the hospital to tell us not to touch millions?”

“I left to tell you the millions are bait.”

Naz agreed. “The convoy gets robbed, Saint claims insurance, destroys the evidence and gets a federal task force to occupy both neighborhoods.”

Reck looked toward La Madrina. “So we let Saint move it?”

“No,” she said. “We change what gets stolen.”

Naz understood first.

“Take the records. Leave enough money for every enemy to fight over.”

Mari smiled. “And while they watching the cash?”

“We take the proof,” Reck said.

Zay sank deeper into the wheelchair, exhausted.

“That’s how you win.”

Khaos walked toward the remains of his father’s Chevrolet.

“They keep burning buildings because they think buildings make us.”

He held D-Low’s pendant against his chest.

“Let them burn every spot. As long as we standing, Haven and Ridge still alive.”

He looked at Reck.

“We taking the records. But I want Haven’s share of the money too.”

Reck nodded. “Everybody eats.”

• • •

The convoy left the Renewal Center the following night beneath police escort.

King K watched from a closed gas station with Mon.

Cell and Tide waited near the canal bridge.

Captain Vance controlled two of the escort vehicles.

Each believed Saint had secretly given the route only to them.

None understood they were all expected to collide.

The first interruption came at the bridge.

A false emergency diverted the marked police units. Streetlights died across three blocks. Vehicles blocked the east approach while alarms drew private security toward an empty warehouse.

Then Palm Haven’s war arrived from every direction.

King K’s people struck the rear.

Canal Boyz attacked from the water side.

Vance’s officers abandoned their escort positions and attempted to seize the cash themselves.

Ridge and Haven moved through the confusion with a different objective.

Reck and Khaos reached the armored records vehicle while the older organizations fought over the money truck. Naz identified the black archive cases. T-Rell and Mari moved them into separate vehicles. TJ captured every badge, face and license plate through remote cameras positioned around the corridor.

The street became noise, headlights and betrayal.

King K saw Reck across the bridge.

“That’s mine!” he shouted.

Reck lifted one archive case.

“Everything you got belonged to somebody else first.”

Mon moved toward him.

Khaos stepped between them wearing D-Low’s pendant.

Mon stopped.

For the first time, D-Low’s son stood face-to-face with the man who helped cause his father’s death.

“You look like him,” Mon said.

“Remember that when I come back for you.”

Tide’s SUV crashed between them as Cell’s men attempted to escape with the cash vehicle.

Khaos could have chased Mon.

Instead, he protected T-Rell and the archive cases.

The choice cost him revenge that night.

It gained him the operation.

Reck saw the difference.

Khaos was no longer merely D-Low’s angry son.

He was becoming a leader.

The Ridge and Haven vehicles left the bridge with Saint’s records and part of the cash. Behind them, King K, Cell, Tide and Vance’s corrupt officers continued fighting over what remained.

Sirens approached from downtown.

Holloway’s homicide task force arrived alongside federal agents she had never called.

Saint’s final move had begun.

• • •

By sunrise, Palm Haven declared a state of emergency.

The mayor appeared beside Gabriel Saint and announced a joint federal task force targeting organized crime in Sunridge, Paradise Haven and Harbor View.

Saint offered Renewal Center properties as temporary police command posts.

He appeared calm.

Concerned.

Victorious.

He had lost the archive cases but gained the occupation he wanted.

At a hidden location beneath D-Low's old trucking company, Naz opened the first case.

Cash filled the top layer.

Beneath it were contracts, ledgers and encrypted drives.

The second case contained photographs of judges, officers, developers and organization leaders accepting payments.

The third held property deeds for nearly half of Sunridge and Paradise Haven.

Every deed transferred ownership to a company none of them recognized.

### **CROWN HARBOR DEVELOPMENT GROUP.**

La Madrina examined the signatures.

"These weren't signed by Saint."

Naz turned to the final page.

The controlling owner had been hidden behind a trust.

Elena Ruiz broke the encryption and displayed the beneficiary.

Reck read the name aloud.

"Kareem Dawson Sr."

Nobody moved.

Khaos looked from the document to Reck.

“Your father owns Saint’s companies?”

“That don’t make sense.”

La Madrina stared at the screen.

“Unless Reem was never protecting Saint.”

Naz understood the implication.

“Saint has been operating the streets.”

He turned the document toward Reck.

“But every time the violence lowered the property value, ownership moved closer to your father’s trust.”

Reck remembered Reem’s words.

**I built you into my revenge.**

The war had made Reck powerful.

It had made Khaos rich enough to rebuild.

It had weakened King K, Cell and Saint.

And it had quietly transferred Palm Haven’s future into Reem’s name.

Reck looked at La Madrina.

“Did you know?”

For once, she had no answer.

Khaos placed D-Low’s recording beside the property deeds.

“Everybody been manipulating everybody.”

Reck stared at his father’s name.

Outside, federal vehicles entered Sunridge.

Inside, the Ridge Boyz and Haven Boyz had more money than either crew had ever controlled—and evidence powerful enough to destroy half the city.

But the price of that power had arrived with it.

Zay was wounded.

Duke and Dreko were being transferred.

D-Low's garage was gone.

The neighborhoods were under occupation.

And Reck's father might have been the hidden hand behind the entire Crown War.

Reck closed the archive case.

"Saint thinks the task force got us surrounded."

Khaos stood beside him.

"Reem thinks we building his empire."

Reck fastened the cracked crown.

Khaos lifted the burning halo.

"They both wrong," Reck said.

The two cousins looked toward the Renewal Center rising above downtown Palm Haven.

"Now we find out who really owns the war."

# CANDY PAINT & GUN SMOKE

Palm Haven looked different when the Two Crowns rode together.

Candy paint turned morning sunlight into moving color across Paradise Boulevard. A cherry-red Caprice rolled on oversized gold rims beside Khaos's burnt-orange Impala. TJ followed in a purple-and-gray box Chevy. Naz drove a forest-green Cadillac with charcoal trim. Mari's orange Hellcat growled behind them while two lifted trucks carried the cracked crown and burning halo above traffic.

Reck led the convoy in a black-and-gold Ford Super Duty.

The passenger doors still carried scars from the war.

He refused to repaint them.

"Let everybody see we still riding," he told Mari.

People came outside as the vehicles passed.

Children pointed at glowing wheels and outrageous wraps. Older men recognized restored Cutlasses, Monte Carlos and Grand Nationals from another generation of Florida streets. Phone cameras followed the fleet from Sunridge to Paradise Haven.

It looked like power.

Naz knew it also looked like evidence.

"Saint got every federal camera in the city watching us," he said through the radio.

Reck looked toward a helicopter circling beyond downtown.

"Let them watch us go home."

They never reached home.



Three unmarked vehicles entered the boulevard behind them.

Two more appeared ahead.

The first shot shattered Reck's rear window.

Gunfire ripped across the candy-black paint and sent pedestrians diving behind parked cars. Reck forced the truck away from the sidewalk as a teal Trackhawk struck his rear bumper.

"Canal Boyz!" Mari shouted through the radio.

Reck saw Deuce leaning from the passenger side.

Khaos turned his Impala toward them.

"Stay with the people," Reck ordered. "Get everybody off the boulevard."

"They shooting at you."

"And they want you chasing."

The lifted truck pushed through the intersection while the others blocked traffic long enough for residents to clear. Teal vehicles followed Reck toward the warehouse district.

He disappeared between two abandoned packing buildings and emerged alone five minutes later.

The Canal Boyz were gone.

The Ford's passenger side was destroyed.

Reck climbed out beneath a cracked-crown mural and stared at the damage.

Mari arrived first.

"We need to move you."

Reck opened the rear door and removed a black bag.

"We need to find who sent them."

"You already know."

"Knowing the organization ain't knowing the names."

Naz arrived with Khaos.

TJ's cameras had captured Deuce and three verified Canal members. A marina access sticker appeared on one windshield.

Khaos looked at the shattered truck.

"We going back tonight."

Reck nodded.

"After the streets clear."

Zay's rule remained alive even while he recovered.

Verify the target.

Protect the neighborhood.

Then answer.

...

The federal operation began before Reck could return.

Agents called it **Operation Crown Sweep**.

Undercover purchases had been arranged across Sunridge, Paradise Haven and Harbor View. Search teams moved simultaneously against The Sunshine's damaged property, D-Low's trucking company, three custom garages and several Ridge-Haven money locations.

Some warrants were legitimate.

Others contained addresses supplied by Captain Vance.

One listed a building demolished two years earlier.

Another described evidence that had not yet entered Palm Haven.

Detective Holloway read the paperwork from a command vehicle and understood Saint's strategy.

The raids were not designed only to arrest people.

They were designed to seize land, money and vehicles before federal auditors examined the waterfront records.

“Stop the Sunridge teams,” she ordered.

The federal commander looked at her. “You don’t control this operation.”

“These affidavits are contaminated.”

“Then challenge them in court.”

The first battering ram struck The Sunshine.

• • •

Kilo had given the task force one final offering.

A large Ridge–Haven transfer would pass through the Royal Palms corridor that afternoon. He promised drugs, cash and enough organization members to justify conspiracy charges.

What he did not know was that Naz had already changed the shipment.

The vehicles carried only a fraction of La Madrina’s supply.

The most important cargo was one archive case containing copies of Saint’s ledgers.

T-Rell drove it inside the candy-blue box Chevy.

Reck saw federal SUVs enter the corridor from both ends.

“Move,” he said into the radio.

The street erupted.

Marked cruisers poured from motel parking lots. Unmarked jump-out cars climbed curbs to block side streets. A helicopter dropped over the rooftops as agents closed on the convoy.

Mari’s Hellcat broke toward downtown.

Khaos stayed beside Reck’s damaged truck.

T-Rell disappeared through the back streets behind Paradise Haven with the archive case.

Police followed all three.

The chase tore across Palm Haven in separate streams of color and sirens.

Reck pushed the wounded Ford through the narrow cuts behind Sunridge, where murals and low apartment buildings turned the helicopter's view into flashes. Khaos's orange Impala remained behind him even when the lifted truck began smoking.

"Leave me," Reck ordered.

"Two crowns," Khaos answered.

Mari drew half the pursuit toward the downtown drawbridge. His orange Hellcat flew beneath neon signs and past stopped traffic while federal SUVs struggled to follow without striking civilians.

T-Rell took the blue Chevy toward the abandoned citrus roads west of the city.

TJ monitored traffic cameras from a moving purple box Chevy.

"They steering all of y'all south," he warned.

Naz studied the road closures.

Every available escape path led toward the marina and Harbor View.

"This ain't a chase," Naz said. "Saint moving everybody into Canal territory."

Reck saw teal headlights appear beyond the next intersection.

Tide was waiting.

Federal vehicles closed from behind.

Canal Boyz blocked the road ahead.

Reck turned the Ford through the rusted gates of an abandoned citrus warehouse. Khaos followed. They exited through the loading yard seconds before police entered the front.

The helicopter remained above them.

There was nowhere left to disappear.

Then hundreds of custom vehicles entered the boulevard.

Owners from Palm Haven's car clubs had watched police seize vehicles all morning. Donks, lifted trucks and old-school Chevrolets filled the roads for an unscheduled protest cruise. Candy paint covered every lane.

Reck and Khaos vanished inside the moving colors.

Federal agents could no longer identify which black truck or orange Chevrolet they were following without endangering uninvolved drivers.

The helicopter climbed.

The Two Crowns escaped the trap.

T-Rell did not.

• • •

Tide captured the candy-blue Chevy near the unfinished wetland bridge.

T-Rell escaped through the orange groves with Saint's archive case.

Lil Smoke, who had followed as protection, did not.

Canal Boyz dragged him into a fishing truck and drove beyond Harbor View, where paved roads dissolved into water and cypress trees.

The Gator Hole sat at the end of a forgotten canal.

Stories surrounded it.

Enemies disappeared there.

Boats returned empty.

Tide used the fear more often than the place itself.

Lil Smoke sat tied beneath an open shelter while dark water moved beyond the dock.

Deuce placed a phone in front of him.

"Tell Khaos where Naz hid Saint's records."

“I don’t know.”

“Then tell him something useful.”

Lil Smoke looked toward the canal.

Two eyes broke the surface and disappeared.

Tide stepped from the shadows.

“You get one chance. After that, we let the swamp decide whether you lying.”

Lil Smoke stared into the phone.

“Khaos, don’t bring them nothing.”

Deuce struck him and ended the recording.

Tide smiled.

“Loyal.”

“Always,” Lil Smoke said.

“That’s going to cost you.”

...

Reck returned to Sunridge after dark in the same damaged truck.

The federal task force had taken six Ridge vehicles, three Haven cars and nearly every customer vehicle from a custom garage. Yellow seizure stickers covered doors across the neighborhood.

The Sunshine was closed behind federal tape.

Saint appeared on television praising the operation.

Then Khaos received Lil Smoke’s video.

Every Haven Boy wanted to leave immediately.

Naz stopped them.

“The Gator Hole got one road, open water and Canal lookouts. Running angry gets him killed.”

Khaos played the video again.

“He stayed loyal while I was locked. I’m not leaving him.”

“Nobody said leave him.” Reck entered wearing black, King K’s watch and D-Low’s bloodline standing beside him. “We verify who there and bring him home.”

T-Rell placed the archive case on the table.

“I know another way near it.”

Reck looked at him.

“How?”

“D-Low used to tow boats from those fishing camps. There’s an old service path from the marina.”

Khaos nodded.

“Then we move after the last fishing families leave.”

Reck saw the growth in him again.

Anger remained.

But leadership now stood in front of it.

• • •

The return strike began with engines.

Reck’s damaged Ford led the convoy down Paradise Boulevard so everybody saw Tide had failed to stop him.

Behind it rolled candy-red and lime-green donks, Khaos’s burnt-orange Impala, Mari’s recovered backup Charger and black lifted trucks carrying both emblems.

They did not approach the wetlands as an invisible force.

They approached as a message.

At the marina, Ridge and Haven members confronted the verified Canal attackers from Reck’s ambush. Money taken from seized

neighborhood operations sat inside the warehouse. Several corrupt jump-out officers were already there demanding their share.

Nobody trusted anyone.

The first shot came from Deuce's side.

The marina erupted.

Glass fell from the warehouse. Boats struck docks as men scattered. Corrupt officers attempted to leave with cash while Canal Boyz turned on them. Reck and Khaos pushed toward the wetland path instead of chasing every enemy.

Their objective was Lil Smoke.

Mari and Rambo held the marina entrance.

Naz recovered the stolen neighborhood money.

T-Rell led the cousins beyond the final dock.

They found the shelter burning.

Lil Smoke had freed one hand and knocked over a fuel lamp. Smoke forced his guards outside before they could carry him toward the water.

Khaos reached him first.

"Took y'all long enough," Lil Smoke said.

Khaos cut him free.

"You talked?"

Lil Smoke looked offended. "About what?"

Khaos pulled him into an embrace.

Across the canal, Tide climbed into an airboat with Deuce.

Reck appeared on the dock.

"This ain't finished."

Tide started the engine.

"Come deeper next time."



The boat disappeared between cypress trees.

The Gator Hole remained his territory.

But the person he intended to make an example of left alive beneath the burning halo.

• • •

Saint controlled the story by sunrise.

News stations played footage of the custom Ridge–Haven convoy, the federal chase and the marina battle. They did not show Reck’s ambush. They did not mention Lil Smoke’s kidnapping. They did not show corrupt officers removing money from the warehouse.

Councilman Saint called the Two Crowns a domestic criminal army.

The mayor expanded emergency powers.

Federal command posts opened inside Renewal Center properties.

Insurance companies canceled coverage across Sunridge custom shops and Paradise Haven businesses.

The city moved to condemn The Sunshine permanently.

Cell increased the price on Reck and Khaos.

La Madrina demanded payment for every package seized during Crown Sweep.

The streets became too hot for anyone to conduct business normally.

King K blamed Reck.

Cell blamed Saint.

Tide blamed Khaos.

The cartel blamed everyone.

Detective Holloway stood inside the federal evidence warehouse examining the packages seized from the Ridge–Haven transfer.

Each carried a faded identification mark beneath newer wrapping.

She entered the numbers into the police system.

All of them had been seized six months earlier by Captain Vance's jump-out unit.

The same drugs had already appeared in a closed federal case.

They were supposed to have been destroyed.

Instead, they had returned to the streets through Cell, passed into La Madrina's war supply and ended inside a federal drug bust designed by Saint.

Holloway called the task-force commander.

"Your biggest seizure belongs to the police."

He stared at the evidence markings.

"That's impossible."

"No," Holloway said. "That's Palm Haven."

Across the city, Captain Vance received an alert that the markings had been discovered.

He called Saint.

Saint watched federal vehicles surround Sunridge from his top-floor office.

"Burn the chain of custody," he said.

"The evidence is inside a federal warehouse."

Saint looked toward the police station across Government Square.

"Then give the city another emergency."

That night, somebody entered the station's evidence annex carrying gasoline.

# STATE OF WAR

Mook believed the fire would make him Ridge again.

The message had reached him from an unknown number shortly after Operation Crown Sweep.

**THEY PLANTED THE CASE ON RECK. DESTROY THE ANNEX AND SAVE THE CREW.**

Beneath it was a photograph of federal boxes labeled with Reck's name.

Mook never asked who took the picture.

He never called Naz.

He never verified anything.

He entered the Palm Haven Police Department through a service door left unlocked by Captain Vance's missing officer. The gasoline waited inside a janitorial cart.

Every decision had been prepared for him.

All Mook supplied was desperation.

He poured the fuel across the evidence-annex floor and struck the flame.

It spread faster than promised.

Fire climbed the shelves, rolled across the ceiling and reached the detention corridor before Mook made it back to the service door. Alarms failed. Emergency locks sealed. Smoke swallowed officers, civilian employees and six people waiting in temporary holding cells.

Mook stood outside watching windows turn orange.

Then he heard screaming.

He ran back inside.

...

The explosion reached Reck as a flash beyond downtown.

He stood inside D-Low's trucking warehouse with Khaos, Naz, Mari and TJ, counting what remained after the federal raids. La Madrina waited near the archive cases while cartel representatives demanded the missing shipment be repaid.

Every television changed to breaking news.

**PALM HAVEN POLICE STATION UNDER ATTACK.**

Saint appeared on screen before firefighters reached the building.

"This is an act of war against law enforcement," he declared.

Reck stared at the words scrolling beneath him.

**RIDGE BOYZ SUSPECTED.**

"How they got suspects already?" TJ asked.

Naz's phone rang.

Mook's name appeared.

Reck answered.

Smoke and coughing filled the line.

"I was trying to help," Mook said.

Reck's expression emptied.

"What did you do?"

"They told me your case was in here. Said if I destroyed it—"

"Who told you?"

"I don't know."

Reck closed his eyes.

The same mistake.

The same open gate.

The same need to earn something he had already lost.

Mook began shouting through the phone.

“People trapped! The holding doors won’t open!”

Reck grabbed his jacket.

Mari blocked him. “Police station burning and you going toward it?”

“Our name already on it.”

“That ain’t a reason.”

“Mook got civilians trapped.”

Khaos picked up the keys to his lifted Silverado.

“Then both crowns go.”

La Madrina looked at them as if they had lost their minds.

Naz understood first.

“Saint wants footage of us attacking police.”

Reck opened the warehouse door.

“Then we give the city different footage.”

• • •

Custom trucks arrived before the fire department established a perimeter.

Reck’s damaged Ford stopped beside Khaos’s burnt-orange Silverado. Ridge and Haven members climbed out without weapons. TJ immediately began streaming from three phones.

The entire city watched them run toward the burning station.

Officers raised guns.

Detective Holloway pushed through them.

“Lower those!”

“They did this,” an officer shouted.

“Then arrest them after they help your people.”

Reck entered the smoke with Khaos and Mari.

They found Mook beside the holding corridor, burned across one arm and trying to lift a steel bench through the locked door.

“I’m sorry,” he coughed.

Reck grabbed the other side.

“Be sorry outside.”

Together they shattered the glass partition. Khaos and Mari carried detainees through the opening while firefighters reached the second floor. Holloway pulled an unconscious records clerk from the stairwell.

Behind the annex, Vance’s corrupt officers used the chaos differently.

They loaded cash, jewelry, seized property and confidential files into two unmarked trucks.

Naz captured the theft from across Government Square.

“There,” he told TJ. “That’s the real operation.”

The trucks left through the courthouse tunnel while television cameras remained focused on the flames.

Saint watched from the Renewal Center.

Reck was supposed to look like a terrorist.

Instead, live video showed him carrying a wounded police employee from the station.

Saint muted the television.

“Find another angle,” he told his communications director.

• • •

Duke's transfer convoy crossed the wetland highway at the same time the station burned.

He occupied the rear cage of the first transport van. Dreko rode in the second. Four Canal Boy inmates sat between them.

The route had been changed without explanation.

Reem's people planned to delay the convoy at the county line so attorneys could challenge the emergency orders.

Saint's people planned something else.

A dump truck entered the highway from a dark service road.

The first transport swerved.

The second struck its rear corner and rolled into the marsh.

Metal folded.

Glass burst.

The world turned over twice before stopping against a cypress tree.

Duke woke hanging from his restraints.

Water entered through a broken window.

Across the aisle, a Canal Boy kicked at the rear door while an injured officer struggled beneath a seat.

Duke freed one hand from the damaged restraint and pulled the officer above the rising water.

The rear doors opened from outside.

Masked men stood on the road.

One pointed toward Duke.

"That's him."

They had not come to free prisoners.

They had come to remove a witness.

Duke pushed the officer through the side window and followed into the marsh. Gunfire cut through reeds behind him. He disappeared between cypress trees still wearing one handcuff and a torn Ridge shirt.

Dreko escaped the second van long enough to drag a wounded Haven member away from the wreck.

He could have run.

Instead, he returned for another.

State officers surrounded him before he could leave again.

Dreko was recaptured.

Duke vanished into the wetlands carrying Administrator Graves's original recording inside the lining of his jail shoe.

By midnight, Palm Haven announced its most wanted fugitive.

Saint blamed Duke for the transport attack.

Reem received a single message from the swamp.

**RIDGE STILL STANDING.**

...

Mook survived the station fire.

Holloway handcuffed him to a hospital bed.

Reck stood in the doorway while doctors treated the burns.

Mook could not look at him.

"I thought I was helping."

"You thought getting your name back mattered more than checking the truth."

"Saint set me up."

"Saint opened a door. You walked through it twice."

Mook began crying.



“What happens now?”

Reck looked toward Holloway.

“Now you tell her everything. The number, the picture, the service door and whoever left that gasoline.”

“That make me a snitch?”

“You almost killed innocent people for somebody else’s lie. This ain’t crew business. This is you fixing what you did.”

Mook looked at him for the first time.

Reck continued.

“You wanted to prove you could stand ten toes. Start by standing in the truth.”

Holloway activated her recorder.

Mook began talking.

• • •

Naz traced the stolen evidence trucks to an abandoned municipal auction yard near the port.

The vehicles carried everything taken from Ridge, Haven and several unrelated crews during Crown Sweep.

La Madrina’s missing supply occupied one truck.

King K’s confidential files occupied another.

D-Low’s property, jewelry from Sunridge residents and cash skimmed from Harbor View filled the rest.

Captain Vance intended to divide it between Cell, Saint and the corrupt officers before federal auditors arrived.

Every organization wanted it.

King K and Mon approached from downtown.

Cell sent Tide from the canal.

La Madrina demanded the Two Crowns recover her shipment.

Reck saw the pattern.

“Saint keeps putting everybody in the same place.”

Khaos checked D-Low’s pendant. “This time we know.”

“Knowing don’t mean we leave our money.”

“Then we take what’s ours before they turn it into another trap.”

Zay joined through a hospital video call.

“Get proof first,” he warned. “Money disappears. Proof keeps Saint from owning the story.”

Reck looked at Naz.

“Cameras everywhere.”

TJ smiled. “Already on it.”

• • •

The auction yard became the center of Palm Haven’s war shortly before dawn.

Rows of seized donks, lifted trucks, motorcycles and luxury cars sat behind razor wire. Many belonged to people never charged with anything.

Vance’s officers opened the evidence trucks beneath portable lights.

Cell arrived first.

“My percentage increased,” he told Vance. “The city too hot because you lost control.”

Vance pointed toward the burning skyline. “You think that station fire was losing control?”

Tide’s Canal Boyz entered through the port gate.

King K and Mon watched from an auction building.

La Madrina’s people occupied the rooftop across the street.

Ridge and Haven arrived last.

Reck's damaged Ford broke through the outer gate beside Khaos's Silverado. Candy-painted vehicles followed, their custom lights reflecting across confiscated cars.

Vance raised his weapon.

"Federal agents are coming."

Reck stepped from the truck.

"Then they can watch you stealing from your own evidence room."

TJ transmitted the live feed.

Vance looked toward the cameras.

Cell realized Saint had abandoned the secrecy of their arrangement.

King K saw his confidential files being unloaded.

Every alliance broke at once.

The yard erupted into gunfire, engines and shattered lights.

Canal Boyz rushed the supply truck. King K's people moved for the informant files. Vance's officers attempted to escape with cash. Mar Azul security demanded everything bearing cartel marks.

Reck and Khaos divided their people.

Naz secured the records.

Mari reclaimed Ridge vehicles.

T-Rell recovered D-Low's property.

Haven members moved neighborhood cash away from the corrupt officers.

Reck saw Mon across the rows of cars.

Mon fired first.

Bullets struck the candy-red Caprice between them.

Reck answered and moved closer, but a vehicle exploded near the auction building. Smoke separated them again.

Khaos chased King K toward the informant truck.

King held D-Low's confidential file in one hand.

"Your father was trying to become me," King said.

"He died becoming better than you."

King threw the file into a burning barrel.

Khaos reached through the flames and pulled it out before the pages disappeared. King escaped through the auction tunnel while Khaos saved the proof.

Again, leadership cost him immediate revenge.

Again, it made him more dangerous.

Federal sirens approached from the port.

Reck ordered both crowns out.

They left with their seized vehicles, neighborhood money, D-Low's file and the records connecting Vance to the station theft.

La Madrina recovered only half her shipment.

She was waiting when Reck reached the trucking warehouse.

"You owe Mar Azul the rest," she said.

"Police took from everybody."

"My agreement was with you."

"And my agreement was everybody connected to The Ridge eats."

Her expression hardened.

"Do not confuse partnership with equality."

Khaos stepped beside Reck.

"Two crowns. Nobody over nobody."

La Madrina looked at D-Low's son.

“That slogan will become expensive.”

Reck closed the warehouse door between them.

“Power already is.”

• • •

Duke emerged from the wetlands after sunrise.

He reached Paradise Haven through drainage canals and abandoned service roads. A custom-car owner recognized the Ridge tattoo on his arm and hid him beneath a vehicle cover before police passed.

Khaos brought him to the trucking warehouse.

Duke entered barefoot, wet and still wearing one broken handcuff.

Reck embraced him.

“They saying you attacked the transport.”

Duke removed Graves’s recording from his shoe.

“They saying whatever Saint pays them to say.”

He handed it to Naz.

“Dreko got recaptured saving one of ours.”

Khaos lowered his head.

“We getting him home.”

“Not by running into Saint’s next setup,” Duke said. “He got people inside every transfer, every jail and every court.”

Reck looked at Zay’s image on the screen.

His two most disciplined voices were finally in the same room.

The Ridge Boyz had their first captain back.

He was also the most wanted fugitive in Palm Haven.

• • •

Naz opened a sealed compartment recovered from the evidence annex.

Inside were contracts older than Reem's federal case.

One established the original port-development partnership between Gabriel Saint and Mar Azul investors.

Another transferred startup money through a company controlled by Camila Vélez.

La Madrina's signature appeared beneath Saint's.

The room went silent.

Reck called her back.

She entered alone.

He placed the contract in front of her.

"You told me Saint manipulated your war."

La Madrina read her own signature.

"He did."

"These papers say you helped build his system."

"I financed a port. Saint promised legitimate access for Mar Azul businesses. He turned the partnership into political control."

"And Reem?"

"He discovered the land transfers and tried taking the system from Saint."

Naz opened the deeds tied to Reem's trust.

"So Reem wasn't only accepting prison to protect Saint."

La Madrina looked toward the window.

"He was protecting his ownership until his son became strong enough to reclaim it."

Reck felt the manipulation closing from every direction.

Saint used King K, Cell, Vance and the federal occupation.

Reem used La Madrina, prison power and his own son's rise.

La Madrina used Reck to weaken her old partners.

Every older leader had treated the younger crews like pieces on a board.

Khaos placed D-Low's burned file beside the contracts.

"Everybody explains betrayal after we find the proof."

La Madrina faced him.

"And everybody demanding power eventually learns it was purchased before they arrived."

Outside, federal armored vehicles entered Sunridge, Paradise Haven and Harbor View simultaneously.

The mayor declared a citywide emergency.

Street businesses closed.

Drug operations stopped.

Money froze.

Arrests climbed.

Bodies appeared in neighborhoods where alliances collapsed overnight.

Nobody could earn safely.

Nobody trusted their supplier.

Nobody trusted police.

Everybody wanted revenge.

Reck looked around the warehouse at the Ridge Boyz, Haven Boyz, a wanted Duke, the wounded faces of his people and millions in recovered money that could not buy peace.

"Saint wants the whole city desperate," Naz said. "Desperate people sell cheap."

Reck looked toward the Renewal Center.

“Then we keep our neighborhoods from selling.”

Mari frowned. “And the war?”

“We finish it.”

Khaos raised the burning halo.

“Who first?”

Reck placed Saint’s contract, King K’s files and Reem’s deeds inside one archive case.

“Everybody hiding behind the corruption.”

The station still burned across Government Square.

Duke was free.

Dreko was trapped.

La Madrina wanted her money.

King K and Mon wanted revenge.

Cell and Tide wanted business restored.

Federal agents wanted the Two Crowns dismantled.

And Saint wanted Palm Haven frightened enough to surrender.

The streets had never been hotter.

The price of power had never been higher.

The citywide war had officially begun.



# NO BUSINESS, NO PEACE

The first thing Palm Haven ran out of was trust.

The second was money.

Federal vehicles occupied the entrances to Sunridge, Paradise Haven and Harbor View. Officers stopped custom cars before they reached the boulevard. Banks froze accounts connected to Saint's conspiracy investigation. Stores closed early. Construction crews refused to enter the neighborhoods without police escorts.

Street business stopped.

Legitimate business stopped with it.

Families who had never touched the war began missing rent because the restaurants, garages, salons and trucking companies employing them could no longer operate.

Saint called it pressure on criminal organizations.

Reck called it starving the neighborhood.

He opened the recovered auction-yard money inside D-Low's trucking warehouse.

Naz separated it into three groups.

Legal defense.

Neighborhood survival.

Organization operations.

Mari looked at the stacks shrinking across the tables.

"At this rate, we broke in two weeks."

"People eat first," Reck said.

“Can’t protect people if we got nothing left.”

“Can’t claim The Ridge if we let it starve.”

Zay entered on crutches wearing royal blue beneath a loose jacket.

Every conversation stopped.

“You supposed to be in the hospital,” TJ said.

“Y’all keep starting wars during visiting hours.”

Reck moved to help him.

Zay waved him away and reached the table alone.

He studied the money.

“This is what Saint waiting on.”

Mari frowned. “Us paying bills?”

“Us getting desperate when it runs out.”

Naz opened Saint’s relocation offers.

Residents were being offered cash to surrender leases and sell damaged property to Crown Harbor Development Group. The offers expired in ten days.

“He freezes the neighborhood’s income,” Naz said. “Then waves money in front of everybody.”

Zay looked at Reck.

“You want to beat Saint? Keep people from having to sell.”

Reck pushed the neighborhood pile toward Naz.

“Then everybody eats until business comes back.”

• • •

Khaos restarted Paradise Haven through D-Low’s legitimate connections.

The trucking company delivered groceries, construction materials and medical supplies instead of anything that could invite another federal seizure. The old club owner reopened his kitchen as a community meal location. T-Rell organized drivers. Rambo protected the lots without displaying weapons. Lil Smoke delivered food to families who had remained loyal while Khaos was incarcerated.

For the first time, the Haven Boyz made money without hiding every dollar.

Khaos stood inside the dispatch office beneath a photograph of D-Low.

“My father had all this and still kept choosing the street first.”

T-Rell checked the delivery board. “Street money faster.”

“So is losing it.”

Khaos looked toward the federal checkpoint beyond the trucking gate.

“We keep both sides alive. But nobody uses the business to dirty D-Low’s name again.”

His phone rang.

Cell.

“Everybody hurting,” Cell said. “Mar Azul wants payment. My canal routes closed. Your people can’t move. Reck’s neighborhood bleeding cash.”

“Sounds like you having a bad week.”

“It becomes your bad year if business doesn’t return.”

Cell proposed a forty-eight-hour ceasefire between the Two Crowns, Canal Boyz, King K’s people and Mar Azul.

No attacks.

No territory moves.

No retaliation.

Each side would pressure Saint’s emergency task force to reopen commercial routes.

Khaos laughed.

“You want peace now because you can’t make money.”

“Peace has always been business wearing cleaner clothes.”

Khaos looked at D-Low’s photograph.

“I’ll bring it to Reck. That ain’t agreement.”

“Bring him something else.”

Cell’s voice lowered.

“Kilo is talking.”

• • •

Kilo sat inside a federal interview room wearing clean clothes and no restraints.

King K’s attorney had arranged the meeting through Captain Vance’s remaining contacts. In exchange for protection, Kilo agreed to describe the Ridge–Haven alliance as one organization controlled by Reck.

The statement was false.

It was also exactly what federal prosecutors needed for a conspiracy case.

Special Agent Marcus Reed entered without introducing himself.

He was forty-two, tall and controlled, with dark brown skin, a close beard and gray beginning at his temples. He commanded the task force occupying Palm Haven.

Kilo expected threats.

Reed placed D-Low’s recovered recording on the table.

“You helped send his car down the Paradise route.”

Kilo’s confidence disappeared.

“I got immunity.”

“From people who needed you to lie.”

“I’m telling the truth.”

“Then explain why your first statement says Khaos created the Haven Boyz after his release.”

Kilo said nothing.

Reed continued.

“He created them before detention. You know that because you were there.”

Kilo looked toward the camera.

“I want my lawyer.”

Reed gathered the file.

“Your lawyer works for King K.”

“So?”

“King protects witnesses until their story stops helping him.”

Reed reached the door.

“Decide whether you want protection from Reck or protection from the man arranging your testimony.”

• • •

The ceasefire meeting took place inside an unfinished restaurant at the marina.

Reck and Khaos sat together without surrendering separate leadership.

Cell represented his network.

King K arrived with Mon.

La Madrina entered last and refused to sit.

Tide was absent.

That concerned Naz more than anything said inside the room.

Cell placed the problem plainly.

“Nobody earning. Federal pressure stays because Saint wants the waterfront empty. We stop shooting for forty-eight hours, reopen routes and put business before revenge.”

Mon looked at Reck. “He still wearing King’s watch.”

Reck raised his wrist. “Come get it.”

King K smiled. “That attitude why everybody broke.”

Khaos touched D-Low’s pendant. “Your setup why my father dead.”

La Madrina struck the table with one palm.

“This is not reconciliation. It is arithmetic. Every hour the city remains closed, all of us lose money while Saint purchases land.”

Reck looked toward her.

“And your shipment?”

“Still owed.”

“Then say this meeting about your money.”

“Everything is about money eventually.”

Naz slid a document across the table.

The Two Crowns would honor forty-eight hours under three conditions:

No attacks on families.

No movement against Sunridge or Paradise Haven property.

Dreko’s transfer information provided immediately.

King K leaned back. “You negotiating for inmates now?”

Khaos looked at him. “I negotiate for everybody beneath my halo.”

Cell signed first.

La Madrina signed second.

King K refused until Mon whispered something in his ear.

Then he added his name.

Reck and Khaos signed on separate lines.

Two crowns.

One temporary peace.

Gunfire struck the restaurant before the ink dried.

The front windows collapsed.

Tide's people attacked from the marina parking lot while everybody inside scattered behind unfinished walls.

Cell shouted into his phone.

Tide did not answer.

Mon fired through a broken window. La Madrina's security surrounded her. Reck pulled Zay's empty chair away from the open floor out of instinct before remembering Zay had refused to attend.

Khaos saw Deuce beside a teal truck.

The ceasefire had lasted forty-three seconds.

Reck moved toward the rear exit with Khaos.

King K blocked them.

"This your setup?" Reck asked.

"If it was, you wouldn't still be talking."

For one impossible moment, old enemies fought toward the same exit.

The attack ended as quickly as it began.

Tide disappeared before police arrived.

One Canal Boy remained wounded in the parking lot.

Cell looked at his signature on the table.

"He moved without me."

Khaos stared at him. "Or you need us believing that."

The ceasefire was dead.

Business remained closed.

And Tide had declared himself independent from the man who built him.

...

Dreko arrived at Gulf Rock State Prison beneath a black sky.

The intake officer removed his burning-halo pendant, photographed it and placed it inside a property envelope.

“Haven Boy?” the officer asked.

Dreko said nothing.

The officer smiled. “King’s people waiting.”

Inside the unit, older men connected to King K controlled phones, food access and protection. A guard wearing Saint’s Renewal Foundation pin opened the wrong gate at the right time.

Six men entered Dreko’s corridor.

He stood alone.

Before they reached him, prison lights died.

Reem’s voice came through the darkness from the neighboring tier.

“Tell Saint the young crown arrived under old protection.”

Doors slammed across the unit.

When emergency power returned, Dreko was gone from the corridor.

Reem’s network had moved him into a maintenance wing Saint’s guards did not control.

Dreko picked up a hidden phone.

Khaos answered.

“You good?”

“For tonight.”



“We getting you out.”

“Get Saint first,” Dreko said. “His people run the prison like another neighborhood.”

• • •

Reem called Reck immediately afterward.

“Dreko is alive because of me.”

“Then I appreciate that.”

“Appreciation doesn’t settle ownership.”

Reck looked at the deeds spread across Naz’s desk.

“There it is.”

“Crown Harbor belongs to my trust. Saint stole control while I was incarcerated. You recovered my property.”

“We recovered our neighborhoods.”

“With my money, my connection and my prison network.”

Reck lowered his voice.

“With D-Low dead, Zay shot, Duke hunted and families sleeping behind federal checkpoints.”

“Power costs.”

“You keep charging everybody else.”

Reem became silent.

Reck continued.

“You want the deeds? Come home and explain everything face-to-face.”

“You know I can’t.”

“Then stop trying to rule Palm Haven through a prison phone.”

Reck ended the call.

Zay stood in the doorway on his crutches.

“You like telling powerful people no.”

“Somebody got to.”

“Just make sure you ain’t saying it because you want to become the only person nobody can tell no.”

Reck looked at him.

Zay continued.

“You started feeding The Ridge because you loved it. Now every decision sound like control.”

“We at war.”

“War don’t decide who you are. It exposes it.”

Reck turned toward the neighborhood survival ledger.

Money was disappearing faster than Naz could replace it.

“What you want me to do?”

“Build something people can own without owing you.”

• • •

The answer came from the property deeds.

Naz created community-owned companies with residents, shopkeepers and family representatives holding shares. D-Low’s trucking business became the first investor. The recovered neighborhood money funded emergency purchases of buildings Saint’s shell companies were attempting to acquire.

Reck did not own the properties personally.

Khaos did not either.

The neighborhoods did.

When Saint’s relocation representatives arrived, residents placed copies of the new ownership documents in their hands.

“We’re not selling,” Ms. Lena told them.

Saint watched the rejection from his office.

For the first time, Reck had attacked his empire without gunfire.

It frightened him more than the convoy robbery.

• • •

Special Agent Marcus Reed entered D-Low’s trucking warehouse alone.

Duke raised a weapon from the shadows.

Reed slowly placed his badge on the floor.

“I came for the archive cases.”

Reck stepped forward. “Federal agents usually bring more agents.”

“Federal commanders usually don’t meet fugitives in warehouses.”

Duke remained behind him.

“You here to arrest me?”

“Eventually.”

Reed looked toward Reck.

“Tonight I need Gabriel Saint’s original contracts.”

Naz studied him. “Why?”

Reed removed an old photograph from his jacket.

Saint stood beside a young woman and a ten-year-old boy.

The boy was Reed.

“Gabriel Saint is my father.”

Nobody spoke.

Reck looked from the photograph to the federal commander.

“Your last name Reed.”

“My mother’s. Danielle Reed.”

La Madrina recognized it.

“The port accountant.”

Reed faced her. “You knew her?”

“She discovered Saint’s first missing development funds.”

“She died in a car accident three days later.”

Reed placed a sealed report beside the photograph.

The crash investigator had received a payment from Saint’s foundation.

“I joined federal law enforcement to build a case against him,” Reed said. “Every time I got close, evidence disappeared. Witnesses changed stories. Then your war produced more records in three weeks than I found in twenty years.”

Reck folded his arms. “So Crown Sweep was about your father?”

“It was supposed to be. Saint fed my team false warrants and turned the operation against you.”

“You still occupied our neighborhoods.”

“And you still run criminal organizations.”

The room tightened.

Reed did not soften.

“I am not your friend. I will prosecute what I can prove. But Saint killed my mother, corrupted my task force and built his career on stolen neighborhoods.”

He looked at the archive cases.

“Give me copies, and I can freeze Crown Harbor before the relocation deadline.”

Naz asked the question everyone needed answered.

“What stops you from taking everything and arresting us?”

Reed glanced toward Duke.

“Nothing except the fact that Saint controls the official evidence system. If I take originals, they disappear. If copies exist everywhere, he can’t bury all of them.”

Zay entered behind Reck.

“That sound familiar.”

Reck remembered his own order to Naz.

Make copies. Hide them everywhere.

Reed extended his hand toward the case.

“We want the same man.”

Reck did not shake it.

“Wanting the same enemy don’t make us partners.”

“No,” Reed said. “It makes us useful to each other.”

Outside, federal vehicles remained at every entrance to Sunridge.

Inside, Gabriel Saint’s son stood beside the most wanted people in Palm Haven asking for proof that could destroy his father.

Reck looked at Naz.

“Give him copies.”

Reed accepted the drive.

His phone vibrated before he reached the door.

He checked the message.

Saint had scheduled an emergency vote for the following morning.

If approved, Crown Harbor would receive permanent control of the waterfront properties—including The Sunshine, D-Low’s trucking company and most of Paradise Haven.

Reed showed them the screen.

“You have twelve hours.”

Khaos looked toward the Renewal Center.

“To do what?”

Reck closed the final archive case.

“Stop Saint from buying the city before breakfast.”

# THE PALM HAVEN HEIST

The Gulf Empress entered Palm Haven before dawn.

From the shoreline, it looked like a moving city.

Stacks of containers rose above the black water. Tugboats guided the ship toward Saint's redevelopment docks while federal patrols watched from both sides of the channel.

Officially, the cargo carried steel, glass and construction equipment for the Crown Harbor waterfront.

Unofficially, half Palm Haven's criminal economy was hidden inside it.

Cell waited inside a harbor office.

La Madrina watched from a private yacht beyond the inspection line.

Captain Vance controlled the police boats.

Gabriel Saint stood behind the windows of the Renewal Center, seven miles away, following the ship on a live port feed.

At 4:17 a.m., container 294 exploded.

The blast tore through the middle deck.

Steel doors ripped away. Cranes collapsed. Containers slid across the ship and crashed against one another before falling into the channel. One split open above the dock.

White packages rained across concrete.

Port workers ran.

Police boats turned toward the fire.

Then the second explosion opened the cargo hold.

Palm Haven saw everything through news helicopters.

By sunrise, kilos were floating against seawalls, scattered across the port and disappearing into trucks, fishing boats and the hands of anyone fast enough to reach them.

The Gulf Empress had broken open.

The White Tide had arrived.

• • •

Reck watched the disaster from D-Low's trucking warehouse.

Every phone in the building rang at once.

Street crews wanted to purchase loose cargo.

Former Ridge associates offered locations.

Residents reported strangers hiding packages inside apartment courtyards.

Mari stared at the television.

"That's more money in the water than we made our whole lives."

Khaos looked toward the port. "Enough to rebuild Haven ten times."

Zay sat beside the archive cases, still pale from the shooting.

"That's what whoever opened it wants you thinking."

TJ enlarged a video of the damaged ship.

One container remained attached to a hanging crane above the channel.

**317.**

Naz compared the number to Saint's ledgers.

"That's not product."

"What is it?" Reck asked.

"Original port records. Payments. Shipping manifests. Maybe the key to Saint's bank vault."



The crane cable snapped.

Container 317 fell into the water and vanished.

• • •

The first White Tide shooting happened twenty-three minutes later.

Two small crews fought over packages washed beneath the Harbor View bridge. A passing bus was caught between them. By the time police arrived, three people were dead and six civilians wounded.

The second shooting happened outside a motel.

The third happened inside a grocery-store parking lot where somebody had hidden cargo behind a dumpster.

By noon, Palm Haven's emergency rooms overflowed.

Prices collapsed.

Robberies multiplied.

Inexperienced sellers moved unfamiliar product into every neighborhood while King K, Canal Boyz and corrupt officers hunted the same packages.

Reck ordered Ridge members to clear loose cargo away from schools, parks and apartment buildings.

Khaos gave Haven the same order.

"Secure it," Reck said. "Nobody sells anything until we know who opened that ship."

Mari looked at him. "We sitting on money while everybody else getting rich."

"Everybody else dying over bait."

Zay nodded.

"That's the difference between running streets and streets running you."

• • •

The Blue Table arrived in three armored vehicles.

Don Esteban “El Almirante” Vélez entered the city beneath the protection of men La Madrina did not command. Mateo “El Contador” Salas carried a ledger documenting every missing dollar. Lucía “La Sombra” Ortega carried nothing visible and noticed everything.

They met La Madrina inside a closed oceanfront hotel.

El Almirante remained standing.

“You were sent to control Florida.”

La Madrina faced him in a white suit stained with smoke from the port.

“Saint sabotaged the ship.”

“A politician opened Mar Azul cargo beneath your authority.”

“With help inside our organization.”

Mateo placed a loss report on the table.

“Hundreds of millions missing. Records gone. Street crews selling our property for fractions.”

El Almirante’s voice remained quiet.

“You are removed from Florida command until this is resolved.”

La Madrina looked at the soldiers behind him.

Half had once answered directly to her.

None moved.

Lucía spoke.

“Forty-eight hours. Return the shipment, Container 317 and whoever opened the Gulf Empress.”

“Or?”

El Almirante looked through the window toward Palm Haven.

“Nobody conducts business safely until Mar Azul is repaid.”

...

The ultimatum reached every faction.

Cell blamed La Madrina.

Tide claimed part of the loose shipment as Harbor View property.

King K offered to trade recovered cargo for a new federal agreement.

Vance ordered officers to seize packages without documenting them.

Smaller crews abandoned alliances and fought over fast money.

The Two Crowns received a separate demand.

El Almirante wanted every package secured in Sunridge and Paradise Haven, along with Saint's archive cases.

Reck met him at the trucking warehouse with Khaos beside him.

"The files ain't yours," Reck said.

"The shipment is."

"Then go ask your people how it got opened."

The room changed.

El Almirante's guards stepped closer.

Ridge and Haven members did the same.

Khaos touched the burning halo.

"You want who stole from you? We want them too. But you threaten our neighborhoods, now you got another war instead of an answer."

El Almirante studied both young leaders.

"Courage is expensive when borrowed from somebody else's supply."

Reck looked at the cartel chief.

"Then send us the bill after we find Container 317."

Lucía hid a small smile.

El Almirante did not.

...

Naz found Container 317 through a toll-camera photograph.

A salvage truck removed it from the channel before federal divers arrived. The truck belonged to a company controlled by Sebastián Vélez—El Almirante’s son.

The container traveled directly to First Palm National Bank.

La Madrina stared at the image.

“Sebastián authorized security access on the ship.”

Lucía added another record.

The explosive device came from a Mar Azul security shipment signed out under Sebastián’s code.

The betrayal had not entered the cartel from Palm Haven.

It came from the Blue Table’s family.

El Almirante refused to believe it until Sebastián called.

His son appeared on a video feed from Saint’s bank vault.

“You built Mar Azul for another century,” Sebastián said. “La Madrina was going to lose Florida to children. I saved it.”

“You destroyed our ship.”

“I destroyed her authority.”

Gabriel Saint stepped into frame behind him.

“The emergency vote begins in two hours,” Saint said. “By noon, the waterfront belongs to Crown Harbor. By tonight, every organization responsible for the port crisis will be federal property.”

El Almirante’s face turned to stone.

“My son is not yours.”

Saint smiled. “Everybody belongs to the person holding their future.”

The call ended.

The Blue Table declared war on Saint.

La Madrina declared war on Sebastián.

And every road led to the same bank.

• • •

First Palm National occupied an entire block beside Government Square.

Beneath it sat a private vault connected to the Renewal Center through an underground service tunnel. Saint had moved the community escrow money, police-seizure cash, cartel profits, waterfront deeds and original smuggling records into that vault before ordering the ship sabotaged.

He wanted every rival to attack the bank.

The city would see criminals destroying downtown.

The council would approve his emergency takeover.

His hidden tactical team would eliminate whoever survived.

Then insurance would replace the money Saint had already moved somewhere else.

Marcus Reed discovered the final part too late.

“The bank is a kill box,” he told Reck through a secure call. “Don’t enter.”

Reck watched Saint’s emergency vote beginning on television.

Council members entered the Renewal Center across the square. Residents from Sunridge and Paradise Haven remained trapped behind federal checkpoints, unable to speak before the vote.

“If we don’t enter, Saint gets the deeds,” Reck said.

“If you do, he gets bodies and a federal case.”

Khaos looked at D-Low’s trucking company on the seizure map.

“He gets everything either way.”

Zay's voice came from behind them.

"Then don't play for what he expects."

Naz opened the bank schematics contained in Saint's archive.

"Everybody else going for the cash."

Reck understood.

"We go for the records."

...

The Palm Haven heist began at 9:42 a.m.

King K and Mon entered through the parking garage disguised among a private security convoy.

Cell's people approached from the port tunnel.

Tide and the Canal Boyz attacked the rear service entrance.

Vance's corrupt officers entered through the front carrying legitimate badges.

The Blue Table surrounded the block.

La Madrina's loyal faction separated from them and moved toward Sebastián.

Ridge and Haven arrived inside custom trucks carrying community-ownership documents and copies of Saint's records.

News helicopters circled above Government Square.

The first shots came from Saint's hidden tactical team.

They fired into Vance's officers from an upper bank floor.

Vance believed Cell betrayed him and answered toward the tunnel.

Cell's people blamed the Canal Boyz.

Tide used the confusion to push for the vault.

Within seconds, every alliance collapsed.

The bank became thunder.

Glass covered the marble lobby. Civilians hid behind counters. Council members across the square dropped beneath tables as bullets struck Renewal Center windows.

Reck and Khaos entered through the side hall with Naz, Mari, T-Rell and Rambo.

Their first move was not toward the vault.

It was toward the civilians trapped inside the lobby.

They cleared a path through the records wing while Marcus Reed's loyal federal agents opened an evacuation route from outside.

Rambo remained behind Khaos.

"You get the container," he said. "I keep the hall."

"We move together."

"You the crown. Act like it."

Deuce appeared at the far end wearing Baby Ant's missing chain replacement and carrying D-Low's original port file.

Khaos started toward him.

Rambo saw the tactical shooter above them first.

He pushed Khaos aside.

The shot struck Rambo beneath the shoulder.

He fell against the vault corridor.

Khaos caught him.

"Stay with me."

Rambo pressed D-Low's pendant back against Khaos's chest.

"Get Deuce."

T-Rell dragged Rambo toward the evacuation route while Khaos followed the stolen file deeper into the bank.

...

Marcus Reed reached the council chamber with evidence against his father.

An agent from his own task force blocked the door.

“Orders changed,” the agent said.

“Whose orders?”

The answer came as a gunshot.

Reed fell against the marble wall.

Detective Holloway fired from the stairwell, forcing the agent away. She reached Reed and pressed both hands against the wound.

Across the chamber, cameras continued broadcasting the emergency vote.

Saint stepped over broken glass and demanded the council proceed.

“The violence outside proves why Crown Harbor must act now.”

Holloway dragged Reed toward the live cameras.

He raised the drive Reck had given him.

“Your councilman built this crisis,” he said into the nearest microphone. “He sabotaged the Gulf Empress, corrupted the task force and arranged the attack happening outside.”

Saint looked at his son without emotion.

“You always blamed me for your mother.”

Reed’s blood spread across the floor.

“Because you killed her.”

The entire city heard him.

...



Reck reached the private vault as King K emerged from another corridor.

Mon stood beside him.

For the first time, there was no vehicle, crowd or Harbor View crash between Reck and the man who had hunted his family.

Mon raised his weapon.

“D-Low died because he stepped in front of you,” he said. “Zay got shot doing the same. Everybody around you bleeds while you wear the crown.”

Reck looked at him.

“And everybody around King dies so he can keep one.”

The confrontation exploded across the vault lobby.

King K moved toward his informant files while Reck and Mon fought between shattered security gates. Mon was larger, older and certain rage made him stronger.

Reck had learned rage needed direction.

He forced Mon away from the civilians sheltering behind the deposit counters and drove him toward the empty tunnel.

Before either could finish it, Tide crashed through the vault door with Canal Boyz behind him.

“Everybody move!” Tide shouted. “The vault mine.”

Cell appeared behind him.

“You don’t own anything I built.”

Tide turned his weapon toward his former supplier.

“That’s why I’m taking it.”

The Canal Boyz split in two.

Some remained with Cell.

Others stood behind Tide.

Their civil war began inside Saint's vault.

King K escaped with part of his file.

Mon disappeared into smoke.

Reck reached the vault controls as Khaos arrived carrying D-Low's records.

Behind them, Container 317 sat open.

It contained drives, original manifests and a metal key bearing First Palm National's crest.

Naz used the key to open the inner vault.

Money rose from floor to ceiling.

More than either young leader had imagined.

Community funds.

Cartel profits.

Police theft.

Political bribes.

Reem's hidden fortune.

Khaos stared at it.

"We can rebuild everything."

Zay's voice came through TJ's phone.

"If you take all the money and bury the proof, you become another Saint."

Reck looked toward the archive drives.

He made the decision.

"Community escrow comes with us. Enough dirty money to keep both neighborhoods alive."

Khaos nodded slowly.

"And the rest?"

“Expose it.”

Naz transmitted the contents of Container 317 to news stations, independent investigators, federal oversight offices and thousands of Palm Haven residents.

Smuggling manifests filled television screens while the bank was still under siege.

Names appeared.

Judges.

Officers.

Developers.

Bank executives.

Cartel intermediaries.

Politicians in cities beyond Florida.

Palm Haven was not the first community the network had destroyed and purchased.

It was only the most profitable.

...

Lucía found Sebastián inside the bank’s underground tunnel.

La Madrina stood beside her.

El Almirante approached from the opposite end.

Sebastián had nowhere left to move.

“I did this for Mar Azul,” he told his father.

“You did it for my chair,” El Almirante replied.

Sebastián looked toward La Madrina. “She was losing Florida.”

“And you handed it to Saint.”

Lucía displayed the sabotage authorization.

The Blue Table saw the truth together.

El Almirante removed Sebastián from succession in the tunnel beneath the city he tried to purchase with betrayal.

But before cartel guards could take him, the lights died.

Saint's emergency escape system opened a hidden wall.

Sebastián disappeared through it.

La Madrina followed.

She reached an underground platform as a private vehicle accelerated away.

Gabriel Saint sat in the rear.

Sebastián was beside him.

A third passenger remained hidden in shadow.

• • •

The bank burned by afternoon.

Rambo entered surgery.

Marcus Reed remained alive but critical.

Captain Vance's corruption played across every news station.

The emergency waterfront vote collapsed before it could finish.

Federal authorities froze Crown Harbor's property transfers.

Residents carried community deeds out of the bank while cameras watched.

The Two Crowns escaped with their neighborhood funds, D-Low's records and enough money to survive the occupation.

They did not leave untouched.

Four Ridge-Haven members were arrested.

Several Canal Boyz and corrupt officers died during the crisis.

Downtown Palm Haven became a federal crime scene.

Saint disappeared.

King K and Mon remained free.

Tide survived and broke fully from Cell.

The Blue Table occupied the port.

And the entire national smuggling network now knew Reck and Khaos had released its secrets.

TJ recovered surveillance footage from the tunnel.

The private vehicle carrying Saint and Sebastián passed beneath one working camera.

For two seconds, light crossed the third passenger's face.

Reck stopped the video.

Khaos leaned closer.

La Madrina said nothing.

The man leaving with Gabriel Saint was Kareem Dawson Sr.

Reck's father was supposed to be inside Blackwater State Prison.

Instead, Reem sat beside Palm Haven's most wanted politician while the city burned behind them.

The prison calls.

The waterfront deeds.

La Madrina's arrival.

The hidden trust.

The war that made Reck powerful enough to open Saint's vault.

Every answer created a worse question.

Khaos looked at his cousin.

"Your father planned this with Saint?"

Reck stared at the frozen image.

Reem had said he built his son into revenge.

Maybe revenge had never been the destination.

Maybe Reck had been the key.

Outside, smoke from the Gulf Empress mixed with smoke from First Palm National above Palm Haven's skyline.

The biggest shipment in the city's history had flooded the streets.

The biggest bank heist had exposed a national empire.

The deadliest shooting crisis had stopped Saint's vote.

But the two men who understood the entire plan were gone.

Reck fastened the cracked crown.

"Find Reem."

## FIND REEM

By nightfall, Kareem Dawson Sr. had replaced his son as Palm Haven's most wanted man.

Federal bulletins described Reem as the architect of the Crown Harbor conspiracy, the organizer of the First Palm National heist and the fugitive leader of a multigenerational criminal network.

His prison photograph appeared beside Gabriel Saint and Sebastián Vélez on every news station.

Reck watched from Rambo's hospital waiting room.

The report called Reem armed, dangerous and responsible for the violence consuming Palm Haven.

Khaos stood beside the intensive-care doors wearing Rambo's blood across his burnt-orange shirt.

"They got footage of him leaving with Saint," Khaos said.

"Footage don't tell me why."

"It tells you he ain't in prison."

Reck turned from the television.

"Your father died saving me. Mine might be risking everything to save my mama and little brother. I can't call him a traitor until I hear it from him."

Khaos looked through the glass at Rambo.

Machines surrounded the Haven enforcer. Doctors had removed the bullet, but internal damage kept him unconscious.

"Then we find Reem," Khaos said. "But if he chose Saint over us, you got to be Reck before you be his son."

Reck nodded once.

The intensive-care light remained red.

Two fathers had left two sons different kinds of pain.

Neither cousin had time to carry it slowly.

• • •

Duke became the first official Ridge captain inside D-Low's trucking warehouse.

No celebration followed.

He remained a wanted fugitive, one wrist scarred from the broken handcuff and his face displayed on highway signs throughout the county.

The founding Ridge Boyz stood around him.

Zay attended on crutches.

Naz held the cracked-crown pendant.

TJ monitored federal radio traffic.

Mari kept watch near the door.

Reck placed the chain around Duke's neck.

"You stood for us inside. You saved an officer during that transport even when Saint sent people to kill you. You carried proof out when you could've carried nothing but yourself."

Duke touched the crown.

"I ain't looking for a title."

"That's why you get one."

Reck faced the founders.

"Darius 'Duke' Coleman—first captain of the Ridge Boyz."

Zay offered his hand first.



The others followed.

Duke accepted the position with one condition.

“We bring Dreko home too.”

Khaos extended his hand from the Haven side.

“Both sides of the walls.”

They shook.

• • •

The White Tide rebuilt the street economy faster than anyone could control it.

Tide seized three missing containers and turned the Gator Hole into a protected distribution point. With Cell’s old routes and Sebastián’s surviving port contacts, the Canal Boyz earned more in forty-eight hours than they had during their entire existence.

King K and Mon recovered loose cargo through smaller crews desperate for protection.

Money returned to Palm Haven.

So did bodies.

Corners that had remained quiet during federal occupation became battlegrounds. Robberies followed every sale. Hospitals treated overdoses from packages damaged by seawater and mixed by inexperienced sellers.

Cell watched his empire break into younger pieces.

He had supplied Tide.

Now Tide no longer answered.

He had built Reck.

Reck had rejected him.

He called Naz with an offer.

“I know where Saint took Reem.”

Naz placed the call on speaker.

Reck leaned toward the phone.

“Say it.”

“Private island south of the channel. Saint used it for meetings nobody could photograph.”

“What you want?”

“Protection from the Blue Table.”

Khaos laughed. “The man who created the Canal Boyz scared of his own business now.”

Cell ignored him.

“La Madrina wants me alive long enough to explain the Gulf Empress. El Almirante wants somebody to pay for his son.”

“Did you help Sebastián?” Reck asked.

Silence.

“Wrong answer,” Reck said.

“I gave him port access. I didn’t know he planned to open the ship.”

Naz wrote the admission down.

Cell continued.

“Saint’s island is called Pelican Key. Cameras, private dock, underground bunker. He’ll destroy whatever remains before federal teams reach it.”

“Send the location.”

“Protection first.”

Reck looked at Duke.

“You get one safe conversation with La Madrina. After that, whatever you did decides what happens.”

Cell knew it was the only offer coming.

The location appeared on Naz's screen.

...

Marcus Reed awakened with a tube in his chest and Holloway beside the bed.

His first question was not about Saint.

"Did the vote pass?"

"No."

Reed closed his eyes with relief.

Holloway showed him the Pelican Key coordinates.

"Recognize it?"

"My father took me there once when I was twelve."

"What's on it?"

"A house above. Bunker below. Private tunnel from the dock."

He struggled to sit higher.

"Danielle found records there before she died."

"Your mother?"

"She copied something Saint never recovered. If he still has Shanice Dawson, it's because he thinks Reem knows where Danielle hid it."

Holloway stared at him.

"Shanice is alive?"

Reed looked toward the door.

"My father sent me one message before the bank attack."

He handed her a photograph.

Shanice and Kobe sat inside a white room beneath a coastal painting.

“He told me to destroy the archive or they would disappear.”

Holloway called Reck.

For the first time, he knew why Reem entered Saint’s vehicle.

• • •

At Gulf Rock, Dreko started a rebellion without throwing the first punch.

He copied names.

Guards paid by Saint.

Inmates moved for King K.

Medical transfers used to hide witnesses.

Confiscated phone calls sold back to criminal organizations.

Reem’s network carried the list between units.

When a corrupt guard attempted to move Dreko into an isolated corridor, incarcerated Ridge and Haven members refused to return to their cells. Other inmates joined after learning the same guards had stolen family money and sold protection.

The prison locked down.

No doors opened.

No meals moved.

No transport left Gulf Rock without every camera recording.

Dreko called it standing together.

News stations called it an uprising.

Saint’s remaining allies ordered tactical teams inside.

Holloway released Administrator Graves’s recording before they could enter.

The public heard prison officials discussing Saint, Cell and King K.

State authorities suspended the assault.

Dreko remained incarcerated.

But he had survived long enough to turn one prison against Saint's system.

• • •

La Madrina met the Blue Table on the deck of the damaged Gulf Empress.

El Almirante looked older than he had the previous morning.

His son had betrayed him publicly.

His shipment filled enemy streets.

His organization had divided into factions beneath him.

Lucía placed Sebastián's communications on the table.

One message identified Pelican Key.

Another ordered Mar Azul soldiers loyal to him to kill La Madrina before she reached it.

El Almirante read both.

"Bring him back alive."

La Madrina looked toward the island beyond the horizon.

"If he resists?"

El Almirante's face revealed nothing.

"He already did."

Mateo objected. "We still have missing cargo throughout the city."

"Cargo can be replaced," Lucía said. "Authority cannot."

La Madrina regained temporary command of the Florida operation.

Her first order was not against Reck.

It was against Sebastián.

...

Reck returned to Sunridge before leaving for the island.

Residents surrounded Crown Harbor representatives attempting to post new seizure notices. Ms. Lena stood on the steps of The Sunshine holding her community-ownership certificate.

“We’re still here,” she told them.

The representatives left under federal escort.

Zay watched Reck study the neighborhood.

“You thinking about your father or your crown?”

“My family.”

“Good answer.”

“You don’t believe me?”

Zay adjusted his crutch.

“I believe you don’t know the difference anymore.”

Reck looked toward children playing beside the damaged car wash.

“If I get Shanice and Kobe back, Saint still got to answer.”

“He does. Just don’t sacrifice everybody trying to make the answer look like revenge.”

Reck handed Zay King K’s watch.

“Hold this.”

Zay frowned. “Why?”

“Because I’m going as Reem’s son. Not King K’s replacement.”

Zay accepted the watch.

Reck left wearing only the cracked crown.

...

Pelican Key appeared beyond the morning fog.

Reck and Khaos approached with Duke, Mari, Naz, TJ, T-Rell and a small group representing both crowns. La Madrina's faction traveled separately. Lucía accompanied the Blue Table team. Holloway and Reed's loyal agents waited beyond the island's private waters for evidence sufficient to enter.

Nobody trusted anybody completely.

Everybody wanted somebody different.

Reck wanted his family.

Khaos wanted the truth about Reem.

La Madrina wanted Sebastián.

Lucía wanted Container 317's missing master drive.

Holloway wanted Saint alive.

Duke wanted the transfer orders connecting Saint to Gulf Rock.

The first explosion destroyed the island dock behind them.

Sebastián's soldiers opened fire from the tree line.

The group scattered through tropical gardens surrounding Saint's white mansion. Windows shattered above them. Security vehicles crossed the courtyard while alarms sealed the underground bunker.

Mari and Duke moved toward the generator house.

Naz and TJ followed the surveillance lines.

Khaos remained beside Reck.

"Two crowns."

"Family beside family."

They entered the mansion together.

...

Shanice heard the shooting from below the house.

Kobe sat beside her inside the bunker room, frightened but unharmed. Saint had kept them alive because Reem refused to disclose the location of Danielle Reed's missing account book.

Reem stood on the opposite side of the locked glass.

His prison uniform was gone. He wore black clothing supplied by Saint and a tracking cuff around his ankle.

Saint entered holding the master drive from Container 317.

Sebastián followed.

"Your son is on the island," Saint said.

Reem looked toward the ceiling as another explosion shook dust loose.

"Then you already lost it."

"He opened my bank because you made him believe the city was his inheritance."

"You opened your bank because you thought everybody had a price."

Saint placed the drive on a steel table.

"Where did Danielle hide the original ledger?"

"Ask your son."

"Marcus was a child."

"Children see what powerful men ignore."

Sebastián raised his weapon toward Shanice.

Reem moved instantly.

The tracking cuff shocked him before he reached the glass.

He fell to one knee.

Saint watched without sympathy.

"Tell me, or Reck watches his family disappear because his father chose secrets again."

Reem lifted his head.



“I got in your car to save them.”

Saint leaned closer.

“You got in because part of you still believes we can finish what we started.”

Reem said nothing.

The silence frightened Shanice more than Saint’s threat.

• • •

Reck reached the bunker corridor through the mansion’s collapsed kitchen.

Khaos covered the rear while Duke forced the first security door. La Madrina entered from the opposite side with Lucía.

Sebastián appeared above the lower stairwell.

“A street crew and a cartel fighting over a politician’s basement,” he said. “This is what my father was trying to prevent.”

La Madrina looked at him.

“Your father was trying to prevent you from becoming exactly this.”

Sebastián fired and disappeared behind the blast door.

Lucía followed him.

Reck continued downward.

He found the white room first.

Shanice struck the glass when she saw him.

“Kareem!”

Kobe ran toward the door.

Reck crossed the room and opened it with Saint’s security card recovered upstairs. His mother held him with both arms while Kobe pressed against his side.

For several seconds, the war disappeared.

Then Reck looked through the second glass wall.

Reem stood inside the control room.

Father and son saw each other face-to-face for the first time in years.

Reck entered slowly.

Reem looked older than the prison calls had shown.

“You came.”

“You left with Saint.”

“He had your mother and brother.”

“You could’ve told me.”

“He monitored every call.”

“You manipulated every call before he took them.”

Reem lowered his eyes.

“That part is true.”

Khaos entered behind Reck.

“Did you build the war with Saint?”

Reem looked at D-Low’s pendant around his nephew’s neck.

“We built the system together. Then Saint turned it against everybody.”

Reck stepped closer.

“Did you use me to take it back?”

Reem did not answer quickly enough.

Reck felt the truth before hearing it.

“I gave you the chance to become strong enough that nobody could erase our family again,” Reem said.

“That ain’t what I asked.”

“Yes. I used your war to weaken Saint, King K and Cell.”

Khaos’s expression hardened.

Reem continued.

“But I never ordered D-Low’s death. I never ordered Amaya taken. I never wanted Zay shot.”

“You just built the road everybody used to reach us.”

The words struck Reem silent.

An alarm announced Saint’s escape tunnel opening beneath the bunker.

Reck looked toward it.

Then back at his father.

Reem removed the tracking cuff with the released control key and placed it on the table.

“We can argue when your family is off this island.”

Reck stared at him.

“You coming with us?”

Reem looked toward the tunnel where Saint had disappeared.

“I came here to finish him.”

Reck stepped between his father and the exit.

“You came here to save them.”

Shanice stood in the doorway holding Kobe.

“For once,” Reck said, “choose the family before the empire.”

Reem looked at his wife.

Then his youngest son.

Then the child he had turned into revenge.

The island shook as fire reached the generator room.

Reem made his choice.

He walked toward his family.

Behind them, Gabriel Saint escaped into the final tunnel carrying Container 317's master drive.

# BLOOD BEFORE EMPIRE

Federal boats surrounded Pelican Key before Reck reached the beach.

Red and blue lights covered the water. Helicopters circled above Saint's burning mansion while loudspeakers ordered everyone on the island to surrender.

Reck stood between his family and the shoreline.

Reem looked toward the jungle path leading to the eastern cove.

"There's another boat."

Shanice stared at him. "No more running."

"Federal agents think I helped Saint rob a bank and escape prison."

"Did you?"

The question stopped him.

Reck watched his parents face each other beneath smoke from a criminal empire they had both hidden from their children.

Reem answered carefully.

"I escaped because Saint's people controlled the transfer. I entered his vehicle because he had you and Kobe."

"That wasn't all I asked."

Reem looked away.

Marcus Reed's loyal agents landed at the ruined dock with Detective Holloway. Reed himself remained hospitalized, but his order placed Shanice and Kobe under federal-witness protection.

Holloway approached with her weapon lowered.

“Reem, I need your hands where I can see them.”

Reck stepped forward.

“He tells you where Saint went first.”

“That isn’t how surrender works.”

“He ain’t surrendering until my family leaves this island.”

Holloway looked toward Shanice.

Shanice took Kobe’s hand.

“We’re leaving. Then Kareem answers for Kareem.”

Reem heard the finality in her voice.

He raised his hands.

“Saint’s tunnel exits beneath a boathouse on the north reef. He’ll transfer to a private aircraft beyond federal water.”

Holloway relayed the location.

Agents rushed toward the north side.

Too late.

An aircraft lifted beyond the horizon before they reached the boathouse.

Saint still had the master drive.

Reem allowed Holloway to place the handcuffs around his wrists.

Reck looked at him.

“You choosing prison again?”

“I’m choosing not to make you fight federal agents for my mistakes.”

It was the first decision Reem made without turning his son into the weapon.

...

Sunridge came under attack while Reck was trapped on the island.

King K and Mon knew the founding leader was gone. They also knew federal pressure had thinned Ridge protection around The Sunshine.

Three vehicles entered Garden Courts before sunrise.

Mon's people struck the community office holding Crown Harbor deeds. King K's remaining crew hit the trucking-payment location. A third group attempted to burn the temporary housing ledger so residents could not prove community ownership.

Duke received the warning first.

He stood inside The Sunshine wearing the captain's cracked crown and the same clothes he escaped the swamp in.

"Founders out," Mari said. "Reck unreachable."

Duke looked toward the residents gathering in the courtyard.

"Then I lead."

He divided the response without pretending to be Reck.

Mari protected the deed office.

TJ secured the digital records.

Naz moved families away from the attack.

Duke held the center with Ridge soldiers and trusted residents who refused to surrender their property.

Zay arrived on crutches.

"You ain't fighting," Duke told him.

"I'm organizing people."

"Same thing today."

Zay stood in front of the community office with Ms. Lena and dozens of property owners. Phones streamed every moment.

When King K's group attempted to claim the building as abandoned, residents held up their ownership certificates.

"This ain't gang property," Ms. Lena shouted. "This belongs to us."

Mon's shooters opened fire from the far end of the block.

Duke moved residents behind concrete walls before Ridge members answered. The street became chaos, but the documents remained protected.

Mari chased Mon's group away from the office.

Naz caught one attacker attempting to burn the paper ledger.

TJ saved every digital copy before the power failed.

Duke reached the center courtyard as King K's final vehicle withdrew.

He could have pursued it.

Instead, he stayed with the neighborhood.

When Reck called from Pelican Key, Duke answered with smoke behind him.

"The Ridge still ours."

Reck looked at his new captain through the screen.

"Anybody hurt?"

"Some wounded. Everybody alive."

"King?"

"Ran."

"Why you ain't chase?"

Duke looked toward Zay.

"Crown protects what's behind it before it chases what's in front."

Reck understood he had chosen the right captain.

...

Rambo awakened that afternoon.

Khaos sat beside the bed wearing D-Low's pendant and Baby Ant's recovered chain wrapped around one hand.



Rambo tried moving his injured arm.

Nothing happened.

His face changed.

“Doctor says nerves damaged,” Khaos told him. “They don’t know how much coming back.”

Rambo stared at the ceiling.

“I can’t be your enforcer with one arm.”

“You pushed me out that shot.”

“That ain’t a position.”

Khaos leaned closer.

“You think Haven only needs people who can shoot and fight? That thinking got half our members dead or locked.”

Rambo looked at him.

“Then what I am?”

“Alive. Loyal. And still one of mine.”

Khaos placed Baby Ant’s pendant on the bedside table.

“When you heal, you train the young ones to survive without becoming Deuce.”

For the first time since waking, Rambo’s expression softened.

“You really changed in jail.”

“Nah.” Khaos sat back. “I changed after I got out.”

• • •

Kilo and Deuce were captured on different sides of Palm Haven.

Kilo remained in federal protection after his false statement collapsed.

Deuce was found hiding inside a White Tide stash location abandoned by Tide. T-Rell brought him to the burned foundation of D-Low's garage.

Khaos stood with the surviving Haven Boyz.

Reck attended after returning from Pelican Key.

Deuce's confidence disappeared when he saw Baby Ant's chain beside D-Low's pendant.

"Tide made me do it," he said.

Khaos looked at him. "Tide made you wear our dead friend's jewelry?"

"I was surviving."

"T-Rell survived without switching. Rambo survived getting shot for me. Lil Smoke survived the Gator Hole without talking."

Khaos stepped closer.

"You kept using survival to explain every choice that paid you."

The Haven Boyz wanted revenge.

Khaos wanted it too.

But D-Low's final recording had warned him not to inherit his father's mistakes.

He looked toward Reck.

"Both crowns decide betrayal."

Reck answered. "Truth first."

Deuce was forced to disclose every Canal location, White Tide storage site and payment he received from Sebastián's network. The information was recorded and copied.

Afterward, Khaos removed every Haven symbol from him.

"You never wear our dead again. You never enter Paradise Haven. You spend the rest of your life knowing you traded family for people who abandoned you."

Deuce looked surprised.

“That’s it?”

Khaos’s eyes hardened.

“Living without the name you sold is the first consequence. What law does with everything you confessed comes next.”

Reck saw D-Low’s son choose something harder than rage.

He chose to become different.

...

At Gulf Rock, Dreko’s evidence forced the state to remove six guards and suspend the warden.

The prison remained locked down, but outside investigators entered with cameras Saint’s people could not disable.

Dreko sat across from a state inspector.

“You expect protection for talking?” she asked.

“I expect the same rules for guards as inmates.”

“That isn’t how prison works.”

“That’s why your prison almost exploded.”

He provided dates, transfers and payment names without describing Ridge or Haven operations.

He exposed corruption without surrendering his people.

The distinction mattered to him.

It also gave Holloway the first legal path to challenge Duke’s sabotaged transfer.

...

La Madrina and Lucía found Sebastián at a private airfield north of Palm Haven.

Saint's aircraft had dropped him there before continuing west.

Sebastián stood beside two Mar Azul pilots and a case containing duplicate access codes from Container 317.

El Almirante joined through a secure video call.

His son faced him across the screen.

"Saint escaped because you trusted an outsider over blood," El Almirante said.

Sebastián looked toward La Madrina. "You trusted her over me first."

"She earned authority."

"I was born to it."

Lucía closed the hangar doors.

"That is the difference."

Sebastián tried bargaining with the network names contained in the master drive. La Madrina refused.

"You opened our ship, flooded a city and delivered our records to Saint. Information does not erase betrayal."

El Almirante removed his son from Mar Azul permanently and ordered Lucía to take him into cartel custody.

Before the feed ended, Sebastián gave La Madrina one final warning.

"Saint isn't running to hide. He is meeting the man who financed everything."

"Who?"

Sebastián smiled.

"Ask Shanice Dawson."

...

Shanice refused federal protection until she spoke to her children.

She gathered Reck, Amaya and Kobe inside the same Sunridge apartment where the family had once worried about grocery money while Reem controlled fortunes from prison.

Reem attended through a secured interview-room screen, wrists still cuffed.

Shanice placed an old accounting ledger on the table.

Marcus Reed joined from his hospital room.

He recognized the handwriting.

“My mother.”

Shanice nodded.

“Danielle gave it to me three days before she died.”

Reck stared at his mother.

“You knew all this time?”

“I knew Saint’s money touched the port, police and your father’s businesses. I didn’t know how far it reached until years later.”

“Why didn’t you tell me?”

“Because I was trying to give you a life where none of it mattered.”

Reem looked through the screen.

“You told me the ledger was destroyed.”

“Because you would’ve used it for revenge.”

Shanice opened another folder.

Inside were business registrations, insurance policies and original property certificates.

“While your father built prison alliances, I kept the legitimate companies alive. The trucking operation. The Sunshine land. Three Garden Courts buildings. I moved them into trusts for you, Amaya and Kobe before Saint could find them.”

Reck felt another version of his childhood rearrange itself.

“You controlled the businesses?”

“I protected them.”

“You shaped this too.”

Shanice met his anger without looking away.

“Your father wanted you powerful enough to inherit his empire. I wanted you protected enough to refuse it.”

Reem lowered his head.

Shanice turned Danielle’s ledger toward Marcus Reed.

The earliest payments did not begin with Saint.

They came from **Meridian Coastal Holdings**, a national development company controlling ports, banks and luxury waterfront projects throughout Florida.

Its founder appeared on magazine covers, charity boards and political donor lists.

**Augustus “Gus” Bellamy.**

Bellamy was seventy-three, worth billions and publicly celebrated for rebuilding struggling coastal cities.

Danielle’s ledger showed something else.

Bellamy financed Saint’s first election.

He funded Reem’s original port organization through intermediaries.

He introduced Mar Azul money into First Palm National.

He profited every time street violence lowered property prices.

Palm Haven was one project inside a national machine.

Marcus Reed read the final page.

“Grand jury convenes in six days.”

Naz looked at him. “Bellamy knows?”

“If Saint has the master drive, yes.”

Shanice closed the ledger.

“Then he won’t spend six days running.”

“What will he do?” Reck asked.

Reem answered through the screen.

“Erase everybody who can connect him to Palm Haven.”

• • •

Tide declared himself Palm Haven’s new supplier that night.

He stood at the Gator Hole surrounded by White Tide cargo and the Canal Boyz who chose him over Cell.

“Cell built routes,” Tide said. “I own what moves through them now.”

King K and Mon joined him through a private call.

The old enemies reached a new agreement.

Tide supplied.

King distributed.

Mon enforced.

Their first objective was not Reck.

It was Duke.

The escaped captain carried proof capable of destroying Saint’s jail network and King K’s protection.

If Duke died, they could blame Bellamy’s cleanup operation.

Nobody would know which war killed him.

• • •

Reck returned to The Sunshine after midnight.

The founding five, Duke, Khaos and the Haven leadership waited beneath the damaged roof.

He placed Danielle's ledger beside the cracked crown and burning halo.

"Everybody keeps telling us what we inherited," Reck said. "My father left me a war. My mother left me a way out. D-Low left Khaos the truth. Saint left the whole city bleeding."

He looked at every face.

"Now we choose what survives. We can inherit their mistakes, or we can build something they never controlled."

Khaos touched his father's pendant.

"Bellamy first?"

Naz shook his head.

"Bellamy got billions, national connections and six days to erase evidence. He won't come at us like King K."

Zay leaned on his crutches.

"Then we don't fight him like King K."

Reck looked toward downtown Palm Haven.

The street war remained active.

Tide controlled the White Tide.

King K and Mon were rebuilding.

Saint held the master drive.

Bellamy controlled the money above them all.

And a federal grand jury waited six days away.

Reck placed King K's watch permanently inside the archive case.

He no longer needed to wear another man's proof of power.

"We protect Duke. We get Dreko home. We keep the neighborhoods owned by the people."

He closed the case.



“Then we take down the man who been buying every war.”

# THE MAN WHO BOUGHT THE WAR

Augustus Bellamy watched Palm Haven burn from a room that did not officially belong to him.

The private suite occupied the top floor of Meridian Coastal Holdings' newest waterfront tower, thirty-seven stories above a city his company claimed it was saving. Magazine covers framed the hallway outside. Bellamy breaking ground on a children's hospital. Bellamy standing beside governors. Bellamy smiling beneath the words \*A Better Coast for Everyone\*.

None of the photographs showed Sunridge Gardens.

None showed the Gator Hole, Gulf Rock or the families displaced whenever a block became cheap enough for Meridian to purchase.

Gabriel Saint stood before the windows holding Container 317's master drive.

Smoke from Pelican Key still stained his jacket.

Bellamy did not offer him a chair.

"You lost the island," Bellamy said.

"The island was expendable."

"You lost the bank."

"The money moved."

"You lost the port records, your police protection and Reem Dawson."

Saint placed the drive on the glass table between them.

"I brought you the only record that can destroy everyone."

Bellamy looked at it without reaching.

“Including me?”

Saint smiled carefully. “Especially you.”

For twenty years, Gabriel Saint had frightened politicians, officers and street leaders by knowing what they wanted hidden. Bellamy did not look frightened.

He looked disappointed.

“You confused possession with power,” Bellamy said. “Power is deciding whether the thing you possess continues to matter.”

He pressed one button on the table.

Across Palm Haven, Meridian attorneys filed emergency motions challenging every Crown Harbor property transfer. Insurance companies froze payments connected to The Sunshine. A state banking examiner opened reviews of every business Shanice Dawson had placed in trust. News stations received documents describing Reck and Khaos as leaders of a criminal land-seizure conspiracy.

Saint watched notifications reach his phone.

Bellamy had begun the war without raising his voice.

“The grand jury meets in six days,” Saint said.

“It will not meet with the witnesses it expects.”

“You plan to kill all of them?”

Bellamy finally looked at him.

“That is why you were always temporary, Gabriel. Dead witnesses create investigations. Discredited witnesses create silence.”

He slid a folder across the table.

Inside were photographs of Duke, Danielle Reed’s ledger, Shanice, Marcus Reed, Detective Holloway, La Madrina and the surviving founders.

Each photograph carried a different instruction.

**ARREST. DISBAR. TRANSFER. FREEZE. EXPOSE. DIVIDE.**

Duke's photograph carried one word.

**RETURN.**

Saint understood.

"You want him sent back to Gulf Rock."

"I want the city to watch the law place its own witness in a cage."

Bellamy turned toward the skyline.

"Then I want Palm Haven to beg Meridian to restore order."

• • •

The first notice reached The Sunshine at 8:03 the next morning.

Shanice read it twice before placing it beside Danielle's ledger.

**TEMPORARY ASSET CONTROL ORDER.**

The state had frozen the Dawson family trusts pending an organized-crime investigation. Payroll for the trucking company stopped. Repair funds for Garden Courts stopped. The account paying temporary housing after the cargo disaster stopped.

Reck stood at the head of the conference table.

"Saint did this."

"Bellamy," Naz corrected. "Saint attacks people. Bellamy attacks the ground under them."

TJ turned his laptop toward the room. Every local station carried the same headline.

**STREET ORGANIZATIONS USED CHARITY FUNDS TO PURCHASE PALM HAVEN PROPERTY, SOURCES CLAIM.**

The reports showed footage of candy cars, iced-out pendants and the Ridge-Haven celebration outside The Sunshine. They did not show the ownership certificates held by residents. They did not show the ledgers TJ saved during King K's attack.

They showed exactly what Bellamy needed strangers to believe.

Khaos entered with T-Rell and Lil Smoke.

“Paradise accounts froze too.”

“Suppliers?” Reck asked.

“Backing away.”

Mari hit the table. “Then we make them remember who kept them paid.”

Zay leaned on his crutches near the window.

“That is what Bellamy wants. One threat, one fight, one video he can call proof.”

Mari looked at him. “So we just watch him take everything?”

“No,” Naz said. “We make him fight in daylight.”

Duke remained near the rear door, wearing the cracked captain’s crown. He had barely slept since Pelican Key. Every siren made his body tighten. Every unknown car looked like Gulf Rock returning for him.

TJ’s screen changed.

An arrest warrant appeared beneath Duke’s photograph.

**ESCAPED STATE PRISONER. ARMED AND DANGEROUS.**

The room became silent.

Duke looked at the words \*armed and dangerous\*.

“They forgot government witness.”

Detective Holloway called seconds later.

“State tactical officers are moving toward Sunridge,” she said. “The warrant came from Judge Ward’s emergency court.”

Reck looked toward Duke.

“How long?”

“Ten minutes.”

Mari reached for his keys.

Zay blocked the doorway with one crutch.

“Nobody runs.”

“They taking Duke,” Mari said.

“They taking the neighborhood if we give Bellamy the scene he ordered.”

Duke removed the cracked crown from his neck and placed it on the table.

“I’ll turn myself in.”

Reck shook his head. “You go back in that prison, Boone’s people finish the job.”

“If y’all fight the police over me, Bellamy finishes everybody.”

Khaos looked at the warrant. “There another way?”

Naz was already thinking.

“A surrender they cannot hide.”

• • •

By the time tactical vehicles reached Sunridge, three hundred residents stood outside The Sunshine holding ownership certificates above their heads.

TJ streamed from twelve angles.

Naomi Price arrived with two independent reporters. Bianca Flores carried duplicate property records rescued from the port authority. Special Prosecutor Camille Hart stood beside Detective Holloway with a federal witness order in her hand.

Duke walked into the courtyard alone.

No weapon.

No crown.

His hands remained visible.

The state commander raised a loudspeaker.

“Get on the ground.”

Duke stopped beside Ms. Lena.

“I’m surrendering to Special Prosecutor Hart under federal protection.”

“You are a state fugitive.”

Hart lifted the witness order. “And a material witness in a federal corruption case. Any transfer must be recorded and approved.”

The commander ignored her.

Officers moved forward.

Phones rose across the courtyard.

Zay stood with the residents, one hand resting on a crutch and the other holding his ownership certificate.

“Everybody stay still,” he said.

Reck watched from The Sunshine doorway. Every instinct told him to move between Duke and the officers. Zay caught his eye.

Protect what is behind you.

Reck stayed beside his mother and the neighborhood records.

The first officer reached Duke.

Then Rochelle Kane stepped from an Internal Affairs vehicle.

The deputy chief carried a sealed suspension order for the commander and body-camera audit findings tying his unit to Officer Briggs, Warden Boone and Saint’s contaminated warrants.

“Stand down,” Kane ordered.

The commander looked at the cameras.

For the first time, Bellamy’s plan had too many witnesses.

He lowered the warrant.

Duke entered federal custody instead of a state transport van.

The neighborhood did not celebrate.

They understood it was only one move.

But it was a move Bellamy had failed to purchase.

...

King K watched the surrender from a private room above the Gator Hole.

Mon stood beside him. Tide occupied Cell's old chair beneath a teal light.

"They made Duke look like a hero," Mon said.

King K turned off the screen.

"Heroes bleed like everybody else."

Tide placed a White Tide route map across the table. "Bellamy wants Sunridge isolated. We stop every package moving through Ridge or Haven streets. Merchants pay us or they get nothing."

"Bellamy don't care who controls street packages," King K said.

"He cares who makes the neighborhood desperate."

Mon studied him. "And when he buys the land?"

Tide smiled. "We get paid to clear it."

King K saw the trap before Mon did.

Bellamy was offering them Palm Haven the same way Saint once offered it to him: as long as they remained useful.

Afterward, their names would become evidence. Their wars would justify bulldozers. Their people would disappear beneath glass towers carrying Meridian's logo.

King K had spent years believing he owned The Ridge.



Now he understood somebody had been renting it to him.

“We need the master drive,” he said.

Tide’s eyes narrowed. “Saint got it.”

“Then we find Saint before Bellamy decides none of us matter.”

• • •

Marcus Reed left the hospital against medical advice.

He met Shanice, Holloway and Naomi Price inside an old church records room beneath Pastor Brooks’s sanctuary. Deacon Keys Wallace locked the exterior doors. Raymond Knox swept the building for surveillance before placing a small black device on the table.

“Bellamy’s people watched the hospital, federal office and Danielle’s old house,” Knox said. “They didn’t watch the church.”

“They will now,” Holloway answered.

Shanice opened Danielle’s ledger.

Bianca’s rescued port records covered the table beside it. Solomon Pierce’s banking discrepancies connected Meridian shell companies to First Palm National. Talia Grant had delivered copies of her father’s private calendars. Jasmine Cole’s recording captured the order to shut down the port during the cargo crisis.

For the first time, the Palm Haven Network was not a theory.

It was a structure.

Commissioner Grant controlled police access.

Judge Ward protected emergency warrants.

Warden Boone controlled prisoners and transfers.

Malcolm Voss buried charges.

Councilman Bishop moved property through zoning votes.

Mayor Cross gave redevelopment legitimacy.

Gabriel Saint connected the streets, port and political money.

Augustus Bellamy financed the machine above them all.

Marcus studied the evidence.

“This can reach the grand jury.”

Naomi shook her head. “Not if Bellamy owns the story first.”

“You want to publish?”

“I want the public to understand the pattern before he calls every witness a criminal.”

Shanice closed the ledger.

“Then we do both. Court gets the proof. The city gets the truth.”

Holloway looked at her. “Once this goes public, Bellamy stops trying to discredit you.”

“And starts what?”

Marcus answered.

“Erasing the evidence.”

A noise sounded above them.

One footstep.

Then another.

The church lights died.

...

Reck received Shanice’s emergency message while standing inside Garden Courts.

### **CHURCH. BRING NO PARADE.**

He left with Naz and Khaos in an ordinary work truck borrowed from the housing repair crew. No candy paint. No convoy. No jewelry visible through the windows.

For the first time, Reck entered a fight without announcing himself to the city.

They found the church dark.

The front doors were chained from the inside.

Reck heard glass break near the records wing.

Khaos moved toward it.

Naz stopped both of them.

“Fire exit.”

Smoke had begun filling the basement hallway. Bellamy’s cleanup team had not come for people first. They had come for the documents.

Inside the records room, Marcus and Holloway pushed filing cabinets against the door while Shanice and Naomi packed evidence into archive cases. Pastor Brooks guided them toward an old baptism corridor connecting the sanctuary to the community kitchen.

The attackers entered above.

They wore no street colors.

They shouted no names.

They moved with the silence of people who expected official reports to protect them afterward.

Reck reached the kitchen entrance as Shanice emerged carrying Danielle’s ledger.

“Where’s Marcus?” he asked.

“Getting Holloway.”

Khaos took one archive case. Naz took another.

Reck started back toward the smoke.

His mother grabbed his arm.

“The evidence survives first.”

“They still inside.”

“And they made their choice.”

Reck looked at the ledger in her hands.

All his life, power had meant being the first person into danger and the last person to leave. Bellamy’s kind of power was different. It made other people enter danger while he watched from glass towers.

Reck refused both definitions.

“Naz, take my mother and the cases.”

He looked at Khaos.

“We bring everybody.”

They returned through the corridor.

Marcus had fallen beneath a collapsed shelf. Holloway tried lifting it while flames moved across the ceiling. Reck and Khaos raised the metal together. Pastor Brooks opened the baptism door from the opposite side.

They escaped seconds before the records-room windows shattered outward.

Across the street, a black sedan pulled away.

TJ captured its plate from a traffic camera three blocks north.

The registration belonged to Meridian Coastal Security.

Bellamy had made his first visible mistake.

• • •

At sunrise, Naomi Price published the first installment of **The Palm Haven Files**.

She did not call Reck a hero.

She did not excuse Ridge or Haven crimes.

She showed how Bellamy’s companies profited from violence, corrupted institutions and purchased land after every crisis. She published Danielle Reed’s payment dates beside Councilman Bishop’s

zoning votes. She connected Warden Boone's transfers to Voss's dismissed cases and Saint's redevelopment contracts.

Every claim linked to a record stored in five different locations.

The article reached one million views before breakfast.

Meridian called it fabricated.

Mayor Cross called it dangerous misinformation.

Commissioner Grant ordered an investigation into the leak.

Governor Crowe announced a state task force chaired by three Bellamy donors.

Then Talia Grant released her father's calendars.

Jasmine Cole released the port recording.

Rochelle Kane released the contaminated body-camera audit.

The story became too large for one office to bury.

Outside The Sunshine, residents gathered around phones and read the names of people who had treated their neighborhood like inventory.

Reck stood beneath the damaged roof with the founding five, Khaos and Duke appearing through a secure federal screen.

"Bellamy wanted six days," Naz said. "Now the whole country watching the clock."

TJ displayed a map of Meridian properties across Florida.

Palm Haven was not alone.

The same pattern appeared in five coastal cities: violence, emergency declarations, property collapse, Meridian purchase, luxury redevelopment.

Khaos looked at Reck. "So what now?"

Reck placed the cracked crown and burning halo beside Danielle's ledger.

"We stop defending only our block."

Mari smiled. "That sound expensive."

"It is."

Reck looked toward downtown, where Meridian's tower reflected the morning sun.

"That's why Bellamy thought nobody from here could afford to fight him."

His phone rang.

Unknown number.

He answered.

Gabriel Saint's voice came through.

"Bellamy knows I kept a second copy of the master drive."

Reck said nothing.

"He will kill me before the grand jury," Saint continued. "You need what I have. I need a way out."

"After everything you did, you calling me for protection?"

"I am calling because Bellamy made the same mistake King K made."

Reck looked at the people surrounding him.

"Which one?"

Saint lowered his voice.

"He thinks the crown belongs to the man standing above everybody."

The line went silent for a moment.

"Meet me where Palm Haven first learned to disappear."

The call ended.

TJ searched the signal. Nothing.

Naz studied the final sentence.

Khaos knew the answer first.

“The old citrus tunnels.”

Reck lifted the burning halo.

Bellamy had money, courts, police, prisons and governors.

Saint had the master drive.

King K, Mon and Tide were hunting both sides.

The grand jury was five days away.

Reck fastened the halo around Khaos’s neck and placed the cracked crown around his own.

“Then we go find the man who sold us the war.”